

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Case Study Method and Answer Architecture - Complete Topic Package

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Case Study Method and Answer Architecture

TEN-SESSION CORE PATH • PRACTICE • OPTIONAL ADVANCED • REGISTER NOTES

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| 1 Eight-element architecture: from verified facts to residual risk | 2 Six ethical checks: hard thresholds before weighted balancing |
| 3 Nested dilemmas, steeldancing and the residual-risk close | 4 Improper pressure, ethical dissent, whistleblowing and resignation |
| 5 Triage, scarce resources and competency-based case practice | 6 Worked mechanism: DC Vijay and integrated decision architecture |
| 7 Domain adaptation across public, corporate and professional cases | 8 Prelims facts, examiner traps and representative PYQ routing |
| 9 Mains analysis, probable demands and time-bound answer design | 10 Study links, recent cases, historical cases and final synthesis |

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / SESSION INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Case Study Method and Answer Architecture - Complete Topic Package	4
CURRENT-AFFAIRS ANCHOR	4
BASIC LEARNING SESSION	5
SESSION 1 - Eight-element architecture: from verified facts to residual risk	5
SESSION 2 - Six ethical checks: hard thresholds before weighted balancing	7
SESSION 3 - Nested dilemmas, steelmanning and the residual-risk close	8
SESSION 4 - Improper pressure, ethical dissent, whistleblowing and resignation	9
SESSION 5 - Triage, scarce resources and competency-based case practice	10
SESSION 6 - Worked mechanism: DC Vijay and integrated decision architecture	11
SESSION 7 - Domain adaptation across public, corporate and professional cases	12
SESSION 8 - Prelims facts, examiner traps and representative PYQ routing	24
SESSION 9 - Mains analysis, probable demands and time-bound answer design	25
SESSION 10 - Study links, recent cases, historical cases and final synthesis	26
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	38
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	62
ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS	70
OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER	73
1. Architecture	73
2. Concepts and distinctions	73
3. Detailed treatment	74
4. Institutional and reform architecture	75
5. Indian applications and boundary cases	75
6. Limitations and trade-offs	76
7. Must-Know Facts for Advanced Prelims	76
8. Advanced Prelims traps	76
9. Current application	76
10. PYQ-based analytical application	76
11. Mains-ready framework	77

12. Probable questions	77
13. Study links	77
Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)	77
CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES	86
EMBEDDED TWELVE-PANEL ASCII REVISION ATLAS	86
ONE-PAGE CONCEPT GRID	93
CORE REVISION SPINE	94
SOURCE AND ATTRIBUTION DISCIPLINE	94
ANSWER SPINE	95

Case Study Method and Answer Architecture - Complete Topic Package

Subject: Ethics **Section:** Subject-wide Syllabus **Generation:** learner-v2:g1 **Ownership:** GS-IV Ethics topic; recent official-paper questions retain their exact year, paper and source note. **Source policy:** complete Basic owner first; solved practice before optional Advanced depth; consolidated register notes last.

CURRENT-AFFAIRS ANCHOR

Current official anchor: Amrit Gyaan Kosh and case-based governance learning

- **FACT:** Fact: The Capacity Building Commission describes Amrit Gyaan Kosh as a repository that captures and curates governance best practices as India-centric case studies for officials across Union, State, municipal and panchayat levels.
- **FACT:** Fact: The official Commission page states that each case study has precise learning objectives intended to improve problem-solving and evidence-based decision-making under Mission Karmayogi.
- **FACT:** Fact: The Commission's launch note says the portal provides access to case studies and supporting materials on iGOT and seeks to institutionalise experiential, case-based learning in governance.

ANALYSIS: Inference / administrative link: The official initiative supports the central teaching claim of Topic 22: structured cases build judgment by requiring officials to identify facts, constraints and stakeholders, compare feasible actions, justify a decision and learn from implementation. It is a training linkage, not evidence that the eight-element UPSC answer architecture is an officially mandated government template.

ANALYSIS: Limit: The official pages establish the repository's purpose and case-based pedagogy. They do not state that every iGOT course uses one uniform simulation design, nor do they endorse a single UPSC model answer. Specific course or case claims should be verified on the platform before citation.

Official source links:

- <https://cbc.gov.in/amrit-gyaan-kosh>
- <https://cbc.gov.in/index.php/mos-dr-jitendra-singh-inaugurated-advanced-case-writing-and-teaching-workshop-and-launched-amrit>

Source caution: Topic 22 owns the complete method for GS-IV case studies: facts, stakeholders, constraints, realistic options, ethical evaluation, decision, implementation and communication, and residual-risk mitigation. The six-check framework is a synthesis heuristic, not an official UPSC algorithm or a promise of one uniquely correct answer. Legality is normally a hard threshold; conflict of interest is near-disqualifying and ordinarily triggers written disclosure, recusal, referral to an untainted authority and objective criteria. Public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion are weighted considerations whose relative importance must be explained. Moral theories supplement rather than replace the six checks. Nested dilemmas should be separated only when analytically genuine. A steelman is the strongest credible objection, not a ceremonial weak counterpoint. Residual risk means the specific danger remaining after controls, with a named monitor and review mechanism; its formula is a reasoning aid, not literal arithmetic. Improper oral directions should be converted into a written record with the officer's professional objection and lawful escalation. Ethical dissent usually moves through internal, independent internal, authorised external and last-resort public channels; a compromised recipient may be skipped. Public disclosure can carry confidentiality, safety and legal risks. Resignation is an evaluated last resort after resistance and escalation, not an automatic symbol of integrity. Triage requires relevant published criteria, an explicit welfare-equity trade-off, records, review and adaptation. The architecture transfers across domains, but each answer must identify the governing legal authority, technical standard and competent institution; Topic 22 does not replace the detailed law in Topics 14-21 or named-case evidence in Topic 23. Official local UPSC papers control question wording. PYQ entries marked neutral routing deliberately condense scenarios because some scans have imperfect OCR; they must not be presented as verbatim quotations. The canonical Basic treatment controls the 2018-2025 routing and worked method, while the Advanced treatment adds weighting, stress testing and residual-risk refinement. The Capacity Building Commission pages support a current case-based-learning anchor but do not make this exact answer framework an official Mission Karmayogi requirement.

SESSION 1 - Eight-element architecture: from verified facts to residual risk

Subject: Ethics | **Tier:** Must-Do (foundation) | **GS Paper:** GS-IV (Section B, Case Studies). **Core area:** A complete, self-sufficient, eight-element architecture for analysing and answering GS-IV case studies across every major case family - facts, stakeholders, constraints, options, ethical evaluation, decision, implementation/communication, residual-risk mitigation - plus the operational mechanics (hard-threshold vs weighted checks, the disclose-recuse-refer-publish conflict-of-interest sequence, nested-dilemma decomposition, steelmanning, the residual-risk closing formula, written-order response to oral pressure, the whistleblowing/dissent ladder, resignation as a last resort, and triage) needed to write a complete Section-B answer without reference to any other file.

Grounded in: Official UPSC GS-IV Section-B case-study format; audited GS-IV PYQs (2024-2025 Mains case studies - DC Vijay disaster-management case, tech-company AI/environment case, Rajesh GFR-splitting case, Ashok cross-border-influx case, Subash conflict-of-interest case); moral theories from 08; ARC-derived concepts (01, 09, 14, 18, 19, 21); Vishaka & Ors v. State of Rajasthan (1997) 6 SCC 241; the Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace Act, 2013; ICMR National Ethical Guidelines for Biomedical and Health Research Involving Human Participants, 2017; GFR 2017 Rule 157; NHRC v. State of Arunachal Pradesh (1996) 1 SCC 742; Mohammad Salimullah v. Union of India (2021); D.K. Basu v. State of West Bengal, (1997) 1 SCC 416; Justice K.S. Puttaswamy (Retd.) v. Union of India, (2017) 10 SCC 1; the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023. **FACT:** = PYQ/source-grounded | **ANALYSIS:** = analytical inference | **CURRENT:** = current anchor. *Companion:* advanced/22_Case-Study-Method-and-Answer-Architecture.md (deeper theoretical refinement of the same mechanics); this file is the self-sufficient Basic version.

1. Visual foundation - the eight-element case-study architecture

ELEMENT 1: FACTS

Restate the dilemma in one line; verify what is actually given vs assumed

ELEMENT 2: STAKEHOLDERS

List every affected party - direct AND indirect/silent (future generations, absent parties, the institution's own long-term credibility)

ELEMENT 3: CONSTRAINTS

State the HARD CONSTRAINTS that bound the choice - legal/delegation, time, information, resource, jurisdiction/capacity

ELEMENT 4: OPTIONS (3-4, REALISTIC)

Generate at least three realistic courses of action, including hybrid/sequenced options; state one concrete pro AND con for each

ELEMENT 5: ETHICAL EVALUATION

Apply deontology, consequentialism, virtue ethics ('08') + the six-check framework, marking which checks are HARD THRESHOLDS and which are WEIGHTED (Sec. 3-3B)

ELEMENT 6: DECISION

State the chosen option and WHY - which check(s)/framework were decisive, and how the strongest counter-argument was addressed (steelman, Sec. 6)

ELEMENT 7: IMPLEMENTATION & COMMUNICATION

How will the decision be executed and communicated to seniors, juniors, and affected parties

ELEMENT 8: RESIDUAL-RISK MITIGATION

Name the specific risk that survives the decision, and how it will be monitored/reviewed going forward (Sec. 7's closing formula)

Why constraints deserve their own element: ANALYSIS: most weak case-study answers propose options the protagonist has no power, time, information or money to execute. Naming the binding constraint - "the file must be decided before the tender closes on Friday", "the DC cannot reach the Home Secretary because connectivity is down", "GFR delegation caps this officer at Rs 30 lakh" - converts an essay into an administrative decision and rules out unrealistic options early.

Core proposition: ANALYSIS: A high-scoring case-study answer is not a narrative essay but a **structured decision architecture** across all eight elements - facts, stakeholders, constraints, 3+ realistic options, explicit ethical evaluation (moral theories + the six-check framework), a reasoned decision, a realistic implementation/communication plan, and

an honest residual-risk mitigation close. Every fully worked case in Section 14 of this file is written to this exact eight-element standard, and any Section-B case not covered there should still be decomposed into these same eight elements before writing.

2. Essential definitions

Concept	Exam-ready meaning
ANALYSIS: Facts	The verified, given elements of the scenario - restated in one or two lines, separating what is stated from what the candidate is inferring or assuming.
ANALYSIS: Stakeholder mapping	Identifying every party affected by the decision, including indirect/silent stakeholders (future generations, absent parties, the institution's own long-term credibility).
ANALYSIS: Constraint mapping	Separately identifying what <i>bounds</i> the decision: legal and delegation limits (a GFR financial ceiling, a statutory timeline), informational limits (facts not yet verified, communications down), resource and capacity limits, and jurisdictional limits (what the protagonist can decide alone versus what must be referred). An option that violates a hard constraint is not an option; an option that merely strains a soft constraint should be costed, not silently ignored.
ANALYSIS: Options generation	Listing at least three realistic courses of action (not just "do it" vs "don't do it") - including hybrid/sequenced options that a sophisticated administrator would actually consider - with one concrete pro and one concrete con named for each.
FACT: Conflict of interest	A situation where an official's personal interest (financial, family, reputational) could improperly influence their official duty. ANALYSIS: It is not itself misconduct - the failure is proceeding without disclosure or recusal (see 09, 14, and Sec. 4's resolution sequence below).
FACT: Legality check	Whether an option is actually lawful - a necessary threshold test before any further ethical weighing (see 09's ethical-dilemma-vs-legal-violation distinction).
ANALYSIS: Proportionality check	Whether the scale/intensity of the proposed action matches the scale/severity of the problem - avoiding both under-reaction and over-reaction (the Buddhist Middle Path, 06, applied procedurally).
ANALYSIS: Hard threshold vs weighted check	Legality and conflict of interest function as hard thresholds - an illegal or self-interested option is eliminated outright, never merely "weighed" against its benefits. Public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion function as weighted checks that must be balanced against each other case by case, with the candidate stating explicitly which check was decisive (Sec. 3B).
ANALYSIS: Nested-dilemma decomposition	Separating a complex case into its 2-3 analytically distinct sub-dilemmas, solving each with its own mini evaluation, then integrating into one coherent recommendation (Sec. 5).

Concept	Exam-ready meaning
ANALYSIS: Steelmanning	Stating the <i>strongest</i> - not a weak - version of the objection to the chosen decision, and either showing why it does not overturn the decision or modifying the decision to accommodate its valid part (Sec. 6).
ANALYSIS: Residual-risk closing formula	Ending every answer not with "the problem is solved" but with a named risk that survives the decision and a specific monitoring/review mechanism for it (Sec. 7).

SESSION 2 - Six ethical checks: hard thresholds before weighted balancing

3. The six-check evaluation framework (Element 5, in full)

1. **Conflict of interest:** Does any option involve, or appear to involve, the decision-maker's own or a close associate's private benefit? If so, disclose and recuse before proceeding (Sec. 4).
2. **Legality:** Is the option lawful? Illegal options are eliminated regardless of their apparent ethical appeal (see 09, 10).
3. **Public interest:** Which option best serves the broader public, not just the most vocal or powerful stakeholder?
4. **Proportionality:** Is the response calibrated to the actual scale of the problem - neither an overreaction nor an underreaction?
5. **Transparency:** Can the decision and its rationale be openly stated and defended under public/institutional scrutiny (Nolan's accountability/openness principles, 09)?
6. **Compassion + long-term consequence:** Does the decision treat affected individuals, especially vulnerable ones, with dignity, and does it hold up when projected forward in time (not just in its immediate optics)?

3B. Hard thresholds vs weighted checks - applying the six checks correctly

- ANALYSIS: **Legality is (almost) always a hard threshold:** no matter how compelling the public-interest or compassion argument, an option that is actually unlawful should not be chosen. A case-study answer that "chooses" an illegal option because it "feels" more compassionate loses marks for confusing sympathy with ethical reasoning.
- ANALYSIS: **Conflict of interest is also close to a hard threshold:** where a genuine personal-benefit link exists, disclosure/recusal is the correct first move regardless of other considerations, because proceeding despite the conflict taints the legitimacy of *any* subsequent decision, however well-reasoned it looks on paper.
- ANALYSIS: **Public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion are weighted checks** that can genuinely conflict with each other - e.g., in a scarce-resource triage scenario (Sec. 11), pure aggregate public interest might favour one allocation while compassion for the single most vulnerable individual might favour another. A strong answer states explicitly which check is being prioritised, and why, rather than pretending no tension exists.
- ANALYSIS: **Exam technique:** name the hard-threshold checks first (they eliminate options), then apply the weighted checks to the surviving options, then state which weighted check was decisive for the final choice. This sequencing itself signals analytical maturity to the examiner.

4. The conflict-of-interest resolution sequence: disclose -> recuse -> refer -> publish

ANALYSIS: Once a genuine conflict of interest is identified (Sec. 3B), it is resolved through one fixed sequence, not through case-by-case improvisation:

1. **Disclose in writing** - put the personal/family/financial connection on record on the file

itself, addressed to the next competent authority, the moment it is identified - not after a decision has already been taken.

2. **Recuse** from the specific decision - step back from chairing, deciding or influencing that one matter, while continuing normal duties elsewhere.

3. **Route to an untainted authority** - the decision is taken instead by a superior, a committee, or a colleague with no personal stake, so its legitimacy does not depend on trusting the conflicted officer's self-restraint.

4. **Publish/apply criteria in advance** - the untainted authority decides against pre-published, objective criteria (tender specifications, merit lists, a scoring rubric) rather than ad hoc discretion, so the outcome is defensible regardless of who ultimately signs it.

- ANALYSIS: This sequence applies whether the conflict arises from a family member's business interest (a hospital-procurement committee member whose brother is a bidder - 2024 GS-IV Q10, Sneha) or from privileged official information reaching a family member (a PWD Secretary whose son wants pre-announcement alignment details of a road project - 2025 GS-IV Q9, Subash). The reasoning that "my family member is trustworthy/discreet" or "management trusts me fully" is precisely the reasoning a compromised outcome would use, and a strong answer names it as such rather than accepting it as a mitigating factor.

- ANALYSIS: **Conceptual cross-link, not a duplicate treatment:** the institutional *owners* of this sequence are probity/codes-of-conduct (14, 16), the GFR/procurement-propriety framework (18), the PC Act's undue-advantage provisions where privileged information is actually acted upon (19), and vigilance administration's bona fides test for the officer who correctly recused (21). This file states the *method* a case-study answer should apply; it does not restate those files' institutional detail.

SESSION 3 - Nested dilemmas, steelmanning and the residual-risk close

5. Nested-dilemma decomposition

ANALYSIS: Many GS-IV cases are not one dilemma but two or three analytically separable dilemmas bundled into one scenario. The discipline is:

1. **Identify** each sub-dilemma explicitly (e.g., in the 2025 DC-Vijay case: (a) personal grief vs public duty; (b) fairness of ongoing relief-resource allocation; (c) transparency vs calm during an active crisis - see the fully worked case in Sec. 13).

2. **Solve each independently** with its own mini six-check pass, rather than blending them into one undifferentiated emotional reaction.

3. **Integrate** the separate resolutions into a single coherent recommendation, showing how the decisions on each sub-dilemma reinforce rather than contradict each other.

- ANALYSIS: **Discipline, not decoration:** decompose only the sub-dilemmas that are genuinely analytically separable and exam-relevant. Artificially multiplying sub-dilemmas in a simple, single-issue case wastes word-limit and dilutes the answer's focus - the skill is proportionate decomposition, not maximal decomposition.

6. Steelmanning the strongest counter-argument

ANALYSIS: Before closing an answer, state the single *strongest* objection a reasonable, well-informed critic would raise against the chosen decision - not a weak strawman that is easy to dismiss - and then either (a) explain concisely why it does not overturn the conclusion, or (b) modify the decision to accommodate its valid part.

- ANALYSIS: Example (2024 GS-IV Q7, tech company AI/data-centre emissions): the strongest objection to "invest in verifiable renewable transition" is that unconstrained competitors could out-innovate a self-restrained company, eroding its market position and, paradoxically, its long-term capacity to fund sustainability at all. The mature answer meets this directly by recommending a *time-bound, verifiable* (not indefinite or unlimited) commitment calibrated to remain commercially competitive - turning the objection into a design constraint on the decision rather

than ignoring it.

- ANALYSIS: **Calibration:** steelman concisely - one strong objection, addressed in two or three lines. An answer that relitigates the entire dilemma under the guise of "steelmanning" reads as indecisive and wastes the word limit that should go to the decision and implementation elements.

7. The residual-risk closing formula

ANALYSIS: Close every case-study answer with a three-part formula, not a vague "and thus the problem is resolved":

1. **Name the specific residual risk** that survives the chosen decision (e.g., "the deputy's decisions during the DC's absence carry inherent execution risk"; "the untainted authority's decision may still be perceived as favouring the recused officer's associate unless made visibly public").

2. **State the monitoring/review mechanism** that will track that risk (a post-return after-action review; a published tender file open to audit; a scheduled follow-up report).

3. **State who is accountable for that monitoring** - not "it will be monitored" in the passive voice, but naming the office/authority responsible.

- ANALYSIS: This closing formula is what separates a "complete" answer from one that merely stops after announcing a decision - examiners reward the explicit acknowledgment that no single decision is perfectly risk-free.

SESSION 4 - Improper pressure, ethical dissent, whistleblowing and resignation

8. Written-order/file-note response to improper oral pressure

ANALYSIS: A recurring GS-IV pattern (a minister, a superior, or a powerful private party pressing an officer *orally* to bend a decision) has one standard, defensible response: **convert the oral pressure into a written record**, not a unilateral verbal refusal that leaves no trace.

1. Record the substance of the oral instruction/pressure in a file note or a formal letter seeking written confirmation of the direction, addressed to the person who gave it.

2. State on the same file the officer's own considered, reasoned position (legal/technical/ethical objection), so the record shows independent professional judgment was exercised, not mere defiance.

3. If the pressure persists or a written direction is actually issued, refer the matter up the normal reporting line (and, where the pressure itself amounts to impropriety, to the competent vigilance/oversight authority) rather than either quietly complying or publicly confronting the source of pressure.

4. Continue performing the substantive duty (inspection, clearance, tender evaluation) according to the officer's own professional judgment while this reference is pending, unless doing so is itself unsafe or unlawful.

- ANALYSIS: **Why this matters:** an oral instruction leaves no accountability trail; a written file note fixes responsibility on whoever gave the improper direction and protects the officer who resisted it. This is the same underlying logic taught as probity/transparency in 14, 15, and as the vigilance-administration bona fides test in 21 - this file supplies the case-study *method* (what to actually write into the answer), while those files remain the conceptual owners of the institutional detail.

9. Protected whistleblowing and the ethical-dissent ladder

ANALYSIS: Where wrongdoing is discovered and the ordinary chain of command either is the source of the wrongdoing or has failed to act, the defensible response follows a **ladder**, escalating only as far as each lower rung genuinely fails - not jumping straight to public/external disclosure:

1. **Internal reporting** to the immediate competent authority, on file, with evidence.

2. **Escalation** to the next higher or an independent internal authority (a vigilance officer, an internal audit/ethics committee, or - where the internal channel is itself compromised, for example because the wrongdoing implicates the officer's own superior - the next institutionally independent tier available, such as a

statutory ombudsman/regulator or the relevant vigilance commission) once the first channel demonstrably fails or is itself conflicted.

3. **Statutory/lawful external channels** (a vigilance or anti-corruption authority, a regulator, or another lawful reporting mechanism) where internal escalation is exhausted or unavailable.

4. **Public/external disclosure** only as a genuine last resort, when all lawful internal and statutory channels have failed or are unavailable and the wrongdoing poses serious, continuing public harm - recognising this carries real personal and legal risk in the Indian context.

- ANALYSIS: **Where the internal channel is compromised:** if the wrongdoing is committed or shielded by the person who would normally receive the report (a direct superior, or - in a private organisation - ownership/management itself), the correct move is *not* to stay silent, but to skip that specific compromised rung and go to the next genuinely independent one (an external regulator, a vigilance authority, or a professional/statutory body), while still preferring lawful, evidence-based channels over immediate public disclosure.

- FACT: **Status of formal protection:** the Whistle Blowers Protection Act, 2014 (assent 9 May 2014) provides a statutory mechanism but has never been brought into force, and its 2015 amendment bill lapsed - a case-study answer should treat whistleblowing as an ethically correct and administratively necessary course of action, while being factually accurate that comprehensive statutory protection does not yet operate (see 10, 19 for the legal-status detail; 23 for the Manjunath/Dubey human cost that motivated this recommendation).

- ANALYSIS: This ladder is the operational tool for the classic loyalty-vs-public-interest dilemma named in 09; this file supplies the step sequence, 09/10/19 remain the conceptual/legal owners.

10. Resignation as an evaluated last-resort option, not a reflex

ANALYSIS: Resignation should never be the first or an automatic answer to an ethical dilemma - it is one option among several, to be evaluated like any other, and chosen only when it clears an explicit test:

1. Has every lawful internal option - recording dissent on file, escalation, the whistleblowing ladder (Sec. 9), referring the matter to a competent higher or independent authority - genuinely been exhausted or is genuinely unavailable?
2. Would resigning actually *improve* the public-interest outcome (by refusing to lend legitimacy to a wrong decision, or by drawing visible attention to it), or would it simply remove a principled voice from within, leaving the wrongdoing to continue unchecked by someone less willing to resist it?
3. Is continuing in post, while formally recording dissent and refusing personal participation in the specific wrongful act, a more effective safeguard than leaving?

- ANALYSIS: A case-study answer that reaches for resignation without running this test reads as an emotional escape rather than a reasoned administrative decision. The 2020 GS-IV Q7 case (Rajesh Kumar, pressured to re-appropriate welfare funds) explicitly asks the candidate to evaluate "whether resignation is worthy" as one option among several - the worked treatment is in Sec. 14.11.

- ANALYSIS: Where an officer concludes that continuing in post is right, the answer should still name what would change that conclusion (e.g., being compelled to personally sign or execute the wrongful act despite recorded dissent) - showing resignation was genuinely considered, not dismissed by default.

SESSION 5 - Triage, scarce resources and competency-based case practice

11. Triage and scarce-resource allocation

ANALYSIS: Where a decision-maker faces genuinely insufficient resources (beds, staff, relief material, compensation funds) for every claimant, the defensible method is:

1. **Publish criteria in advance**, wherever time allows, rather than deciding case-by-case on an

ad hoc or discretionary basis - e.g., clinical severity/survivability for hospital triage, verified need/vulnerability for disaster relief.

2. **State the ethical trade-off explicitly:** pure aggregate-welfare (utilitarian) reasoning may favour the allocation that saves/helps the largest number, while a compassion/priority-to-the-worst-off (Rawlsian-adjacent) reasoning may favour the most vulnerable claimant even if the numbers served are fewer (08). A strong answer names which principle is being prioritised and why, rather than presenting the allocation as value-neutral logistics.

3. **Keep a record** of the criteria actually applied and who applied them, so the allocation can be defended afterwards under scrutiny (linking to the transparency check, Sec. 3).

4. **Review and adjust** the criteria as the situation develops (e.g., resources become available, or the emergency's profile changes) rather than treating the first published criteria as permanently fixed.

- **ANALYSIS:** Anchor case: 2021 GS-IV Q10 (a COVID-19 hospital administrator deciding criteria for deploying scarce clinical and non-clinical staff during an infectious-disease surge, and whether the justification differs for a private hospital) is the standard triage case study to practise this method against.

12. Mission Karmayogi case/simulation linkage

- **CURRENT:** Mission Karmayogi (the National Programme for Civil Services Capacity Building, Cabinet approval 2 September 2020) increasingly uses structured case-based and simulation learning on the iGOT-Karmayogi platform to build administrative judgment, rather than relying purely on rule memorisation - verify the specific named module before citing it as a current, programme-wide requirement.

- **ANALYSIS:** The link to this architecture: iGOT-style simulations reward exactly the same disciplined sequence taught here - surface the facts and constraints, generate real options, evaluate them against named checks, decide, communicate, and monitor residual risk - rather than an intuitive, unstructured response. Practising this eight-element architecture on paper is therefore also practice for Karmayogi-style competency-based training, not merely an exam technique.

SESSION 6 - Worked mechanism: DC Vijay and integrated decision architecture

13. Mechanism: worked application to the 2025 GS-IV Q7 case (DC "Vijay") - full eight-element architecture

- **Facts:** Vijay, Deputy Commissioner of a remote hill district, is leading relief after a cloudburst that has killed more than 200 people and injured about 5,000, with roads and telecommunications disrupted; his mother dies in Kerala during the crisis; his only close relative is an elder sister who is a US citizen living abroad; heavy rain resumes after a five-day gap while family messages press him to come for the last rites.

- **Stakeholders:** disaster-affected citizens (right to continued, competent relief leadership); Vijay's own family duty and grief; the relief team and institutional continuity of the operation; his own long-term wellbeing (see 05); the deputy who would assume temporary command; the wider administrative service's precedent-setting interest in how personal-versus-public duty is handled.

- **Constraints:** rain has resumed and communications are disrupted, so travel is itself uncertain; there is no other close relative in India to perform the rites; any absence must be authorised and recorded, not improvised; the relief operation cannot be paused, so any absence requires a genuinely competent, briefed deputy to be available now, not after a delay.

- **Options:** (a) leave immediately for the last rites, handing over informally - fast personally, but risks command confusion and an unrecorded authority gap; (b) remain at post and forgo the rites entirely - protects command continuity but disregards a recognised filial duty without necessity, given a workable delegation alternative exists; (c) delegate command to a competent deputy for a short, defined period, attend the essential rites, and return - balances both duties if the delegation is genuine and recorded; (d) manage remotely via continuous communication while a deputy handles ground operations, without travelling at all - avoids travel risk entirely but may not satisfy the

specific familial/rites obligation the facts raise, and still requires the same deputy-competence and communication safeguards as (c).

- **Ethical evaluation:** no conflict of interest; both remaining and a short, delegated absence are fully legal, so legality does not itself decide the case - the weighted checks are decisive. Deontology: duty to citizens is a role-specific, non-negotiable public obligation, but filial duty is also a recognised value, not dismissible. Consequentialism: a short, well-delegated absence causes minimal relief disruption if a competent deputy is briefed; an uncommunicated or undelegated departure causes public panic and command confusion. Virtue ethics: a practically wise administrator seeks a proportionate, transparent balance, not a heroic, martyr-like refusal of all personal need, nor an unrecorded abandonment of post. Applying the six-check framework: public interest favours continuity of competent command; proportionality favours a brief, well-delegated absence over either extreme; transparency favours openly communicating the arrangement to seniors/family/team; compassion applies both to citizens and to the DC's own grieving family. **Steelmanning the strongest counter-argument (Sec. 6):** the strongest objection to option (c) is that *any* command gap during an active, resumed-rain disaster is itself unacceptably risky, however short and well-briefed - a critic could argue Vijay should simply forgo the rites (option (b)). This is met by showing the delegation is not a bare handover but a time-bound, written, closely monitored arrangement with continuous remote oversight - converting the objection into a design requirement (a defined check-in schedule and clear authority limits, Element 7 below) rather than a reason to reject delegation outright.

- **Decision:** Option (c) - delegate command to a well-briefed, competent deputy for a defined, short period; attend essential final rites; maintain remote oversight/communication throughout; communicate the arrangement transparently to all stakeholders.

- **Implementation/communication:** issue a written delegation order with clear authority limits and a defined check-in schedule; communicate the arrangement to seniors (for authorisation on record), to the relief team (so command is unambiguous), and to family (so the arrangement's boundaries are understood); maintain remote contact through the absence.

- **Residual risk:** the deputy's decisions during the DC's absence carry inherent execution risk, and a further deterioration during the short absence cannot be fully ruled out - mitigate by keeping the absence as short as genuinely possible, maintaining the defined check-in schedule throughout, and conducting an after-action review of the relief operation during the DC's absence on return, owned by the DC personally, to capture lessons for future succession planning.

SESSION 7 - Domain adaptation across public, corporate and professional cases

14. Domain modules and fully worked eight-element cases

ANALYSIS: Each module below applies the full eight-element architecture (Sec. 1) to a distinct GS-IV case family. Together they give Basic-alone coverage of every major family audited in 2018-2025 papers.

14.1 Procurement/GFR expenditure-splitting and sanction evasion (anchor: 2025 GS-IV Q10, Rajesh)

- **Facts:** Rajesh, an executive engineer, must repair a collapsed culvert before monsoon; the FACT: Rs 42 lakh estimate exceeds his delegated power of Rs 25 lakh, requiring Superintending Engineer sanction and fresh tendering likely to overrun the deadline; a contractor offers to raise two Rs 21 lakh work orders to stay within Rajesh's own limit and avoid referral upward.

- **Stakeholders:** commuters/villagers dependent on the culvert; the contractor; Rajesh's own integrity and career; the Superintending Engineer's statutory oversight; audit/CAG.

- **Constraints:** ANALYSIS: this is a **works** contract (culvert repair, work orders), so the operative citation is the applicable works-procurement rule and delegation-of-financial-powers framework for works, not GFR Rule 157 verbatim - Rule 157's own text bars only piecemeal splitting of **goods** purchases (see 18 for the precise scope caution); the underlying evasion principle (dividing one genuine requirement to duck the next competent authority's sanction) is identical in effect and is treated as a propriety violation by the same delegation-of-financial-powers logic. The monsoon timeline is genuinely tight; a separate emergency-works provision

exists for genuine urgency but has its own procedure, not artificial splitting.

- **Options:** (a) split the order as suggested - fast, but a direct sanction-evasion/propriety breach; (b) refer the full Rs 42 lakh estimate upward now, citing urgency, and wait - lawful but slow; (c) sanction only the independently justifiable emergency-stabilisation scope within his own power now, while simultaneously referring the full permanent-repair estimate upward; (d) do nothing until sanction arrives - lawful but risks structural failure during monsoon.
- **Ethical evaluation:** legality/propriety is a hard threshold - the works-splitting evasion eliminates option (a) regardless of time saved; the weighted public-interest/proportionality checks favour urgent, lawful action, making (c) decisive.
- **Decision:** Option (c) - undertake only the genuinely separate, urgent stabilisation scope within delegated power, invoking the emergency-works provision with reasons recorded, while referring the balance upward the same day.
- **Implementation/communication:** same-day written reference to the Superintending Engineer with the safety assessment attached; communicate the phased timeline to local authorities/commuters; do not let the contractor structure the paperwork.
- **Residual risk:** the phasing itself could be misread as a disguised split - mitigate by recording the technical/safety justification for treating stabilisation as a genuinely separate scope, having the Superintending Engineer's office countersign the phasing rationale, and scheduling an internal-audit review before contract closure.

14.2 Whistleblowing where the internal channel is compromised (illustrative original case)

- **Facts:** Meera, a quality-assurance officer at a public-sector pharmaceutical unit, finds a medicine batch failed a stability test; her direct manager - who reports to a plant head implicated in past shortcuts - orders the test "re-run until it passes" and threatens her appraisal if she escalates.
- **Stakeholders:** patients who would receive the medicine; Meera's career/safety; the manager and plant head; the drug regulator; public health.
- **Constraints:** the normal first-level channel (her manager) is itself the source of the pressure; the batch's release is time-sensitive; comprehensive statutory whistleblower protection is not yet fully operative in India (see 10, 19).
- **Options:** (a) comply and re-run tests until a pass appears - protects her job, endangers patients; (b) stay silent - same harm, plus complicity; (c) skip the compromised rung (Sec. 9) and report in writing, with evidence, to the plant's independent quality council or the statutory drug regulator, keeping her own dated record; (d) resign immediately without reporting - removes her complicity but leaves the batch and future risk unaddressed.
- **Ethical evaluation:** legality is a hard threshold - releasing an unsafe batch is impermissible regardless of career risk; the dissent ladder (Sec. 9) directs escalation past a compromised rung to the next genuinely independent tier, not silence.
- **Decision:** Option (c) - written report with evidence to the independent quality council and, if unresponsive within a defined short window, to the statutory regulator.
- **Implementation/communication:** record the original failed result and the manager's instruction before acting further; seek written confirmation of the "re-run" instruction (Sec. 8) to fix accountability; report to the regulator with full technical documentation, not rumour.
- **Residual risk:** retaliation despite an incomplete statutory-protection regime - mitigate by keeping records outside office custody, seeking available professional-body/union support, and anchoring disclosure in the specific regulatory reporting obligation rather than personal opinion.

14.3 Communal/law-and-order/procession/viral-rumour case (illustrative original case)

- **Facts:** In a mixed-community town, a doctored video alleging desecration of a religious symbol

goes viral overnight; by morning a large crowd demands an immediate march through the other community's main market, while both sides give conflicting, unverified accounts.

- **Stakeholders:** both communities' residents/traders; crowd leaders; police/district administration; the unverified original complainant; the district's wider law-and-order climate.

- **Constraints:** the video's facts are unverified; any procession requires prior administrative clearance under the prevailing local law; police strength is limited relative to crowd size; a decision is needed within hours.

- **Options:** (a) permit the march as demanded - risks direct confrontation at the market; (b) impose a blanket, indefinite restriction on all movement/assembly - disproportionate and unfocused; (c) urgently verify the video through the cybercrime/forensic channel, engage both communities' recognised leaders in dialogue, permit only a scaled-down, rerouted assembly away from the market under supervision, and record the specific, time-bound restriction in a written order; (d) delay pending full verification - risks the crowd moving regardless.

- **Ethical evaluation:** legality is a hard threshold - any restriction must use the lawful, narrowly tailored preventive/prohibitory powers actually available, never an ad hoc blanket order; proportionality is the decisive weighted check, favouring the least restrictive lawful measure that still prevents violence; transparency favours a written, reasoned order over an unrecorded verbal direction to police.

- **Decision:** Option (c) - verify urgently, engage both communities, permit a scaled-down, rerouted assembly under supervision, record the reasoned, time-bound restriction in writing.

- **Implementation/communication:** issue the written order to police and both sets of community leaders; calibrated public communication that neither confirms the unverified claim nor dismisses community sentiment, committing to publish verified facts once confirmed; visible, briefed police presence at the market rather than a show of force at the procession.

- **Residual risk:** the rumour may resurface or verification may outlast the crowd's patience - mitigate through a scheduled follow-up communication once verification completes, a standing leader-administration dialogue mechanism, and a post-incident review of the escalation, owned by the district administration.

14.4 Health/research informed-consent, clinical-trial and data-integrity case (anchor: 2024 GS-IV Q12, Dr Srinivasan)

- **Facts:** Dr Srinivasan, a senior scientist at a biotechnology company, is under board pressure to accelerate a drug trial's enrolment; a site coordinator has been enrolling economically disadvantaged, poorly literate participants via a simplified verbal explanation instead of the full written consent process, and one interim data point unfavourable to efficacy has been quietly excluded from the dataset shown to the Institutional Ethics Committee (IEC) as an "outlier."

- **Stakeholders:** trial participants, especially the vulnerable; future patients; the IEC; the regulator; the company's board; the scientific record's integrity.

- **Constraints:** FACT: the ICMR National Ethical Guidelines for Biomedical and Health Research Involving Human Participants (2017) require documented, comprehensible informed consent, added safeguards for vulnerable participants, and full, undistorted reporting to the IEC; the trial has a commercial timeline; Dr Srinivasan does not control enrolment but is scientifically accountable for the dataset.

- **Options:** (a) accept the pressure, let the simplified consent and the exclusion stand - a clear breach of consent standards and data integrity; (b) unilaterally halt the trial without informing the IEC - bypasses the correct institutional authority; (c) report both lapses in writing to the IEC immediately, propose ICMR-compliant re-consenting of affected participants, and reinstate the excluded data point pending the IEC's own determination; (d) quietly instruct retroactive "fixing" of consent forms - compounds the breach with falsification.

- **Ethical evaluation:** research-ethics compliance is a hard threshold regardless of commercial pressure; the IEC, not the individual scientist or the board, is the correct "untainted authority" (paralleling Sec. 4) to weigh continuation vs suspension; transparency and compassion for vulnerable participants are decisive over the commercial timeline.

- **Decision:** Option (c) - disclose both lapses to the IEC without delay, propose compliant re-consenting, reinstate the full dataset for the IEC's determination.

- **Implementation/communication:** document the process failure and exclusion on file; tell the board continuation is now the IEC's call, not a unilateral one; re-approach affected participants through a compliant process with a genuine right to withdraw without penalty.

- **Residual risk:** re-consenting itself risks re-traumatising vulnerable participants - mitigate via an independent, trained counsellor (not the original coordinator) conducting re-consent, and a follow-up IEC compliance audit of the site.

14.5 Refugee/border influx including armed persons (anchor: 2025 GS-IV Q12, Ashok)

- **Facts:** Ashok, a Divisional Commissioner in a border district, learns a large group of civilians has crossed overnight fleeing violence in a neighbouring country, and that a smaller number among them are armed and in what appears to be a foreign uniform; residents are alarmed and border forces want one uniform response for the whole group.

- **Stakeholders:** the fleeing civilians (women, children, elderly); the armed individuals; local residents' security; national security agencies; India's constitutional/human-rights obligations to all persons on its soil; the neighbouring state's government.

- **Constraints:** FACT: India is not a party to the 1951 Refugee Convention or its 1967 Protocol and has no dedicated refugee statute, so no automatic refugee-status process exists; the Foreigners Act's ordinary procedure still governs a foreign national's legal status; ANALYSIS: the Supreme Court, in an **interim order declining a stay on deportation** (*Mohammad Salimullah v. Union of India*, 8 April 2021 - not a final judgment on the underlying petition), reasoned that the right to remain/ not be deported tied to citizenship under Article 19(1)(e) is not automatically available to non-citizens, while leaving the separate question of whether customary international law binds India to non-refoulement independent of treaty membership an open legal debate; Articles 14 and 21 (due process, protection of life/personal liberty for "any person") apply to every person on Indian soil, including non-citizens (*NHRC v. State of Arunachal Pradesh*, 1996, a final judgment); the armed individuals pose a genuine but unverified security risk; humanitarian urgency is immediate.

- **Options:** (a) push the entire group back uniformly as armed intruders - ignores civilians' distinct status and due-process obligations, a disproportionate, legally fragile response; (b) allow unrestricted entry for everyone including the armed individuals - ignores the genuine security risk; (c) immediately separate the group - disarm and detain the armed individuals for security screening and formal referral to the appropriate authority under the ordinary law, while giving unarmed civilians humanitarian shelter, medical care and registration pending case-by-case status determination, with force used only as necessary and proportionate; (d) refer the whole matter to the central government before any local action - leaves both the security risk and the humanitarian need unaddressed indefinitely.

- **Ethical evaluation:** legality is a hard threshold on both sides - due process/dignity for civilians cannot be dispensed with, nor can the ordinary security-screening procedure for the armed individuals be skipped; proportionality is decisive, requiring an individually calibrated response (disarm-and-refer vs shelter-and-register) rather than one blanket rule; compassion for civilians must not obscure the distinct, genuine security question the armed minority poses, and vice versa - this is deliberately **not** a simple "open border" or "automatic deportation" answer.

- **Decision:** Option (c) - separate without delay; disarm and hand the armed individuals to the appropriate security/investigating authority for ordinary-law screening; give unarmed civilians immediate humanitarian assistance and register them for case-by-case determination.

- **Implementation/communication:** written order recording the separation criteria and basis for each stream's handling; calm, factual public communication to residents (cross-linking Sec. 14.3's method); formal coordination with security agencies; escalate any diplomatically sensitive element through proper channels rather than resolving it unilaterally.

- **Residual risk:** initial screening may misclassify individuals amid a fast-moving crossing -

mitigate through a documented, reviewable screening record per individual, a defined review window before further action on the civilian group, and central-government escalation of sensitive elements.

14.6 POSH/workplace sexual-harassment case (illustrative original case, grounded in Vishaka + POSH Act mechanics)

- **Facts:** Anjali, a junior engineer at a public-sector unit, reports to HR that her project head has made repeated unwelcome remarks and pressured her for after-hours meetings; the unit's Internal Committee (IC - termed the "Internal Complaints Committee" in the principal-office constitution wording of POSH Act s.4(1), and "Internal Committee" in its proviso for other administrative units/offices; both denote the same body) exists on paper, but its presiding officer is a close friend of the accused, and colleagues warn that raising the complaint could hurt her upcoming confirmation.

- **Stakeholders:** Anjali; the accused; other women who may face similar conduct; the IC's credibility; management; the organisation's legal exposure.

- **Constraints:** FACT: the Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace Act, 2013, built on the guidelines in *Vishaka & Ors v. State of Rajasthan* (1997) 6 SCC 241, mandates an IC in any workplace with ten or more employees, at least half its members women, an external member from a women's-cause body, a written complaint within three months (extendable), inquiry completion within ninety days, and employer action on the recommendation within sixty days; the compromised element here is the specific presiding officer's bias, not the law's own requirement.

- **Options:** (a) advise Anjali to withdraw or "manage" it informally to protect her confirmation - fails the legality/dignity threshold and enables continued harassment; (b) file with the existing, presiding-officer-biased IC unchanged - risks a compromised inquiry; (c) file the statutory complaint, while separately flagging the presiding officer's conflict of interest in writing to the employer/appointing authority, requesting recusal and reconstitution with an unbiased presiding officer or referral to the Local Committee; (d) bypass the IC entirely for the police/media - available in serious cases, but should not be the first move where the statutory mechanism can still be corrected.

- **Ethical evaluation:** legality is a hard threshold - the POSH Act's process must be followed, not avoided from career-risk concern; the conflict-of-interest sequence (Sec. 4) applies directly to the presiding officer - disclose, recuse, and route to an untainted composition rather than accept a compromised inquiry; compassion and public interest favour protecting the complainant from retaliation during the process.

- **Decision:** Option (c) - file the statutory complaint and, in writing, raise the presiding officer's conflict of interest, seeking recusal and an unbiased reconstitution.

- **Implementation/communication:** both the substantive complaint and the conflict concern go on record with dates; the employer confirms the reconstituted committee and inquiry timeline in writing and acts on the outcome within sixty days; no retaliatory action pending the inquiry.

- **Residual risk:** informal retaliation can persist even with a procedurally correct inquiry - mitigate through a written non-retaliation assurance, periodic HR check-ins with the complainant, and independent review of the final outcome by higher management.

14.7 Conflict-of-interest procurement case (anchor: 2024 GS-IV Q10, Sneha)

- **Facts:** Sneha chairs a private hospital chain's medical-supplies procurement committee; during bid evaluation she finds her financially stressed brother has submitted a competing bid; the hospital, being private, has no mandatory-lowest-bid rule, and management says it will support whatever she decides.

- **Stakeholders:** the hospital and patients needing reliable supplies; competing bidders; Sneha's brother/family; her own professional integrity; management's institutional credibility.

- **Constraints:** no external regulator governs this private process, so the committee's own integrity is the only real constraint; management's "full trust" removes an external check rather than providing one; the tender evaluation has its own timeline.

- **Options:** (a) evaluate the bids herself, trusting her own objectivity - fails the hard-threshold

conflict-of-interest test regardless of her actual intentions, because the process's legitimacy, not just the outcome, is compromised; (b) quietly favour a competitor to "prove" impartiality - equally improper, substituting one bias for another; (c) disclose the relationship in writing to management immediately, recuse from this evaluation, and have an alternate, unconflicted manager/committee evaluate strictly against the published tender criteria; (d) ask her brother to informally withdraw - fixes this one tender but builds no durable institutional safeguard.

- **Ethical evaluation:** the textbook hard-threshold conflict-of-interest case - the six-check

framework's first check controls the outcome regardless of the other five; the disclose -> recuse -> refer -> publish sequence (Sec. 4) applies completely.

- **Decision:** Option (c) - full written disclosure, recusal, evaluation by an untainted alternate authority against pre-published criteria.

- **Implementation/communication:** disclosure memo and management's acknowledgment go on file before bid opening is finalised; the alternate evaluator is briefed only on published criteria, not personal context; the outcome is communicated to all bidders on the same objective basis.

- **Residual risk:** perceived favouritism (either direction) may persist even after a clean process
- mitigate by publishing the evaluation scoring on request and by Sneha recusing from any future tender involving her brother, not just this one.

14.8 Environment-development case (anchor: 2025 GS-IV Q8, deforestation for housing)

- **Facts:** To advance the constitutional welfare objective of "Roti, Kapda aur Makan", a district administration proposes clearing part of a forest for housing for homeless and economically weaker sections. The site is an ecologically sensitive zone with age-old trees, medicinal plants and vital biodiversity. It regulates micro-climate and rainfall, supports wildlife habitat and soil fertility, prevents erosion, and sustains tribal and nomadic livelihoods. The administration invokes fundamental human rights, upliftment of the poor, recurring human-wildlife conflict and alleged use of the forest as hideouts by anti-social elements.

- **Stakeholders:** homeless and economically weaker households; tribal and nomadic communities; wildlife and ecological systems; district officials; future generations; citizens affected by housing deprivation, human-wildlife conflict and law-and-order concerns.

- **Constraints:** the administration must protect human dignity without treating social welfare as an automatic override of ecological integrity or traditional livelihoods. Claims about unsafe forests and alleged hideouts require evidence. Alternatives must be evaluated against housing urgency, accessibility, livelihood disruption, ecological sensitivity and lawful clearance.

- **Options:** (a) proceed immediately citing humanitarian emergency, bypassing full clearance - fails the legality hard threshold regardless of genuine need; (b) reject the project outright to protect the forest patch - disproportionate, ignoring a genuine competing public interest; (c) commission an urgent, time-bound comparison of non-forest public land, brownfield and in-situ housing options while subjecting any proposed forest diversion to lawful, independent ecological and social assessment; (d) delay through an open-ended study - protects the forest by default but leaves families unsheltered indefinitely.

- **Ethical evaluation:** legality is a hard threshold - statutory clearance cannot be bypassed even for an urgent welfare objective; proportionality and public interest are decisive, requiring the least ecologically damaging option that still meaningfully meets the housing need in reasonable time, not a simple either/or between shelter and ecology.

- **Decision:** Option (c) - prioritise the least ecologically and socially damaging feasible housing route, using in-situ upgrading, vacant or brownfield public land, higher-density design and serviced rental housing before considering forest diversion.

- **Implementation/communication:** publish a time-bound alternatives matrix; consult homeless, tribal and nomadic communities; independently verify ecological and livelihood impacts; provide interim shelter and services; document the reasons for the selected option and monitor outcomes.

- **Residual risk:** the alternative-site search could be used to stall indefinitely, or rushed to

justify the original site regardless of findings - mitigate with a fixed, published assessment timeline and independent (non-departmental) verification of feasibility and ecological comparison.

14.9 Corporate/AI discrimination or emissions case (anchor: 2024 GS-IV Q7, ABC Incorporated)

- **Facts:** ABC Incorporated, the world's second-largest technology company situated in the Third World, recorded a 48% increase in greenhouse-gas emissions in 2023 compared with 2019. The rise is linked mainly to the surging electricity demand of data centres supporting rapid AI expansion. The company has committed to net-zero emissions by 2030, but renewable-energy investment is substantial and the technology sector rewards rapid innovation, market position and shareholder value. The paper asks for the CEO's immediate response, the ethical issues, arguments concerning a proposed penalty, and measures balancing AI innovation with environmental footprint.

- **Stakeholders:** communities affected by energy, water and emissions burdens; employees; shareholders; customers; environmental activists; regulators; future generations; competitors facing different costs and commitments.

- **Constraints:** the 48% increase and 2030 commitment require a credible response, yet an indiscriminate halt to AI services may sacrifice useful innovation, employment and competitive position. The CEO must not treat a public pledge as a substitute for verified implementation.

- **Options:** (a) continue unchanged and manage criticism as public relations; (b) halt AI expansion immediately; (c) retain AI innovation while adopting time-bound, independently verifiable efficiency, renewable-energy, procurement and emissions-reduction milestones; (d) offset reported emissions without changing energy demand or operating choices.

- **Ethical evaluation:** option (a) risks greenwashing and breaches the company's public commitment. Option (b) gives precaution absolute priority but may be disproportionate. Option (d) can shift responsibility without reducing the underlying footprint. Option (c) joins intergenerational justice, stakeholder responsibility and honest disclosure with a feasible transition. A proportionate penalty can internalise environmental costs and deter false promises, but must use transparent criteria, due process and equal treatment.

- **Decision:** Option (c) - commission an immediate independently assured footprint assessment, publish a credible 2030 transition pathway and tie capital expenditure and executive accountability to measurable reduction milestones.

- **Implementation/communication:** establish board-level responsibility; disclose scopes, assumptions and progress consistently; improve model and data-centre efficiency; procure cleaner power; manage water, hardware and e-waste impacts; engage regulators and affected communities.

- **Residual risk:** cleaner electricity may remain constrained and efficiency can induce rebound demand. Use periodic external assurance, absolute as well as intensity indicators, and a review trigger when emissions diverge from the published pathway.

14.10 Disaster/personal-duty case - strengthened cross-reference

This family now has a complete eight-element worked case, with separately stated facts, stakeholders, constraints, four options, ethical evaluation (including an explicit steelmanned counter-argument), decision, implementation/communication and residual risk, in Sec. 13 (2025 GS-IV Q7, DC Vijay), sharpened further by the nested-dilemma decomposition (Sec. 5) and the residual-risk closing formula (Sec. 7). ANALYSIS: Practise variants of this family - a rescue officer whose team is assaulted by an angry crowd (2019 GS-IV Q7); a district officer during a migrant-worker crisis (2020 GS-IV Q12) - using the identical eight-element sequence, since a personal-duty-versus-professional-duty tension recurs across disaster/crisis case studies.

14.11 Public-funds/social-audit case (anchor: 2020 GS-IV Q7, Rajesh Kumar) - the anchor for resignation-as-last-resort

- **Facts:** Rajesh Kumar, a Finance Ministry official, is directed to re-appropriate a National Health Scheme welfare allocation toward an SEZ project and a gas-based power plant favoured by senior functionaries; he is told the re-appropriation is "technically permissible" under budgetary-flexibility provisions but believes it substantively diverts welfare money from intended beneficiaries.

- **Stakeholders:** intended welfare-scheme beneficiaries; the SEZ/power-plant proponents; his own career and conscience; the Ministry's institutional integrity; Parliament's budgetary oversight; taxpayers.

- **Constraints:** the reallocation may be procedurally valid, so this is a propriety/intent question, not a bright-line illegality - the weighted public-interest/transparency checks carry more weight than a clean legality veto; he lacks unilateral authority to block the reallocation; the budgetary window is limited.

- **Options:** (a) comply silently - protects his position but fails public-interest/transparency checks if the diversion is unjustified; (b) refuse outright and resign immediately in protest - dramatic, but skips testing whether internal escalation (Sec. 9) could still correct the decision, and removes his voice from the process; (c) record a written, reasoned objection on file (Sec. 8), seek written confirmation of the direction from the competent higher authority, and escalate - with a welfare-impact analysis - to the ministry's financial-oversight mechanism or, if unresolved, the appropriate parliamentary/audit oversight route, before considering resignation; (d) leak the decision anonymously to the press - bypasses lawful internal channels prematurely.

- **Ethical evaluation:** not a clean legality hard-threshold case - the decisive checks are transparency and public interest, worked through the dissent ladder (Sec. 9) since internal channels are not yet exhausted; resignation (Sec. 10) is explicitly evaluated and found premature, because internal escalation has neither been tried nor shown to fail.

- **Decision:** Option (c) - written, reasoned objection; written confirmation sought; escalation through the ministry's own oversight mechanism; continue performing duties professionally while pending, reserving resignation only if the objection is overruled without adequate justification and he would otherwise be compelled to personally certify a diversion he has formally objected to.

- **Implementation/communication:** the objection and escalation go on the official file, not an informal conversation; the escalation's outcome is documented; social-audit-style transparency (echoing MKSS's Jan Sunwai method, 23) is proposed as a durable safeguard for future allocations.

- **Residual risk:** the escalation may be overruled by the same functionaries who directed the reallocation - mitigate by ensuring the written record independently reaches the normal CAG/ parliamentary-audit trail regardless of the internal outcome, and by revisiting the resignation test (Sec. 10) only if he is personally compelled to certify the diversion against his recorded, unresolved objection.

14.12 Custodial-justice/police-excess case (anchor: D.K. Basu v. State of West Bengal safeguards)

- **Facts:** Priya, the Station House Officer of a busy urban police station, learns that two constables under her command used disproportionate force while interrogating a theft suspect overnight, causing visible injuries; the suspect's family has gathered outside demanding answers, the constables claim the suspect "resisted arrest," and no arrest memo, medical examination or entry in the custody diary was made at the time of detention.

- **Stakeholders:** the detained suspect (dignity, medical need, due-process rights); the suspect's family; the two constables (including their own due process and safety from mob action outside); Priya's command responsibility and legal exposure; the police force's institutional credibility; the judiciary/magistracy with oversight jurisdiction; the wider public interest in lawful, humane policing.

- **Constraints:** FACT: the constitutional and procedural safeguards laid down in *D.K. Basu v. State of West Bengal*, (1997) 1 SCC 416 (18 December 1996) - given statutory force through Cr.P.C. provisions on arrest procedure and now carried forward under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023 (verify the exact current section numbers before citing them in a live answer, since BNSS renumbered the former Cr.P.C. provisions) - require a memo of arrest attested by a witness and countersigned by the arrestee, informing a friend/relative of the arrest and place of custody, medical examination of the arrestee at the time of arrest and thereafter at approximately 48-hour intervals with injuries recorded, entries in a case diary/custody register, and information to the local magistrate; none of this was done here, which is itself a documented procedural breach independent of what actually happened during interrogation; the suspect requires prompt medical attention; the crowd outside is an immediate law-and-order and officer-safety concern; any internal cover-up materially worsens both the legal and reputational exposure.

- **Options:** (a) accept the constables' "resisted arrest" account without independent verification

and quietly regularise the paperwork after the fact - fails legality/transparency thresholds and risks destroying the evidentiary trail; (b) suspend the constables publicly before any inquiry and make a public statement assuming guilt - pre-empts due process for the constables and may inflame rather than calm the situation; (c) immediately arrange independent medical examination and treatment of the suspect, secure and document the existing evidence (CCTV, duty roster, the belated custody entries) before it can be altered, report the incident up the chain and to the magistrate as required, and refer the conduct question to an independent departmental/vigilance inquiry while managing the crowd through calm, factual communication; (d) resolve it informally between the family and the constables to avoid escalation - fails both legality and the victim's right to a formal, recorded process.

- **Ethical evaluation:** legality is a hard threshold on two fronts - the missing arrest-memo/medical-examination/custody-diary safeguards are themselves breaches of settled procedure regardless of what force was actually used, and any established use of disproportionate force is a separate legal wrong; proportionality is the central weighted check on the *use of force* question itself (was any force used necessary and proportionate to actual resistance, or excessive) and must be assessed by evidence, not by the accused officers' own account alone; compassion and victim dignity require prompt medical care and honest information to the family, not paperwork regularisation; officer safety for the constables also matters procedurally - due process (a fair departmental/legal inquiry) protects them from an unverified mob or media judgment just as it protects the complainant from an unverified official denial. **Steelmanning the strongest counter-argument:** a critic could argue that referring the matter to an independent inquiry and informing the magistrate immediately unfairly presumes the constables' guilt before any finding - this is met by making clear that securing evidence and following the mandatory custodial safeguards is a *procedural* obligation owed regardless of the eventual finding on the merits, and that an independent inquiry protects an innocent officer's position at least as much as it protects the complainant's, since a self-investigated, undocumented outcome would be equally vulnerable to later challenge either way.

- **Decision:** Option (c) - immediate medical examination and treatment of the suspect; evidence preservation (CCTV, duty logs, belated entries, photographs of injuries); mandatory reporting up the chain and to the jurisdictional magistrate; referral of the force-used question to an independent departmental/vigilance inquiry; calm, factual crowd communication in parallel.

- **Implementation/communication:** written report to superior officers and the magistrate same-day, attaching the medical examination record and an honest account of the missing initial paperwork; factual, non-speculative communication to the waiting family on the steps being taken (medical care given, inquiry ordered) without pre-judging guilt either way; internal communication to the constables that they retain due-process rights within a fair inquiry, not blanket protection from one.

- **Residual risk:** evidence quality may already be compromised by the delay in following custodial procedure, and community trust may remain damaged regardless of the inquiry's eventual finding - mitigate through an independent forensic/medical review of the available evidence, a published (non-sensitive) summary of the inquiry's procedural timeline once concluded, and a station-level review of custodial-procedure compliance going forward, owned by the SHO personally and audited periodically by the district vigilance/oversight authority.

14.13 Data/privacy case (illustrative original case, grounded in Puttaswamy + the DPDP Act, 2023)

- **Facts:** Meera heads a State's digital welfare-delivery mission, whose citizen database was built and consented to for one specific purpose - verifying eligibility and disbursing subsidy payments. A state police unit investigating an organised crime network asks her, informally and urgently, for bulk access to the linked mobile numbers and location logs of thousands of citizens in a district to help trace the network, without producing any specific statutory order or documented necessity; a senior political functionary separately calls to say the request should be "expedited in the public interest."

- **Stakeholders:** citizens whose personal data is held (privacy, dignity, trust in the welfare platform); the public's genuine interest in effective crime-fighting; the police unit; the political functionary applying pressure; Meera's own legal exposure and the mission's institutional credibility; future users who would be deterred from a welfare scheme they fear is a surveillance tool in disguise.

- **Constraints:** FACT: *Justice K.S. Puttaswamy (Retd.) v. Union of India*, (2017) 10 SCC 1 (nine-judge

bench) holds any state infringement of the fundamental right to privacy must meet a **proportionality** standard - a legitimate aim, necessity, and a proportionate means-end balance; FACT: the DPDP Act, 2023's consent and **purpose-limitation** principle means data consented to for welfare disbursement cannot simply be repurposed for law-enforcement surveillance without an independent, documented legal basis; no specific court/competent-authority order authorising this particular disclosure exists yet; the political pressure is oral, not a written legal direction; the crime investigation is time-sensitive, but urgency alone is not a legal basis for disclosure.

- **Options:** (a) share the full requested bulk dataset immediately - fastest for the investigation, but fails the legality/proportionality hard threshold: it repurposes purpose-specific, consented welfare data for surveillance without any documented legal basis; (b) refuse all cooperation outright, citing privacy - protects data integrity but disregards a genuine, weighty public-safety interest and is itself a disproportionate response to a legitimate investigative need; (c) require the police unit to route the request through the applicable lawful data-sharing/interception channel (a specific, reasoned order from the competent authority, in writing, identifying necessity and a narrowly defined dataset - not an open-ended bulk request), apply **data minimisation** (share only what the documented order actually requires), log the disclosure, and convert the political functionary's oral pressure into a written record (Sec. 8) rather than a verbal refusal; (d) share only anonymised/aggregated pattern data - protects individual privacy most fully but may not meet the investigation's genuine individual-level need, and still requires the same lawful-order route as (c) if individual data is later shown to be genuinely necessary.

- **Ethical evaluation:** legality/proportionality functions as a hard threshold here - Puttaswamy's own proportionality test and the DPDP Act's purpose-limitation principle together mean personal data cannot be disclosed for a new, unconsented purpose merely because the request is urgent or politically endorsed; public interest and security are genuine, weighted values, but they must be channelled through the lawful order route, not ad hoc political pressure. **Steelmanning the strongest counter-argument:** a critic could argue that insisting on a documented order costs time the investigation cannot afford, potentially letting the network escape or cause further harm - this is met by making the requirement time-bound (actively assisting the agency in expediting a properly reasoned order through whatever emergency provision genuinely exists, rather than either an unconditional refusal or an unlawful bulk handover) and by data minimisation, which supplies the agency with what it actually needs, on time, without eliminating the legal safeguard.

- **Decision:** Option (c) - insist on and help expedite a specific, written, competent-authority order; disclose only the minimum data that order actually requires; log the disclosure; put the political functionary's pressure on written record rather than complying informally.

- **Implementation/communication:** a written note to the political functionary explaining the statutory/constitutional requirement (not a personal refusal); written guidance to the police unit on the correct, expedited lawful channel; secure, access-logged handling of any data actually shared; an internal file note recording the full sequence for future audit.

- **Residual risk:** the eventual order, even if lawful, may later be challenged as insufficiently narrow, and Meera may still face criticism for "non-cooperation" in the interim - mitigate through a periodic, independent audit of all law-enforcement data-sharing requests and disclosures, a named data-protection/nodal officer reviewing the proportionality of each one, and a scheduled review of the sharing protocol itself, owned by the mission's own governance committee.

14.14 Scarce-resource triage case (anchor: 2021 GS-IV Q10, COVID-19 hospital administrator)

- **Facts:** FACT: A hospital administrator must decide, during an infectious-disease surge, the criteria and justification for deploying scarce clinical and non-clinical staff, and whether the justification differs for a private hospital (2021 GS-IV Q10's own framing).

- **Stakeholders:** patients across the full range of clinical severity; hospital staff (workload, safety, burnout); hospital management/ownership (including commercial considerations at a private facility); the wider public-health system and referral network; regulators overseeing emergency standards of care.

- **Constraints:** an absolute, not merely inconvenient, shortage of trained staff/beds/equipment at the surge's peak; decisions cannot be deferred without patients coming to direct harm; a private hospital operates under the same public-health regulatory oversight during a declared health emergency as a public one, even though

its ownership and resourcing structure differ.

- **Options:** (a) allocate staff purely by rota/seniority with no severity-based criteria - simple

and non-discretionary, but ignores clinical urgency and reduces aggregate lives/outcomes saved; (b) allocate informally, case-by-case, allowing influence/ability-to-pay to affect priority (a live risk at a private facility absent published criteria) - fails the transparency and public-interest checks outright; (c) **publish clinically-anchored triage criteria in advance** (Sec. 11's method), applied identically regardless of ward or payment status, with a built-in equity safeguard against the criteria mechanically devaluing any specific patient group, and a fixed review cycle as the surge evolves; (d) defer any systematic criteria and decide purely case-by-case under pressure - avoids the difficulty of publishing a formula but produces inconsistent, undocumented, harder-to-defend decisions exactly when scrutiny is highest.

- **Ethical evaluation:** this is the textbook application of Sec. 11's triage method and 08

Section 12's applied-theory treatment - reused here, not restated: publish criteria in advance; state explicitly which principle is prioritised (aggregate-welfare/consequentialist severity ranking, softened by a compassion/priority-to-the-worst-off safeguard against arbitrary devaluation of any person, 08); keep a record of criteria actually applied; review and adjust as the emergency's profile changes. **Steelmanning the strongest counter-argument:** a critic could argue that a purely severity-anchored formula could still systematically disadvantage a patient group whose presenting symptoms or comorbidities score poorly on the chosen severity metric - this is met by building an explicit equity review into the criteria's design and its periodic audit, not by abandoning published criteria for ad hoc discretion, which would be worse on transparency and consistency grounds.

Public-versus-private distinction: ownership does not licence a different-quality triage ethic - the same transparent, non-discriminatory, published-criteria standard applies to a private hospital during a declared public-health emergency; what legitimately differs is the private entity's own internal resourcing/staffing/redeployment decisions, which remain its operational prerogative within that shared ethical/regulatory floor.

- **Decision:** Option (c) - published, clinically-anchored, equity-audited triage criteria, applied uniformly regardless of ward or payment status, reviewed on a fixed cycle.

- **Implementation/communication:** publish the criteria to staff and, in an appropriate public form, to patients/families; train triage teams on consistent application; communicate individual allocation decisions to families factually and compassionately; log every decision against the criterion actually applied.

- **Residual risk:** published criteria can still be perceived as unfair by those who lose out, and the criteria may need revision as the surge's clinical profile shifts - mitigate through a scheduled review cycle, an independent grievance/review channel separate from the treating clinician, and ownership of both by a named triage-oversight committee rather than any single individual.

14.15 Political-pressure/politicisation case (anchor: 2023 GS-IV Q10, honest IAS officer as SRTC Managing Director)

- **Facts:** FACT: An honest IAS officer serves as Managing Director of a State Road Transport Corporation (SRTC) whose politically powerful Chairman is corrupt, while the Managing Director also faces pressure from an Opposition party in relation to the same matter (2023 GS-IV Q10's own framing). ANALYSIS: Working scenario: the Chairman has been steering procurement/contract decisions toward favoured, overpriced vendors; the Opposition party separately presses the Managing Director to hand over internal records to use politically against the Chairman, while associates of the Chairman press the Managing Director to look the other way.

- **Stakeholders:** SRTC's commuting public and employees (service quality, fare and safety integrity); the Chairman and his patronage network; the Opposition party seeking political advantage; the Managing Director's own career, integrity and legal exposure; the state government's administrative and vigilance oversight; taxpayers funding the Corporation.

- **Constraints:** the Managing Director has no unilateral power to remove a politically appointed Chairman; acting on the Opposition's terms risks turning a genuine propriety question into a partisan controversy that undermines the Managing Director's own institutional neutrality; specific irregularities must be documented before any formal escalation, not merely suspected; day-to-day Corporation operations must continue regardless of this conflict.

- **Options:** (a) quietly comply with the Chairman and let the irregularities continue - protects

the Managing Director's position but fails the legality/public-interest/transparency checks; (b) hand over internal records to the Opposition party as requested - dramatic and possibly effective politically, but converts a propriety/vigilance matter into a partisan act, breaching the neutrality a civil servant owes regardless of which political side is asking; (c) document the specific irregularities on file, seek written clarification from the Chairman on the questioned decisions (the written-record method, Sec. 8), and escalate through the Corporation's own audit/vigilance mechanism and the administrative department that oversees the SRTC, while declining - politely and on record - to route information through the Opposition's politically framed channel; (d) resign in protest - premature, since internal/statutory escalation (Sec. 9-10) has neither been tried nor shown to fail.

- **Ethical evaluation:** legality/propriety is a hard threshold for the underlying procurement irregularities once verified; the decisive weighted checks are transparency and public interest, worked through the written-record method (Sec. 8) and the whistleblowing/dissent ladder (Sec. 9), since the Chairman is the very authority who would normally receive such a report; resignation (Sec. 10) is explicitly evaluated and found premature.

Steelmanning the strongest counter-argument: the strongest objection to option (c) is that slow internal-audit/vigilance channels, while the Chairman remains in position, risk continued harm and could look like institutional complicity - this is met by making the escalation explicitly time-bound and by the Managing Director independently safeguarding every procurement decision within their own authority against improper influence in the interim, rather than either waiting passively or short-circuiting due process through a partisan leak.

- **Decision:** Option (c) - document irregularities, seek written clarification, escalate through the Corporation's audit/vigilance mechanism and the administrative department, decline the Opposition's politically framed request, and maintain professional, non-partisan continuity of service delivery throughout.

- **Implementation/communication:** written file notes and escalation correspondence maintained independently of both the Chairman's and the Opposition's channels; transparent, non-partisan communication to staff on service-delivery priorities; any necessary public statement confined to factual, process-based information rather than political framing.

- **Residual risk:** the escalation may be slow-walked given the Chairman's political weight, and the Managing Director may face retaliatory transfer or continued pressure - mitigate by ensuring the escalation record independently reaches the state vigilance commission or the relevant statutory oversight body regardless of the departmental outcome, and by keeping a personal, dated record of every instance of pressure, reviewed periodically by an authority independent of the Corporation's own management chain.

15. Indian applications and examples

- **FACT:** 2024 GS-IV Q7 (Section B case study: tech company AI/data-centre emissions, see 12, 13, and the fully worked case in Sec. 14.9) is best solved using the same eight-element architecture: options (continue as-is; halt AI expansion; invest in verifiable renewable transition) evaluated against the six checks, yielding a decision for time-bound, audited renewable investment alongside continued innovation.

- **ANALYSIS:** The other 2024 Section B cases are worth practising against this architecture too: Q8 (DG Police countering online radicalisation of unemployed youth), Q9 (SP surrounded by tribal women demanding release of apprehended naxalites), Q10 (hospital manager Sneha, whose brother has bid for a procurement contract - the fully worked conflict-of-interest case in Sec. 14.7), Q11 (District Collector balancing farmers and industry in a water crisis) and Q12 (Dr Srinivasan pressed to take data-integrity and informed-consent shortcuts in a drug trial - the fully worked case in Sec. 14.4).

- **ANALYSIS:** For 2025, Section B is Q7 (DC Vijay - Sec. 13), Q8 (clearing forest land to house the homeless - the fully worked case in Sec. 14.8), Q9 (PWD Secretary Subash, insider land information and ministerial pressure - Sec. 4), Q10 (Rajesh and the splitting of expenditure to avoid a GFR sanction limit - Sec. 14.1), Q11 (restoring a mismanaged MGNREGA programme) and Q12 (Divisional Commissioner Ashok and a cross-border influx that includes armed soldiers in uniform - the fully worked case in Sec. 14.5). Between them they cover conflict of interest, procurement propriety, humanitarian obligation and public-money integrity - the syllabus in applied form.

- **ANALYSIS:** Any GS-IV case study involving a public official's private grief, financial pressure, or

political pressure should be decomposed using this same architecture rather than answered as a free-flowing narrative - the fully worked political-pressure case is in Sec. 14.15, and the fully worked scarce-resource-triage and data/privacy cases are in Sec. 14.14 and Sec. 14.13 respectively.

SESSION 8 - Prelims facts, examiner traps and representative PYQ routing

16. Must-Know Facts for Prelims

- ANALYSIS: For the **specific 2024 and 2025 GS-IV papers audited here**, Section B (Case Studies) carried 120 of the paper's 250 marks - six cases of 20 marks each, numbered Q7-Q12 in both years - and rewarded structured, multi-step reasoning over narrative storytelling, while Section A (Q1-Q6) carried the remaining 130. ANALYSIS: This 130:120 (Section A : Section B) split reflects the audited 2024-2025 pattern specifically, not a permanently fixed or universally guaranteed UPSC weightage - always verify the actual question count and marks distribution against the current year's own paper before relying on this figure.

- ANALYSIS: The six-check framework (conflict of interest, legality, public interest, proportionality, transparency, compassion/long-term consequence) is a synthesis tool, not a single "correct" UPSC-mandated checklist - its value is in ensuring no major ethical dimension is missed.

- ANALYSIS: Legality and conflict of interest function as **hard thresholds**; public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion function as **weighted, case-specific checks** (Sec. 3B) - this distinction, not the six-check list alone, is what separates a strong answer from an average one.

17. UPSC traps

- WRONG: A case-study answer should present only one "correct" option without discussing alternatives. -> Examiners reward explicit comparison of multiple realistic options against the evaluation framework before committing to a decision.

- WRONG: Emotional/narrative language ("this is a very difficult situation...") substitutes for analytical structure. -> High-scoring answers name the specific ethical concept/framework being applied at each element, not just describe the emotional difficulty.

- WRONG: Implementation/mitigation is optional if the "right" decision is identified. -> Examiners specifically reward a realistic implementation plan and acknowledgment of residual risk, not just the decision itself.

- WRONG: All six checks carry equal weight in every scenario. -> Legality and conflict of interest are near-hard thresholds; the remaining four are weighted and can genuinely conflict, requiring explicit prioritisation reasoning (Sec. 3B).

- WRONG: Resignation is always the most ethical response to improper pressure. -> Resignation is an evaluated last-resort option (Sec. 10), chosen only after lawful internal escalation is exhausted or shown unavailable - reaching for it immediately reads as an emotional escape, not reasoned administration.

- WRONG: Oral pressure from a senior/political figure can simply be verbally refused with no further action. -> The defensible response converts the pressure into a written record (Sec. 8) - a verbal-only refusal leaves no accountability trail for either side.

- WRONG: A cross-border/refugee influx case is correctly resolved by either unconditional entry or blanket deportation. -> A defensible answer separates individuals by actual risk/status and applies humanitarian protection and security screening in parallel (Sec. 14.5) - neither extreme reflects India's actual constitutional and administrative position.

- WRONG: A custodial-excess case is resolved by accepting the accused officers' account, or by publicly presuming their guilt, without independent evidence. -> The defensible response follows the D.K. Basu safeguards (medical examination, evidence preservation, mandatory reporting, an independent inquiry - Sec. 14.12) regardless of which way the eventual finding goes, protecting both the complainant's dignity and the accused officers' due process.

18. PYQ application

- FACT: 2025 GS-IV Q7 (DC Vijay) and 2024 GS-IV Q7 (tech company) are the audited case studies against which this architecture should be practised; the remaining ten Section B cases of those two papers (2024 Q8-Q12 and 2025 Q8-Q12) supply the rest of the practice bank, with fully worked treatments of Q10/2025 (Sec. 14.1), Q9/2025 (Sec. 4), Q12/2025 (Sec. 14.5), Q8/2025 (Sec. 14.8), Q10/2024 (Sec. 14.7) and Q12/2024 (Sec. 14.4) in Sec. 14.
- ANALYSIS: Both anchor cases reward candidates who explicitly name conflict-of-interest, legality, public-interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion checks rather than a purely narrative emotional response.
- ANALYSIS: A custodial-justice/police-excess case (Sec. 14.12) is not yet part of the audited 2024-2025 Section B bank, but recurs across earlier years' papers as a policing-ethics family; practise it using the identical eight-element sequence and the named D.K. Basu safeguards.
- ANALYSIS: A scarce-resource-triage case (Sec. 14.14, anchored to 2021 GS-IV Q10) and a political-pressure case (Sec. 14.15, anchored to 2023 GS-IV Q10) likewise sit in the historical (2018-2023) bank rather than the audited 2024-2025 papers, and a data/privacy case (Sec. 14.13, grounded in *Puttaswamy* and the DPDP Act, 2023) is an illustrative original case not yet tested as a GS-IV Section B case study - all three should still be practised using the identical eight-element sequence, since the underlying case families recur across years.

SESSION 9 - Mains analysis, probable demands and time-bound answer design

19. Mains angles

- ANALYSIS: Always write case-study answers with explicit section headers or clearly signposted paragraphs matching the eight-element architecture - this structural clarity itself earns credit from examiners scanning for a systematic approach.
- ANALYSIS: End every case-study answer with a specific, actionable implementation step and the residual-risk closing formula (Sec. 7), not just an abstract "I would balance both values" conclusion.

Answer thesis: A defensible GS-IV case-study answer works through facts, stakeholder and **constraint** mapping, 3+ realistic options, moral-theory evaluation, a six-point ethical check (conflict of interest, legality, public interest, proportionality, transparency, compassion/ long-term consequence) that distinguishes hard thresholds from weighted checks, a reasoned decision, a realistic implementation/communication plan, and an explicit residual-risk mitigation close - never a single-paragraph narrative reaction.

20. Probable questions

- ANALYSIS: **Prelims:** N/A (case-study method is a Mains-only skill; Prelims does not test this directly).
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (case study, 20 marks):** Apply the eight-element architecture to a disaster-management scenario involving a district officer's competing personal and professional duties.
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (case study, 20 marks):** Apply the eight-element architecture to a corporate case involving environmental sustainability versus profitability and innovation pressure.
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (case study, 20 marks):** A field engineer faces an urgent repair whose true cost exceeds their delegated financial power. Apply the eight-element architecture, explicitly addressing the works-procurement/delegation-of-financial-powers propriety principle against splitting the requirement (the works-contract analogue of GFR Rule 157's goods-specific piecemeal-purchase bar - see 18 and Sec. 14.1's scope caution).
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (case study, 20 marks):** A district officer must respond within hours to a fast-moving, rumour-driven communal tension around a proposed procession. Apply the eight-element architecture, naming the specific lawful, proportionate measures available.
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (case study, 20 marks):** A border-district officer receives a mixed group of civilian

and armed persons crossing from a neighbouring country. Apply the eight-element architecture, addressing humanitarian protection, security screening, and India's actual legal position on non-refoulement and refugee status.

- ANALYSIS: **Mains (case study, 20 marks):** A Station House Officer discovers that constables under her command used disproportionate force on a detained suspect and that mandatory custodial safeguards were not followed. Apply the eight-element architecture, naming the specific D.K. Basu-derived safeguards (Sec. 14.12) required before any further action.

SESSION 10 - Study links, recent cases, historical cases and final synthesis

21. Study links

- FACT: Advanced companion: `advanced/22_Case-Study-Method-and-Answer-Architecture.md`.
- FACT: `08_Moral-Theories-Deontology-Consequentialism-Virtue-Ethics.md` - the theory-application element.
- FACT: `21_Protecting-Honest-Officials-and-Vigilance-Administration.md` - the independent-inquiry and officer-safety framing that Sec. 14.12's custodial-justice module applies.
- FACT: `05_Emotional-Intelligence-in-Administration.md` - the DC-Vijay-type personal/duty dilemma.
- FACT: `09_Public-Service-Values-Status-and-Ethical-Dilemmas.md` - the loyalty-vs-public-interest and conscience-vs-rule dilemmas underlying Sec. 9's dissent ladder.
- FACT: `14_Probity-Concept-and-Philosophical-Basis-of-Governance.md`, `15_Transparency-RTI-and-Information-Sharing.md` - institutional owners of the written-record discipline in Sec. 8.
- FACT: `18_Utilization-of-Public-Funds-and-Challenges-of-Corruption.md`, `19_Corruption-Legal-Framework.md` - the GFR/procurement and whistleblower-law detail behind Sec. 4 and Sec. 14.1/14.2.
- FACT: `21_Protecting-Honest-Officials-and-Vigilance-Administration.md` - the bona fides test that clears a genuinely recused/documented decision.
- FACT: `13_Emerging-Ethics-Technology-AI-and-Environment.md` Sec. 11A, `15_Transparency-RTI-and-Information-Sharing.md` - the *Puttaswamy*/DPDP-Act ethical and statutory anchors for Sec. 14.13's data/privacy case.
- FACT: `23_Comparative-and-Named-Real-Case-Studies.md` - real, named cases (including Vishaka, ICMR and refugee jurisprudence) grounding the domain modules in Sec. 14.

Recent PYQ Integration (2024-2025)

Status: 2024-2025 question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: `_PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS3-GS4-2024-2025.md`.

- **Years represented:** 2024, 2025
- **Paper(s):** GS-IV
- **Routed question demands:** 12

Semantic table split - Year

- **Year:** 2024

- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 7
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case study: ABC Incorporated, a large technology company
- **Directive / format:** Section B case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Routed to owning topic
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2024
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 8
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case study: Raman, a senior IPS officer appointed DG of a State
- **Directive / format:** Section B case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Routed to owning topic
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2024
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 9
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case study: Rohit and a multi-pronged strategy in LWE-affected States
- **Directive / format:** Section B case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Routed to owning topic
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2024
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 10
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case study: Sneha, a senior manager at a hospital chain
- **Directive / format:** Section B case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Routed to owning topic
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2024
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 11
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case study: District Collector amid acute water scarcity
- **Directive / format:** Section B case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Routed to owning topic
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2024
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 12
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case study: Dr. Srinivasan, a senior scientist at a biotechnology company
- **Directive / format:** Section B case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Routed to owning topic
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2025
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 7

- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case study: Vijay, Deputy Commissioner of a remote district in a hilly northern State
- **Directive / format:** Section B case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Routed to owning topic
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2025
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 8
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case study: deforestation for housing and social-welfare objectives
- **Directive / format:** Section B case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Routed to owning topic
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2025
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 9
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case study: Subash - ethical issues and options
- **Directive / format:** Section B case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Routed to owning topic
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2025
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 10
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case study: Rajesh - options and ethical issues
- **Directive / format:** Section B case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Routed to owning topic
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2025
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 11
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case study: restoring proper functioning of the MGNREGA programme
- **Directive / format:** Section B case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Routed to owning topic
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2025
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 12
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case study: Ashok - ethical and legal dilemmas
- **Directive / format:** Section B case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Routed to owning topic
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.

What this owner must now support

- Case study: ABC Incorporated, a large technology company
- Case study: Raman, a senior IPS officer appointed DG of a State
- Case study: Rohit and a multi-pronged strategy in LWE-affected States

- Case study: Sneha, a senior manager at a hospital chain
- Case study: District Collector amid acute water scarcity
- Case study: Dr. Srinivasan, a senior scientist at a biotechnology company
- Case study: Vijay, Deputy Commissioner of a remote district in a hilly northern State
- Case study: deforestation for housing and social-welfare objectives
- Case study: Subash - ethical issues and options
- Case study: Rajesh - options and ethical issues
- Case study: restoring proper functioning of the MGNREGA programme
- Case study: Ashok - ethical and legal dilemmas

This block integrates the 2024-2025 examinable demand and paper metadata. It is kept separate from the 2018-2023 block and does not convert an unkeyed/answer-free objective question into a solved answer.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS3-GS4-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023
- **Paper(s):** GS-IV
- **Routed question demands:** 36

Semantic table split - Year

- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 7
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Rakesh (district officer) - elderly couple applies for senior citizen healthcare scheme; surgeon willing to operate free but couple cannot afford incidental costs; how should he respond
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 8
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Senior Ministry officer with access to policy decisions - minister requests road realignment near his farm and offers land in wife's name; conflicts of interest and responsibilities as public servant
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 9
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** SP appointed in prohibition state notorious for illicit liquor distillation causing deaths; what new approach to bring problem under control
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method

- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 10
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Corporate chemical factory ordered closed after pollution protests and public agitation; closure causes unemployment in workers and ancillary units; address as senior officer
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 11
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Dr. X charitable trust hospital - tax irregularities found on inspection; two options: broad substantial compliance ignoring technical defaults vs strict pursuit on all fronts
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 12
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Edward Snowden released classified government surveillance documents citing moral obligation to inform public; ethically justified even if legally prohibited - weighing competing values
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2019
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 7
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Rescue officer in severe natural calamity - team members assaulted by angry crowd - some plead to call off operations; what will be your response and what qualities of public servant are required
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2019
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 8
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Civil servants implicated and imprisoned for bonafide mistakes - moral fibre of civil services rattled; how this trend affects functioning and measures to protect honest officers
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method

- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2019
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 9
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Apparel company - marketing executive sexually harasses woman employee - company offers money to withdraw FIR; identify ethical issues and options available to woman employee
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2019
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 10
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Rising politicization of bureaucracy - political executive encroaching on permanent executive including transfers and postings; consequences of this trend
- **Directive / format:** Discuss · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2019
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 11
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Woman SP appointed in frontier narcotics district - money laundering poppy farming arms smuggling education collapse; identify dimensions and suggest measures to restore normalcy
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2019
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 12
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Civil service ethics reform - institutional measures for anticipating ethical threats strengthening ethical competence and developing administrative processes promoting integrity
- **Directive / format:** Suggest · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2020
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 7
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Finance Ministry official Rajesh Kumar: re-appropriation of NHS welfare funds to SEZ and gas plant - (a) ethical issues; (b) options available including whether resignation is worthy
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method

- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2020
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 8
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** BML Chairman asked to expand ATGM production for export to friendly nation
 - (a) ethical issues for a responsible arms-exporting nation; (b) five ethical factors influencing arms sale decision
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2020
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 9
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** DC of tribal Rampura district: minor girls trafficked to cotton farms as child labour by contractors; identify ethical issues; steps to ameliorate conditions and economic scenario
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2020
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 10
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Municipal Commissioner: mall collapse causing deaths; corruption nexus between officials and builder; POSH threat by minister relative; ethical issues and selected course of action
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2020
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 11
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Anil APW factory in backward Parmal district: CSR-driven development of Noora village - critically analyse ethical issues; assess APW as role model for backward area development
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2020
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 12
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** migrant workers during COVID lockdown: ethical issues in crisis; meaning of ethical care and ethical giving; civil society role in mitigating migrant suffering
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method

- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2021
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 7
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Sunil in tribal district combats illegal sand mining mafia and faces violence threats - (a) options available; (b) evaluate each option; (c) most appropriate course of action
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2021
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 8
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Vice Principal faces management pressure to suppress exam cheating involving students of influential local politician and businessman - (a) ethical issues; (b) options and best course
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2021
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 9
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** project manager of elevated corridor notices crack in pier; minister and chief engineer pressure to overlook - (a) options; (b) ethical dilemmas; (c) professional challenges; (d) consequences
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2021
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 10
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** COVID-19 hospital administrator: criteria and justification for deploying clinical and non-clinical staff in infectious crisis; whether justification differs for a private hospital
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2021
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 11
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** food company sells inferior products domestically and dumps rejected export products in Indian market - (a) authority action; (b) company remedy to restore reputation; (c) ethical dilemma
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method

- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2021
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 12
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Pawan faces chronic workplace harassment and public humiliation by senior officer causing mental anguish and family distress - options to cope; approach for tranquillity; training suggestions
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2022
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 7
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on a marketing VP offered rival firm's defence tender documents in exchange for employment
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2022
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 8
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on a state civil service officer directed to withdraw confidential report on illegal migrant infiltration
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2022
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 9
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on a journalist exposing stone-mining mafia-official-politician nexus who faces report suppression by the media owner
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2022
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 10
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on a quality inspection officer pressured to clear an export-rejected defective consignment for domestic market
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2022
- **Paper:** GS-IV

- **Q: 11**
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on Joint Commissioner adjudicating bus driver death compensation dispute and resolving transport workers strike
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2022
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q: 12**
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on Environment Pollution Control Board officer enforcing industrial environmental compliance despite resistance and threats
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2023
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q: 7**
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on bank executive whose colleague's father's surgery was funded by manager from a dormant account without authorisation
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2023
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q: 8**
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on District Magistrate (AIIMS physician) facing blood-transfusion dilemma during a landslide relief operation
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2023
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q: 9**
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on Joint Secretary navigating work-life obligations and equitable workplace laws protecting women in service
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2023
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q: 10**
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on honest IAS officer as SRTC MD facing corrupt politically powerful Chairman and pressure from Opposition party
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method

- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2023
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 11
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on ADG CPWD handling workplace harassment of a new woman architect by an insecure senior Chief Architect
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2023
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 12
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on senior government official managing son's cyberbullying and posting a counter-video on social media
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.

What this owner must now support

- Rakesh (district officer) - elderly couple applies for senior citizen healthcare scheme; surgeon willing to operate free but couple cannot afford incidental costs; how should he respond
- Senior Ministry officer with access to policy decisions - minister requests road realignment near his farm and offers land in wife's name; conflicts of interest and responsibilities as public servant
- SP appointed in prohibition state notorious for illicit liquor distillation causing deaths; what new approach to bring problem under control
- Corporate chemical factory ordered closed after pollution protests and public agitation; closure causes unemployment in workers and ancillary units; address as senior officer
- Dr. X charitable trust hospital - tax irregularities found on inspection; two options: broad substantial compliance ignoring technical defaults vs strict pursuit on all fronts
- Edward Snowden released classified government surveillance documents citing moral obligation to inform public; ethically justified even if legally prohibited - weighing competing values
- Rescue officer in severe natural calamity - team members assaulted by angry crowd - some plead to call off operations; what will be your response and what qualities of public servant are required
- Civil servants implicated and imprisoned for bonafide mistakes - moral fibre of civil services rattled; how this trend affects functioning and measures to protect honest officers
- Apparel company - marketing executive sexually harasses woman employee - company offers money to withdraw FIR; identify ethical issues and options available to woman employee
- Rising politicization of bureaucracy - political executive encroaching on permanent executive including transfers and postings; consequences of this trend
- Woman SP appointed in frontier narcotics district - money laundering poppy farming arms smuggling education collapse; identify dimensions and suggest measures to restore normalcy
- Civil service ethics reform - institutional measures for anticipating ethical threats strengthening ethical competence and developing administrative processes promoting integrity
- Finance Ministry official Rajesh Kumar: re-appropriation of NHS welfare funds to SEZ and gas plant - (a) ethical issues; (b) options available including whether resignation is worthy
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- Sunil in tribal district combats illegal sand mining mafia and faces violence threats - (a) options available; (b) evaluate each option; (c) most appropriate course of action
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- Pawan faces chronic workplace harassment and public humiliation by senior officer causing mental anguish and family distress - options to cope; approach for tranquillity; training suggestions
- Case on a marketing VP offered rival firm's defence tender documents in exchange for employment
- Case on a state civil service officer directed to withdraw confidential report on illegal migrant infiltration
- Case on a journalist exposing stone-mining mafia-official-politician nexus who faces report suppression by the media owner
- Case on a quality inspection officer pressured to clear an export-rejected defective consignment for domestic market
- Case on Joint Commissioner adjudicating bus driver death compensation dispute and resolving transport workers strike
- Case on Environment Pollution Control Board officer enforcing industrial environmental compliance despite resistance and threats
- Case on bank executive whose colleague's father's surgery was funded by manager from a dormant account without authorisation
- Case on District Magistrate (AIIMS physician) facing blood-transfusion dilemma during a landslide relief operation
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- Case on honest IAS officer as SRTC MD facing corrupt politically powerful Chairman and pressure from Opposition party
- Case on ADG CPWD handling workplace harassment of a new woman architect by an insecure senior Chief Architect
- Case on senior government official managing son's cyberbullying and posting a counter-video on social media

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1

An officer assumes a contractor bribed a superior merely because they met privately. What initial discipline is missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A disciplined case answer restates only verified facts, identifies uncertainty and avoids silently inventing motives, powers or resources; later options and judgments must remain traceable to what the scenario actually establishes.
- B. Stakeholder mapping must include direct participants and less visible parties such as future generations, absent beneficiaries, vulnerable groups and the institution whose long-term credibility may be altered by the decision.
- C. Legal authority, delegation limits, time, verified information, jurisdiction and actual capacity should be mapped before generating options; a proposal that breaches a binding constraint is not a realistic administrative choice.
- D. A strong answer develops at least three feasible courses, including a sequenced or hybrid response where useful, and states one concrete advantage and disadvantage before selecting the most defensible course.

Answer: A

Explanation: Facts must be separated from assumptions is the controlling principle. A disciplined case answer restates only verified facts, identifies uncertainty and avoids silently inventing motives, powers or resources; later options and judgments must remain traceable to what the scenario actually establishes. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 2

A candidate labels disputed claims as unverified and states what must be checked before action. Which architectural element is being applied? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Legal authority, delegation limits, time, verified information, jurisdiction and actual capacity should be mapped before generating options; a proposal that breaches a binding constraint is not a realistic administrative choice.
- B. A disciplined case answer restates only verified facts, identifies uncertainty and avoids silently inventing motives, powers or resources; later options and judgments must remain traceable to what the scenario actually establishes.
- C. A strong answer develops at least three feasible courses, including a sequenced or hybrid response where useful, and states one concrete advantage and disadvantage before selecting the most defensible course.
- D. Stakeholder mapping must include direct participants and less visible parties such as future generations, absent beneficiaries, vulnerable groups and the institution whose long-term credibility may be altered by the decision.

Answer: B

Explanation: Facts must be separated from assumptions is the controlling principle. A disciplined case answer restates only verified facts, identifies uncertainty and avoids silently inventing motives, powers or resources; later options and judgments must remain traceable to what the scenario actually establishes. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 3

A forest-diversion answer lists officials and applicants but ignores tribal livelihoods, biodiversity and future residents. What mapping defect appears? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A disciplined case answer restates only verified facts, identifies uncertainty and avoids silently inventing motives, powers or resources; later options and judgments must remain traceable to what the scenario actually establishes.
- B. Legal authority, delegation limits, time, verified information, jurisdiction and actual capacity should be mapped before generating options; a proposal that breaches a binding constraint is not a realistic administrative choice.
- C. Stakeholder mapping must include direct participants and less visible parties such as future generations, absent beneficiaries, vulnerable groups and the institution whose long-term credibility may be altered by the decision.
- D. A strong answer develops at least three feasible courses, including a sequenced or hybrid response where useful, and states one concrete advantage and disadvantage before selecting the most defensible course.

Answer: C

Explanation: Stakeholder mapping includes silent parties is the controlling principle. Stakeholder mapping must include direct participants and less visible parties such as future generations, absent beneficiaries, vulnerable groups and the institution whose long-term credibility may be altered by the decision. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 4

A procurement answer includes patients, rival bidders and public trust although none speaks in the narrative. Which disciplined practice does this show? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Legal authority, delegation limits, time, verified information, jurisdiction and actual capacity should be mapped before generating options; a proposal that breaches a binding constraint is not a realistic administrative choice.
- B. A strong answer develops at least three feasible courses, including a sequenced or hybrid response where useful, and states one concrete advantage and disadvantage before selecting the most defensible course.
- C. A disciplined case answer restates only verified facts, identifies uncertainty and avoids silently inventing motives, powers or resources; later options and judgments must remain traceable to what the scenario actually establishes.
- D. Stakeholder mapping must include direct participants and less visible parties such as future generations, absent beneficiaries, vulnerable groups and the institution whose long-term credibility may be altered by the decision.

Answer: D

Explanation: Stakeholder mapping includes silent parties is the controlling principle. Stakeholder mapping must include direct participants and less visible parties such as future generations, absent beneficiaries, vulnerable groups and the institution whose long-term credibility may be altered by the decision. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 5

A district officer promises immediate national legislation to resolve a local emergency. Which overlooked element makes the promise unusable? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Legal authority, delegation limits, time, verified information, jurisdiction and actual capacity should be mapped before generating options; a proposal that breaches a binding constraint is not a realistic administrative choice.
- B. A disciplined case answer restates only verified facts, identifies uncertainty and avoids silently inventing motives, powers or resources; later options and judgments must remain traceable to what the scenario actually establishes.
- C. Stakeholder mapping must include direct participants and less visible parties such as future generations, absent beneficiaries, vulnerable groups and the institution whose long-term credibility may be altered by the decision.
- D. A strong answer develops at least three feasible courses, including a sequenced or hybrid response where useful, and states one concrete advantage and disadvantage before selecting the most defensible course.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Hard constraints eliminate impossible choices early** is the controlling principle. Legal authority, delegation limits, time, verified information, jurisdiction and actual capacity should be mapped before generating options; a proposal that breaches a binding constraint is not a realistic administrative choice. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 6

A field engineer distinguishes emergency stabilisation within delegated power from a permanent repair requiring superior sanction. Which reasoning step is decisive? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Stakeholder mapping must include direct participants and less visible parties such as future generations, absent beneficiaries, vulnerable groups and the institution whose long-term credibility may be altered by the decision.
- B. Legal authority, delegation limits, time, verified information, jurisdiction and actual capacity should be mapped before generating options; a proposal that breaches a binding constraint is not a realistic administrative choice.
- C. A strong answer develops at least three feasible courses, including a sequenced or hybrid response where useful, and states one concrete advantage and disadvantage before selecting the most defensible course.
- D. A disciplined case answer restates only verified facts, identifies uncertainty and avoids silently inventing motives, powers or resources; later options and judgments must remain traceable to what the scenario actually establishes.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Hard constraints eliminate impossible choices early** is the controlling principle. Legal authority, delegation limits, time, verified information, jurisdiction and actual capacity should be mapped before generating options; a proposal that breaches a binding constraint is not a realistic administrative choice. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 7

A response offers only obey or resign, although written dissent and lawful escalation remain available. Which architectural weakness does this reveal? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A disciplined case answer restates only verified facts, identifies uncertainty and avoids silently inventing motives, powers or resources; later options and judgments must remain traceable to what the scenario actually establishes.
- B. Stakeholder mapping must include direct participants and less visible parties such as future generations, absent beneficiaries, vulnerable groups and the institution whose long-term credibility may be altered by the decision.
- C. A strong answer develops at least three feasible courses, including a sequenced or hybrid response where useful, and states one concrete advantage and disadvantage before selecting the most defensible course.
- D. Legal authority, delegation limits, time, verified information, jurisdiction and actual capacity should be mapped before generating options; a proposal that breaches a binding constraint is not a realistic administrative choice.

Answer: C

Explanation: Options require realistic comparison is the controlling principle. A strong answer develops at least three feasible courses, including a sequenced or hybrid response where useful, and states one concrete advantage and disadvantage before selecting the most defensible course. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 8

A disaster answer compares immediate departure, total abstention, brief delegated absence and remote oversight before deciding. Which option discipline is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Stakeholder mapping must include direct participants and less visible parties such as future generations, absent beneficiaries, vulnerable groups and the institution whose long-term credibility may be altered by the decision.
- B. Legal authority, delegation limits, time, verified information, jurisdiction and actual capacity should be mapped before generating options; a proposal that breaches a binding constraint is not a realistic administrative choice.
- C. A disciplined case answer restates only verified facts, identifies uncertainty and avoids silently inventing motives, powers or resources; later options and judgments must remain traceable to what the scenario actually establishes.
- D. A strong answer develops at least three feasible courses, including a sequenced or hybrid response where useful, and states one concrete advantage and disadvantage before selecting the most defensible course.

Answer: D

Explanation: Options require realistic comparison is the controlling principle. A strong answer develops at least three feasible courses, including a sequenced or hybrid response where useful, and states one concrete advantage and disadvantage before selecting the most defensible course. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 9

An officer proposes unlawful data disclosure because it could speed an investigation. Which check defeats the proposal before benefits are weighed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. An unlawful option is normally eliminated before ethical balancing, even when it appears compassionate or efficient; claimed benefits cannot convert absence of lawful authority into a permissible administrative response.
- B. A genuine personal, family or financial interest requires disclosure and withdrawal from the specific decision; confidence in one's own honesty cannot cure the appearance or structural risk of biased authority.
- C. Public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion may pull in different directions; the candidate should state which consideration is decisive in context and explain why the remaining concerns are mitigated rather than denied.
- D. After threshold screening, deontology tests duties and rights, consequentialism compares foreseeable outcomes, and virtue ethics asks what integrity, courage, compassion and practical wisdom require from the decision-maker.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Legality operates as a hard threshold** is the controlling principle. An unlawful option is normally eliminated before ethical balancing, even when it appears compassionate or efficient; claimed benefits cannot convert absence of lawful authority into a permissible administrative response. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 10

A candidate first removes sanction evasion and then compares lawful urgent responses. Which evaluation sequence is correct? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion may pull in different directions; the candidate should state which consideration is decisive in context and explain why the remaining concerns are mitigated rather than denied.
- B. An unlawful option is normally eliminated before ethical balancing, even when it appears compassionate or efficient; claimed benefits cannot convert absence of lawful authority into a permissible administrative response.
- C. After threshold screening, deontology tests duties and rights, consequentialism compares foreseeable outcomes, and virtue ethics asks what integrity, courage, compassion and practical wisdom require from the decision-maker.
- D. A genuine personal, family or financial interest requires disclosure and withdrawal from the specific decision; confidence in one's own honesty cannot cure the appearance or structural risk of biased authority.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Legality operates as a hard threshold** is the controlling principle. An unlawful option is normally eliminated before ethical balancing, even when it appears compassionate or efficient; claimed benefits cannot convert absence of lawful authority into a permissible administrative response. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 11

A committee chair evaluates her brother's bid because management trusts her judgment. Which threshold has been ignored? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. An unlawful option is normally eliminated before ethical balancing, even when it appears compassionate or efficient; claimed benefits cannot convert absence of lawful authority into a permissible administrative response.
- B. Public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion may pull in different directions; the candidate should state which consideration is decisive in context and explain why the remaining concerns are mitigated rather than denied.
- C. A genuine personal, family or financial interest requires disclosure and withdrawal from the specific decision; confidence in one's own honesty cannot cure the appearance or structural risk of biased authority.
- D. After threshold screening, deontology tests duties and rights, consequentialism compares foreseeable outcomes, and virtue ethics asks what integrity, courage, compassion and practical wisdom require from the decision-maker.

Answer: C

Explanation: Conflict of interest is near-disqualifying is the controlling principle. A genuine personal, family or financial interest requires disclosure and withdrawal from the specific decision; confidence in one's own honesty cannot cure the appearance or structural risk of biased authority. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 12

An official records a family link and stops influencing that tender while continuing other duties. Which principle is correctly applied? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion may pull in different directions; the candidate should state which consideration is decisive in context and explain why the remaining concerns are mitigated rather than denied.
- B. After threshold screening, deontology tests duties and rights, consequentialism compares foreseeable outcomes, and virtue ethics asks what integrity, courage, compassion and practical wisdom require from the decision-maker.
- C. An unlawful option is normally eliminated before ethical balancing, even when it appears compassionate or efficient; claimed benefits cannot convert absence of lawful authority into a permissible administrative response.
- D. A genuine personal, family or financial interest requires disclosure and withdrawal from the specific decision; confidence in one's own honesty cannot cure the appearance or structural risk of biased authority.

Answer: D

Explanation: Conflict of interest is near-disqualifying is the controlling principle. A genuine personal, family or financial interest requires disclosure and withdrawal from the specific decision; confidence in one's own honesty cannot cure the appearance or structural risk of biased authority. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 13

Scarce beds could maximise lives saved yet disadvantage a vulnerable group. What must the answer do beyond listing both values? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion may pull in different directions; the candidate should state which consideration is decisive in context and explain why the remaining concerns are mitigated rather than denied.
- B. An unlawful option is normally eliminated before ethical balancing, even when it appears compassionate or efficient; claimed benefits cannot convert absence of lawful authority into a permissible administrative response.
- C. A genuine personal, family or financial interest requires disclosure and withdrawal from the specific decision; confidence in one's own honesty cannot cure the appearance or structural risk of biased authority.
- D. After threshold screening, deontology tests duties and rights, consequentialism compares foreseeable outcomes, and virtue ethics asks what integrity, courage, compassion and practical wisdom require from the decision-maker.

Answer: A

Explanation: Weighted checks require an explicit priority is the controlling principle. Public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion may pull in different directions; the candidate should state which consideration is decisive in context and explain why the remaining concerns are mitigated rather than denied. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 14

A crisis response prioritises proportionality while adding honest communication and a grievance route. Which balancing method is shown? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A genuine personal, family or financial interest requires disclosure and withdrawal from the specific decision; confidence in one's own honesty cannot cure the appearance or structural risk of biased authority.
- B. Public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion may pull in different directions; the candidate should state which consideration is decisive in context and explain why the remaining concerns are mitigated rather than denied.
- C. After threshold screening, deontology tests duties and rights, consequentialism compares foreseeable outcomes, and virtue ethics asks what integrity, courage, compassion and practical wisdom require from the decision-maker.
- D. An unlawful option is normally eliminated before ethical balancing, even when it appears compassionate or efficient; claimed benefits cannot convert absence of lawful authority into a permissible administrative response.

Answer: B

Explanation: Weighted checks require an explicit priority is the controlling principle. Public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion may pull in different directions; the candidate should state which consideration is decisive in context and explain why the remaining concerns are mitigated rather than denied. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 15

A candidate cites compassion alone without testing duty, effects or character. Which evaluative layer remains incomplete? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. An unlawful option is normally eliminated before ethical balancing, even when it appears compassionate or efficient; claimed benefits cannot convert absence of lawful authority into a permissible administrative response.
- B. A genuine personal, family or financial interest requires disclosure and withdrawal from the specific decision; confidence in one's own honesty cannot cure the appearance or structural risk of biased authority.
- C. After threshold screening, deontology tests duties and rights, consequentialism compares foreseeable outcomes, and virtue ethics asks what integrity, courage, compassion and practical wisdom require from the decision-maker.
- D. Public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion may pull in different directions; the candidate should state which consideration is decisive in context and explain why the remaining concerns are mitigated rather than denied.

Answer: C

Explanation: Moral theories test surviving options is the controlling principle. After threshold screening, deontology tests duties and rights, consequentialism compares foreseeable outcomes, and virtue ethics asks what integrity, courage, compassion and practical wisdom require from the decision-maker. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 16

A response compares role duty, likely public harm and practical wisdom before choosing a hybrid course. Which combined method is being used? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A genuine personal, family or financial interest requires disclosure and withdrawal from the specific decision; confidence in one's own honesty cannot cure the appearance or structural risk of biased authority.
- B. Public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion may pull in different directions; the candidate should state which consideration is decisive in context and explain why the remaining concerns are mitigated rather than denied.
- C. An unlawful option is normally eliminated before ethical balancing, even when it appears compassionate or efficient; claimed benefits cannot convert absence of lawful authority into a permissible administrative response.
- D. After threshold screening, deontology tests duties and rights, consequentialism compares foreseeable outcomes, and virtue ethics asks what integrity, courage, compassion and practical wisdom require from the decision-maker.

Answer: D

Explanation: Moral theories test surviving options is the controlling principle. After threshold screening, deontology tests duties and rights, consequentialism compares foreseeable outcomes, and virtue ethics asks what integrity, courage, compassion and practical wisdom require from the decision-maker. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 17

A disaster answer treats personal grief as the only issue and ignores delegation fairness and public communication. Which technique was omitted? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. When a scenario contains analytically distinct tensions, each should receive a compact independent evaluation before the answers are recombined; this prevents one emotional conflict from obscuring resource, transparency or legality questions.
- B. Before closing, the answer should present the most credible objection to its chosen course and either defeat it with reasons or modify implementation to absorb its valid concern without abandoning the decision.
- C. A mature conclusion identifies the specific harm that may survive the preferred course, names a review or monitoring mechanism and assigns responsibility to a person or institution rather than claiming complete resolution.
- D. Residual risk equals inherent risk reduced by effective controls, while uncertainty and control failure remain visible; the expression disciplines mitigation but does not pretend ethical judgment can be reduced to arithmetic.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Nested dilemmas should be solved separately** is the controlling principle. When a scenario contains analytically distinct tensions, each should receive a compact independent evaluation before the answers are recombined; this prevents one emotional conflict from obscuring resource, transparency or legality questions. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 18

A candidate resolves command continuity, relief allocation and crisis communication separately, then integrates them. Which advanced discipline is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A mature conclusion identifies the specific harm that may survive the preferred course, names a review or monitoring mechanism and assigns responsibility to a person or institution rather than claiming complete resolution.
- B. When a scenario contains analytically distinct tensions, each should receive a compact independent evaluation before the answers are recombined; this prevents one emotional conflict from obscuring resource, transparency or legality questions.
- C. Residual risk equals inherent risk reduced by effective controls, while uncertainty and control failure remain visible; the expression disciplines mitigation but does not pretend ethical judgment can be reduced to arithmetic.
- D. Before closing, the answer should present the most credible objection to its chosen course and either defeat it with reasons or modify implementation to absorb its valid concern without abandoning the decision.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Nested dilemmas should be solved separately** is the controlling principle. When a scenario contains analytically distinct tensions, each should receive a compact independent evaluation before the answers are recombined; this prevents one emotional conflict from obscuring resource, transparency or legality questions. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 19

A sustainability proposal ignores the risk that costly commitments could destroy competitiveness. Which stress test is absent? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. When a scenario contains analytically distinct tensions, each should receive a compact independent evaluation before the answers are recombined; this prevents one emotional conflict from obscuring resource, transparency or legality questions.
- B. A mature conclusion identifies the specific harm that may survive the preferred course, names a review or monitoring mechanism and assigns responsibility to a person or institution rather than claiming complete resolution.
- C. Before closing, the answer should present the most credible objection to its chosen course and either defeat it with reasons or modify implementation to absorb its valid concern without abandoning the decision.
- D. Residual risk equals inherent risk reduced by effective controls, while uncertainty and control failure remain visible; the expression disciplines mitigation but does not pretend ethical judgment can be reduced to arithmetic.

Answer: C

Explanation: Steelmanning uses the strongest objection is the controlling principle. Before closing, the answer should present the most credible objection to its chosen course and either defeat it with reasons or modify implementation to absorb its valid concern without abandoning the decision. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 20

A decision adds time-bound milestones after accepting that an unlimited transition could be commercially destructive. Which reasoning device is applied? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A mature conclusion identifies the specific harm that may survive the preferred course, names a review or monitoring mechanism and assigns responsibility to a person or institution rather than claiming complete resolution.
- B. Residual risk equals inherent risk reduced by effective controls, while uncertainty and control failure remain visible; the expression disciplines mitigation but does not pretend ethical judgment can be reduced to arithmetic.
- C. When a scenario contains analytically distinct tensions, each should receive a compact independent evaluation before the answers are recombined; this prevents one emotional conflict from obscuring resource, transparency or legality questions.
- D. Before closing, the answer should present the most credible objection to its chosen course and either defeat it with reasons or modify implementation to absorb its valid concern without abandoning the decision.

Answer: D

Explanation: Steelmanning uses the strongest objection is the controlling principle. Before closing, the answer should present the most credible objection to its chosen course and either defeat it with reasons or modify implementation to absorb its valid concern without abandoning the decision. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 21

An answer ends with justice will prevail and names no remaining danger. Which closing discipline is missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A mature conclusion identifies the specific harm that may survive the preferred course, names a review or monitoring mechanism and assigns responsibility to a person or institution rather than claiming complete resolution.
- B. When a scenario contains analytically distinct tensions, each should receive a compact independent evaluation before the answers are recombined; this prevents one emotional conflict from obscuring resource, transparency or legality questions.
- C. Before closing, the answer should present the most credible objection to its chosen course and either defeat it with reasons or modify implementation to absorb its valid concern without abandoning the decision.
- D. Residual risk equals inherent risk reduced by effective controls, while uncertainty and control failure remain visible; the expression disciplines mitigation but does not pretend ethical judgment can be reduced to arithmetic.

Answer: A

Explanation: Residual risk must name monitoring and accountability is the controlling principle. A mature conclusion identifies the specific harm that may survive the preferred course, names a review or monitoring mechanism and assigns responsibility to a person or institution rather than claiming complete resolution. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 22

A delegated disaster command is followed by scheduled check-ins and a review led by the returning officer. Which closing formula is present? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Before closing, the answer should present the most credible objection to its chosen course and either defeat it with reasons or modify implementation to absorb its valid concern without abandoning the decision.
- B. A mature conclusion identifies the specific harm that may survive the preferred course, names a review or monitoring mechanism and assigns responsibility to a person or institution rather than claiming complete resolution.
- C. Residual risk equals inherent risk reduced by effective controls, while uncertainty and control failure remain visible; the expression disciplines mitigation but does not pretend ethical judgment can be reduced to arithmetic.
- D. When a scenario contains analytically distinct tensions, each should receive a compact independent evaluation before the answers are recombined; this prevents one emotional conflict from obscuring resource, transparency or legality questions.

Answer: B

Explanation: Residual risk must name monitoring and accountability is the controlling principle. A mature conclusion identifies the specific harm that may survive the preferred course, names a review or monitoring mechanism and assigns responsibility to a person or institution rather than claiming complete resolution. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 23

A candidate lists safeguards but never asks what danger remains if one safeguard fails. Which conceptual lens would improve the close? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. When a scenario contains analytically distinct tensions, each should receive a compact independent evaluation before the answers are recombined; this prevents one emotional conflict from obscuring resource, transparency or legality questions.
- B. Before closing, the answer should present the most credible objection to its chosen course and either defeat it with reasons or modify implementation to absorb its valid concern without abandoning the decision.
- C. Residual risk equals inherent risk reduced by effective controls, while uncertainty and control failure remain visible; the expression disciplines mitigation but does not pretend ethical judgment can be reduced to arithmetic.
- D. A mature conclusion identifies the specific harm that may survive the preferred course, names a review or monitoring mechanism and assigns responsibility to a person or institution rather than claiming complete resolution.

Answer: C

Explanation: Residual risk can be expressed as a control formula is the controlling principle. Residual risk equals inherent risk reduced by effective controls, while uncertainty and control failure remain visible; the expression disciplines mitigation but does not pretend ethical judgment can be reduced to arithmetic. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 24

A response names inherent retaliation risk, protection controls and the remaining exposure after those controls. Which formula is being operationalised? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Before closing, the answer should present the most credible objection to its chosen course and either defeat it with reasons or modify implementation to absorb its valid concern without abandoning the decision.
- B. A mature conclusion identifies the specific harm that may survive the preferred course, names a review or monitoring mechanism and assigns responsibility to a person or institution rather than claiming complete resolution.
- C. When a scenario contains analytically distinct tensions, each should receive a compact independent evaluation before the answers are recombined; this prevents one emotional conflict from obscuring resource, transparency or legality questions.
- D. Residual risk equals inherent risk reduced by effective controls, while uncertainty and control failure remain visible; the expression disciplines mitigation but does not pretend ethical judgment can be reduced to arithmetic.

Answer: D

Explanation: Residual risk can be expressed as a control formula is the controlling principle. Residual risk equals inherent risk reduced by effective controls, while uncertainty and control failure remain visible; the expression disciplines mitigation but does not pretend ethical judgment can be reduced to arithmetic. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 25

A procurement chair tells colleagues about her family link but continues scoring bids. Which steps remain incomplete? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A conflicted decision-maker should disclose the connection in writing, recuse from that matter, refer it to an untainted authority and ensure objective criteria govern the eventual decision and its defensibility.
- B. An officer facing an improper oral direction should record its substance, seek written confirmation, state the professional objection and use the normal escalation route while continuing lawful duties unless action would itself be unsafe.
- C. Evidence-based dissent normally moves from competent internal reporting to an independent internal tier, then to authorised external channels and only finally to public disclosure when serious continuing harm and failed alternatives justify it.
- D. Resignation becomes defensible only after lawful resistance and escalation are exhausted or unavailable, and when departure protects public interest better than remaining as a principled internal safeguard; it should not function as emotional escape.

Answer: A

Explanation: Conflict resolution follows **disclose, recuse, refer, publish** is the controlling principle. A conflicted decision-maker should disclose the connection in writing, recuse from that matter, refer it to an untainted authority and ensure objective criteria govern the eventual decision and its defensibility. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 26

A superior appoints an unconflicted committee that applies pre-announced criteria after the original chair withdraws. Which sequence is completed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Evidence-based dissent normally moves from competent internal reporting to an independent internal tier, then to authorised external channels and only finally to public disclosure when serious continuing harm and failed alternatives justify it.
- B. A conflicted decision-maker should disclose the connection in writing, recuse from that matter, refer it to an untainted authority and ensure objective criteria govern the eventual decision and its defensibility.
- C. Resignation becomes defensible only after lawful resistance and escalation are exhausted or unavailable, and when departure protects public interest better than remaining as a principled internal safeguard; it should not function as emotional escape.
- D. An officer facing an improper oral direction should record its substance, seek written confirmation, state the professional objection and use the normal escalation route while continuing lawful duties unless action would itself be unsafe.

Answer: B

Explanation: Conflict resolution follows **disclose, recuse, refer, publish** is the controlling principle. A conflicted decision-maker should disclose the connection in writing, recuse from that matter, refer it to an untainted authority and ensure objective criteria govern the eventual decision and its defensibility. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 27

A minister pressures an engineer verbally and the engineer merely refuses in private. Which protective administrative response is absent? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A conflicted decision-maker should disclose the connection in writing, recuse from that matter, refer it to an untainted authority and ensure objective criteria govern the eventual decision and its defensibility.
- B. Evidence-based dissent normally moves from competent internal reporting to an independent internal tier, then to authorised external channels and only finally to public disclosure when serious continuing harm and failed alternatives justify it.
- C. An officer facing an improper oral direction should record its substance, seek written confirmation, state the professional objection and use the normal escalation route while continuing lawful duties unless action would itself be unsafe.
- D. Resignation becomes defensible only after lawful resistance and escalation are exhausted or unavailable, and when departure protects public interest better than remaining as a principled internal safeguard; it should not function as emotional escape.

Answer: C

Explanation: Improper oral pressure should be converted into writing is the controlling principle. An officer facing an improper oral direction should record its substance, seek written confirmation, state the professional objection and use the normal escalation route while continuing lawful duties unless action would itself be unsafe. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 28

A professional records the instruction, technical risk and request for confirmation before escalating. Which method is correctly used? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Evidence-based dissent normally moves from competent internal reporting to an independent internal tier, then to authorised external channels and only finally to public disclosure when serious continuing harm and failed alternatives justify it.
- B. Resignation becomes defensible only after lawful resistance and escalation are exhausted or unavailable, and when departure protects public interest better than remaining as a principled internal safeguard; it should not function as emotional escape.
- C. A conflicted decision-maker should disclose the connection in writing, recuse from that matter, refer it to an untainted authority and ensure objective criteria govern the eventual decision and its defensibility.
- D. An officer facing an improper oral direction should record its substance, seek written confirmation, state the professional objection and use the normal escalation route while continuing lawful duties unless action would itself be unsafe.

Answer: D

Explanation: Improper oral pressure should be converted into writing is the controlling principle. An officer facing an improper oral direction should record its substance, seek written confirmation, state the professional objection and use the normal escalation route while continuing lawful duties unless action would itself be unsafe. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 29

An employee immediately posts confidential allegations online without testing safe lawful channels. Which escalation discipline was bypassed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Evidence-based dissent normally moves from competent internal reporting to an independent internal tier, then to authorised external channels and only finally to public disclosure when serious continuing harm and failed alternatives justify it.
- B. A conflicted decision-maker should disclose the connection in writing, recuse from that matter, refer it to an untainted authority and ensure objective criteria govern the eventual decision and its defensibility.
- C. An officer facing an improper oral direction should record its substance, seek written confirmation, state the professional objection and use the normal escalation route while continuing lawful duties unless action would itself be unsafe.
- D. Resignation becomes defensible only after lawful resistance and escalation are exhausted or unavailable, and when departure protects public interest better than remaining as a principled internal safeguard; it should not function as emotional escape.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Ethical dissent climbs a proportionate ladder** is the controlling principle. Evidence-based dissent normally moves from competent internal reporting to an independent internal tier, then to authorised external channels and only finally to public disclosure when serious continuing harm and failed alternatives justify it. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 30

A quality officer skips a compromised manager but reports to an independent regulator with preserved evidence. Which rung logic is followed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. An officer facing an improper oral direction should record its substance, seek written confirmation, state the professional objection and use the normal escalation route while continuing lawful duties unless action would itself be unsafe.
- B. Evidence-based dissent normally moves from competent internal reporting to an independent internal tier, then to authorised external channels and only finally to public disclosure when serious continuing harm and failed alternatives justify it.
- C. Resignation becomes defensible only after lawful resistance and escalation are exhausted or unavailable, and when departure protects public interest better than remaining as a principled internal safeguard; it should not function as emotional escape.
- D. A conflicted decision-maker should disclose the connection in writing, recuse from that matter, refer it to an untainted authority and ensure objective criteria govern the eventual decision and its defensibility.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Ethical dissent climbs a proportionate ladder** is the controlling principle. Evidence-based dissent normally moves from competent internal reporting to an independent internal tier, then to authorised external channels and only finally to public disclosure when serious continuing harm and failed alternatives justify it. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 31

An officer resigns before recording dissent although continued service could still block the wrongful act. Which evaluation error occurs? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A conflicted decision-maker should disclose the connection in writing, recuse from that matter, refer it to an untainted authority and ensure objective criteria govern the eventual decision and its defensibility.
- B. An officer facing an improper oral direction should record its substance, seek written confirmation, state the professional objection and use the normal escalation route while continuing lawful duties unless action would itself be unsafe.
- C. Resignation becomes defensible only after lawful resistance and escalation are exhausted or unavailable, and when departure protects public interest better than remaining as a principled internal safeguard; it should not function as emotional escape.
- D. Evidence-based dissent normally moves from competent internal reporting to an independent internal tier, then to authorised external channels and only finally to public disclosure when serious continuing harm and failed alternatives justify it.

Answer: C

Explanation: Resignation is an evaluated last resort is the controlling principle. Resignation becomes defensible only after lawful resistance and escalation are exhausted or unavailable, and when departure protects public interest better than remaining as a principled internal safeguard; it should not function as emotional escape. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 32

An official reserves resignation for a point at which personal execution of an unresolved illegality becomes unavoidable. Which test is applied? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. An officer facing an improper oral direction should record its substance, seek written confirmation, state the professional objection and use the normal escalation route while continuing lawful duties unless action would itself be unsafe.
- B. Evidence-based dissent normally moves from competent internal reporting to an independent internal tier, then to authorised external channels and only finally to public disclosure when serious continuing harm and failed alternatives justify it.
- C. A conflicted decision-maker should disclose the connection in writing, recuse from that matter, refer it to an untainted authority and ensure objective criteria govern the eventual decision and its defensibility.
- D. Resignation becomes defensible only after lawful resistance and escalation are exhausted or unavailable, and when departure protects public interest better than remaining as a principled internal safeguard; it should not function as emotional escape.

Answer: D

Explanation: Resignation is an evaluated last resort is the controlling principle. Resignation becomes defensible only after lawful resistance and escalation are exhausted or unavailable, and when departure protects public interest better than remaining as a principled internal safeguard; it should not function as emotional escape. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 33

A hospital allocates staff through undocumented personal discretion during a surge. Which triage safeguards are missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Scarce-resource allocation should use pre-announced, relevant and non-discriminatory criteria, record their actual application, provide an appropriate review route and revise them when resources or the emergency profile materially changes.
- B. A defensible allocation explains whether aggregate welfare, urgency, survivability, vulnerability or priority to the worst-off is being emphasised, then adds equity safeguards so the chosen metric does not become mechanically dehumanising.
- C. The same eight elements apply across administration, corporate governance, policing, research, health and environmental disputes, but legal authority, technical standards, affected stakeholders and competent institutions must be adapted to the domain.
- D. Under examination pressure, candidates should compress each architectural element rather than omit it: one-line facts and dilemma, a compact stakeholder-constraint map, three options, decisive checks, action steps and a residual-risk close.

Answer: A

Explanation: Triage criteria should be published and reviewable is the controlling principle. Scarce-resource allocation should use pre-announced, relevant and non-discriminatory criteria, record their actual application, provide an appropriate review route and revise them when resources or the emergency profile materially changes. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 34

A relief authority publishes need and vulnerability criteria, logs decisions and revisits them daily. Which method is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The same eight elements apply across administration, corporate governance, policing, research, health and environmental disputes, but legal authority, technical standards, affected stakeholders and competent institutions must be adapted to the domain.
- B. Scarce-resource allocation should use pre-announced, relevant and non-discriminatory criteria, record their actual application, provide an appropriate review route and revise them when resources or the emergency profile materially changes.
- C. Under examination pressure, candidates should compress each architectural element rather than omit it: one-line facts and dilemma, a compact stakeholder-constraint map, three options, decisive checks, action steps and a residual-risk close.
- D. A defensible allocation explains whether aggregate welfare, urgency, survivability, vulnerability or priority to the worst-off is being emphasised, then adds equity safeguards so the chosen metric does not become mechanically dehumanising.

Answer: B

Explanation: Triage criteria should be published and reviewable is the controlling principle. Scarce-resource allocation should use pre-announced, relevant and non-discriminatory criteria, record their actual application, provide an appropriate review route and revise them when resources or the emergency profile materially changes. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 35

A candidate calls a severity score ethically neutral although it disadvantages a patient group. Which analysis is missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Scarce-resource allocation should use pre-announced, relevant and non-discriminatory criteria, record their actual application, provide an appropriate review route and revise them when resources or the emergency profile materially changes.
- B. The same eight elements apply across administration, corporate governance, policing, research, health and environmental disputes, but legal authority, technical standards, affected stakeholders and competent institutions must be adapted to the domain.
- C. A defensible allocation explains whether aggregate welfare, urgency, survivability, vulnerability or priority to the worst-off is being emphasised, then adds equity safeguards so the chosen metric does not become mechanically dehumanising.
- D. Under examination pressure, candidates should compress each architectural element rather than omit it: one-line facts and dilemma, a compact stakeholder-constraint map, three options, decisive checks, action steps and a residual-risk close.

Answer: C

Explanation: Triage must acknowledge its value trade-off is the controlling principle. A defensible allocation explains whether aggregate welfare, urgency, survivability, vulnerability or priority to the worst-off is being emphasised, then adds equity safeguards so the chosen metric does not become mechanically dehumanising. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 36

A committee prioritises urgent survivability while auditing disparate impact on vulnerable patients. Which ethical balance is achieved? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The same eight elements apply across administration, corporate governance, policing, research, health and environmental disputes, but legal authority, technical standards, affected stakeholders and competent institutions must be adapted to the domain.
- B. Under examination pressure, candidates should compress each architectural element rather than omit it: one-line facts and dilemma, a compact stakeholder-constraint map, three options, decisive checks, action steps and a residual-risk close.
- C. Scarce-resource allocation should use pre-announced, relevant and non-discriminatory criteria, record their actual application, provide an appropriate review route and revise them when resources or the emergency profile materially changes.
- D. A defensible allocation explains whether aggregate welfare, urgency, survivability, vulnerability or priority to the worst-off is being emphasised, then adds equity safeguards so the chosen metric does not become mechanically dehumanising.

Answer: D

Explanation: Triage must acknowledge its value trade-off is the controlling principle. A defensible allocation explains whether aggregate welfare, urgency, survivability, vulnerability or priority to the worst-off is being emphasised, then adds equity safeguards so the chosen metric does not become mechanically dehumanising. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 37

A candidate copies a public procurement remedy into a clinical-consent dispute without naming the ethics committee. Which adaptation error occurs? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The same eight elements apply across administration, corporate governance, policing, research, health and environmental disputes, but legal authority, technical standards, affected stakeholders and competent institutions must be adapted to the domain.
- B. Scarce-resource allocation should use pre-announced, relevant and non-discriminatory criteria, record their actual application, provide an appropriate review route and revise them when resources or the emergency profile materially changes.
- C. A defensible allocation explains whether aggregate welfare, urgency, survivability, vulnerability or priority to the worst-off is being emphasised, then adds equity safeguards so the chosen metric does not become mechanically dehumanising.
- D. Under examination pressure, candidates should compress each architectural element rather than omit it: one-line facts and dilemma, a compact stakeholder-constraint map, three options, decisive checks, action steps and a residual-risk close.

Answer: A

Explanation: Domain adaptation preserves the architecture is the controlling principle. The same eight elements apply across administration, corporate governance, policing, research, health and environmental disputes, but legal authority, technical standards, affected stakeholders and competent institutions must be adapted to the domain. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 38

A research case uses the common decision sequence but routes consent and data concerns to the competent ethics body. Which transfer skill is shown? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A defensible allocation explains whether aggregate welfare, urgency, survivability, vulnerability or priority to the worst-off is being emphasised, then adds equity safeguards so the chosen metric does not become mechanically dehumanising.
- B. The same eight elements apply across administration, corporate governance, policing, research, health and environmental disputes, but legal authority, technical standards, affected stakeholders and competent institutions must be adapted to the domain.
- C. Under examination pressure, candidates should compress each architectural element rather than omit it: one-line facts and dilemma, a compact stakeholder-constraint map, three options, decisive checks, action steps and a residual-risk close.
- D. Scarce-resource allocation should use pre-announced, relevant and non-discriminatory criteria, record their actual application, provide an appropriate review route and revise them when resources or the emergency profile materially changes.

Answer: B

Explanation: Domain adaptation preserves the architecture is the controlling principle. The same eight elements apply across administration, corporate governance, policing, research, health and environmental disputes, but legal authority, technical standards, affected stakeholders and competent institutions must be adapted to the domain. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 39

A candidate spends most of the answer narrating facts and has no space for implementation. Which time management correction is needed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Scarce-resource allocation should use pre-announced, relevant and non-discriminatory criteria, record their actual application, provide an appropriate review route and revise them when resources or the emergency profile materially changes.
- B. A defensible allocation explains whether aggregate welfare, urgency, survivability, vulnerability or priority to the worst-off is being emphasised, then adds equity safeguards so the chosen metric does not become mechanically dehumanising.
- C. Under examination pressure, candidates should compress each architectural element rather than omit it: one-line facts and dilemma, a compact stakeholder-constraint map, three options, decisive checks, action steps and a residual-risk close.
- D. The same eight elements apply across administration, corporate governance, policing, research, health and environmental disputes, but legal authority, technical standards, affected stakeholders and competent institutions must be adapted to the domain.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Time pressure changes depth, not sequence** is the controlling principle. Under examination pressure, candidates should compress each architectural element rather than omit it: one-line facts and dilemma, a compact stakeholder-constraint map, three options, decisive checks, action steps and a residual-risk close. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 40

A twenty-mark response uses short labelled blocks while retaining all eight elements. Which examination principle is followed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A defensible allocation explains whether aggregate welfare, urgency, survivability, vulnerability or priority to the worst-off is being emphasised, then adds equity safeguards so the chosen metric does not become mechanically dehumanising.
- B. The same eight elements apply across administration, corporate governance, policing, research, health and environmental disputes, but legal authority, technical standards, affected stakeholders and competent institutions must be adapted to the domain.
- C. Scarce-resource allocation should use pre-announced, relevant and non-discriminatory criteria, record their actual application, provide an appropriate review route and revise them when resources or the emergency profile materially changes.
- D. Under examination pressure, candidates should compress each architectural element rather than omit it: one-line facts and dilemma, a compact stakeholder-constraint map, three options, decisive checks, action steps and a residual-risk close.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Time pressure changes depth, not sequence** is the controlling principle. Under examination pressure, candidates should compress each architectural element rather than omit it: one-line facts and dilemma, a compact stakeholder-constraint map, three options, decisive checks, action steps and a residual-risk close. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 41

An answer lists every value but refuses to choose among feasible options. Which decision-writing defect remains? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A recommendation should name the selected option, the threshold or weighted consideration that controls the choice and the safeguard answering the strongest objection; merely saying balance all interests does not decide the case.
- B. Implementation should specify immediate and later actions, competent actors, documentation and communication to seniors, team members and affected people; a morally attractive choice without an execution route remains administratively incomplete.
- C. Crisis communication should disclose verified information, acknowledge uncertainty, prevent avoidable panic and commit to updates; neither premature certainty nor prolonged concealment protects trust when facts are still developing.
- D. The final verdict should be decisive but not absolute: it should connect lawful action, public purpose, proportionate safeguards and review, showing confidence in the chosen route while accepting that implementation requires continuing ethical oversight.

Answer: A

Explanation: Decision writing should identify the decisive reason is the controlling principle. A recommendation should name the selected option, the threshold or weighted consideration that controls the choice and the safeguard answering the strongest objection; merely saying balance all interests does not decide the case. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 42

A response selects lawful phased repair because urgency and proportionality control after sanction evasion is removed. Which clarity is demonstrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Crisis communication should disclose verified information, acknowledge uncertainty, prevent avoidable panic and commit to updates; neither premature certainty nor prolonged concealment protects trust when facts are still developing.
- B. A recommendation should name the selected option, the threshold or weighted consideration that controls the choice and the safeguard answering the strongest objection; merely saying balance all interests does not decide the case.
- C. The final verdict should be decisive but not absolute: it should connect lawful action, public purpose, proportionate safeguards and review, showing confidence in the chosen route while accepting that implementation requires continuing ethical oversight.
- D. Implementation should specify immediate and later actions, competent actors, documentation and communication to seniors, team members and affected people; a morally attractive choice without an execution route remains administratively incomplete.

Answer: B

Explanation: Decision writing should identify the decisive reason is the controlling principle. A recommendation should name the selected option, the threshold or weighted consideration that controls the choice and the safeguard answering the strongest objection; merely saying balance all interests does not decide the case. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 43

A district officer chooses evacuation but never identifies transport, command or public messaging. Which element is incomplete? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A recommendation should name the selected option, the threshold or weighted consideration that controls the choice and the safeguard answering the strongest objection; merely saying balance all interests does not decide the case.
- B. Crisis communication should disclose verified information, acknowledge uncertainty, prevent avoidable panic and commit to updates; neither premature certainty nor prolonged concealment protects trust when facts are still developing.
- C. Implementation should specify immediate and later actions, competent actors, documentation and communication to seniors, team members and affected people; a morally attractive choice without an execution route remains administratively incomplete.
- D. The final verdict should be decisive but not absolute: it should connect lawful action, public purpose, proportionate safeguards and review, showing confidence in the chosen route while accepting that implementation requires continuing ethical oversight.

Answer: C

Explanation: Implementation must assign actions and audiences is the controlling principle. Implementation should specify immediate and later actions, competent actors, documentation and communication to seniors, team members and affected people; a morally attractive choice without an execution route remains administratively incomplete. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 44

A decision names the deputy, written delegation, check-in schedule and public notice. Which implementation discipline is present? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Crisis communication should disclose verified information, acknowledge uncertainty, prevent avoidable panic and commit to updates; neither premature certainty nor prolonged concealment protects trust when facts are still developing.
- B. The final verdict should be decisive but not absolute: it should connect lawful action, public purpose, proportionate safeguards and review, showing confidence in the chosen route while accepting that implementation requires continuing ethical oversight.
- C. A recommendation should name the selected option, the threshold or weighted consideration that controls the choice and the safeguard answering the strongest objection; merely saying balance all interests does not decide the case.
- D. Implementation should specify immediate and later actions, competent actors, documentation and communication to seniors, team members and affected people; a morally attractive choice without an execution route remains administratively incomplete.

Answer: D

Explanation: Implementation must assign actions and audiences is the controlling principle. Implementation should specify immediate and later actions, competent actors, documentation and communication to seniors, team members and affected people; a morally attractive choice without an execution route remains administratively incomplete. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 45

An administrator repeats an unverified viral claim to appear transparent. Which communication mistake is made? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Crisis communication should disclose verified information, acknowledge uncertainty, prevent avoidable panic and commit to updates; neither premature certainty nor prolonged concealment protects trust when facts are still developing.
- B. A recommendation should name the selected option, the threshold or weighted consideration that controls the choice and the safeguard answering the strongest objection; merely saying balance all interests does not decide the case.
- C. Implementation should specify immediate and later actions, competent actors, documentation and communication to seniors, team members and affected people; a morally attractive choice without an execution route remains administratively incomplete.
- D. The final verdict should be decisive but not absolute: it should connect lawful action, public purpose, proportionate safeguards and review, showing confidence in the chosen route while accepting that implementation requires continuing ethical oversight.

Answer: A

Explanation: Communication should be honest and calibrated is the controlling principle. Crisis communication should disclose verified information, acknowledge uncertainty, prevent avoidable panic and commit to updates; neither premature certainty nor prolonged concealment protects trust when facts are still developing. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 46

An official states what is known, what is being checked and when the next update will come. Which weighted balance is shown? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Implementation should specify immediate and later actions, competent actors, documentation and communication to seniors, team members and affected people; a morally attractive choice without an execution route remains administratively incomplete.
- B. Crisis communication should disclose verified information, acknowledge uncertainty, prevent avoidable panic and commit to updates; neither premature certainty nor prolonged concealment protects trust when facts are still developing.
- C. The final verdict should be decisive but not absolute: it should connect lawful action, public purpose, proportionate safeguards and review, showing confidence in the chosen route while accepting that implementation requires continuing ethical oversight.
- D. A recommendation should name the selected option, the threshold or weighted consideration that controls the choice and the safeguard answering the strongest objection; merely saying balance all interests does not decide the case.

Answer: B

Explanation: Communication should be honest and calibrated is the controlling principle. Crisis communication should disclose verified information, acknowledge uncertainty, prevent avoidable panic and commit to updates; neither premature certainty nor prolonged concealment protects trust when facts are still developing. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 47

A candidate claims the chosen option permanently eliminates every risk. Which concluding flaw appears? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A recommendation should name the selected option, the threshold or weighted consideration that controls the choice and the safeguard answering the strongest objection; merely saying balance all interests does not decide the case.
- B. Implementation should specify immediate and later actions, competent actors, documentation and communication to seniors, team members and affected people; a morally attractive choice without an execution route remains administratively incomplete.
- C. The final verdict should be decisive but not absolute: it should connect lawful action, public purpose, proportionate safeguards and review, showing confidence in the chosen route while accepting that implementation requires continuing ethical oversight.
- D. Crisis communication should disclose verified information, acknowledge uncertainty, prevent avoidable panic and commit to updates; neither premature certainty nor prolonged concealment protects trust when facts are still developing.

Answer: C

Explanation: A complete answer ends with qualified confidence is the controlling principle. The final verdict should be decisive but not absolute: it should connect lawful action, public purpose, proportionate safeguards and review, showing confidence in the chosen route while accepting that implementation requires continuing ethical oversight. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 48

A response commits to a course while naming review triggers and accountability. Which mature conclusion is being used? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Implementation should specify immediate and later actions, competent actors, documentation and communication to seniors, team members and affected people; a morally attractive choice without an execution route remains administratively incomplete.
- B. Crisis communication should disclose verified information, acknowledge uncertainty, prevent avoidable panic and commit to updates; neither premature certainty nor prolonged concealment protects trust when facts are still developing.
- C. A recommendation should name the selected option, the threshold or weighted consideration that controls the choice and the safeguard answering the strongest objection; merely saying balance all interests does not decide the case.
- D. The final verdict should be decisive but not absolute: it should connect lawful action, public purpose, proportionate safeguards and review, showing confidence in the chosen route while accepting that implementation requires continuing ethical oversight.

Answer: D

Explanation: A complete answer ends with qualified confidence is the controlling principle. The final verdict should be decisive but not absolute: it should connect lawful action, public purpose, proportionate safeguards and review, showing confidence in the chosen route while accepting that implementation requires continuing ethical oversight. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 - 20 marks

Question: Neutral routing of GS-IV Q8: a senior Ministry officer with privileged policy knowledge faces a Minister's request to alter a road alignment near the Minister's farm and an offer of land in the officer's wife's name. Analyse the conflict and response.

Source / ownership: Neutral demand verified against books\more_previous_papers\GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf, page 7. OCR quality is uneven, so this entry does not claim verbatim reproduction.

Model solution

Facts: A public decision is being pressed toward private ministerial gain, while a benefit is offered through the officer's spouse. **Stakeholders:** road users, affected landholders, taxpayers, the Ministry, the Minister, the officer and family, and institutional trust. **Constraints:** the officer cannot redesign policy for private advantage; official information and delegated authority must be used only for public purpose.

Options: comply and accept the land; refuse orally but leave no record; or decline the benefit, record the request and technical objection, preserve the original evaluation, and refer the matter through the competent hierarchy or vigilance channel. The first option fails legality and conflict-of-interest thresholds. The second is personally clean but institutionally weak. The third best serves legality, public interest and transparency.

Decision: reject the offer, disclose the attempted inducement, avoid any personal participation tainted by it, and insist that alignment be assessed through published technical and social criteria. The strongest objection is that recording a Minister's request may trigger retaliation; that risk does not justify silent compliance and is reduced by contemporaneous documentation and collective technical review.

Implementation: make a dated written note, seek written confirmation of any contrary direction, secure maps and evaluation records, and escalate through the normal reporting and oversight route. **Residual risk:** political transfer or manipulation of later appraisal remains; the Secretary or competent vigilance authority should monitor the record and audit the final alignment decision.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2019 - 20 marks

Question: Neutral routing of GS-IV Q7: a rescue officer's team is attacked by an angry crowd during a severe natural calamity, and some personnel want operations withdrawn. Evaluate the options and the public-service qualities required.

Source / ownership: Neutral demand verified against

books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-IV.pdf, page 4. The official printed scenario controls all details.

Model solution

Facts: essential rescue work faces violence from distressed citizens, and team safety is now part of the operational dilemma. **Stakeholders:** trapped victims, the crowd, rescue staff and families, local administration, police and the wider disaster response. **Constraints:** the duty to rescue continues, but the leader cannot recklessly expose personnel or abandon victims without exploring safer alternatives.

Options: withdraw completely; continue unchanged despite attack; or pause locally, establish security and communication, engage credible community representatives, redesign deployment and resume priority rescue. Complete withdrawal sacrifices public duty; unchanged deployment is disproportionate to staff risk. The sequenced option best combines courage, empathy, prudence, team leadership and public interest.

Decision: maintain the mission through a safer operational plan. **Steelman:** any pause may cost lives. Therefore the pause must be minimal, rescue of immediately endangered persons must continue where feasible, and police/community liaison must work in parallel rather than sequentially.

Implementation: brief staff, create protected corridors, deploy medical and police support, use local leaders to communicate priorities, document assaults and rotate exhausted teams. **Residual risk:** renewed violence or distrust may disrupt access; the incident commander should maintain live risk review, community liaison and after-action learning while remaining personally accountable for both rescue continuity and team safety.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2020 - 20 marks

Question: Neutral routing of GS-IV Q7: Finance Ministry officer Rajesh Kumar is pressed to re-appropriate welfare funds toward favoured development projects and must evaluate ethical issues, available options and whether resignation is worthy.

Source / ownership: Neutral demand verified against books\more_previous_papers\Gen_St_P4.pdf, pages 4-5. Wording is condensed; the local official paper remains authoritative.

Model solution

Facts: a welfare allocation is proposed for re-appropriation to other projects under senior pressure. **Stakeholders:** intended health beneficiaries, project beneficiaries, Parliament, taxpayers, Ministry leadership and Rajesh. **Constraints:** he lacks unilateral authority to stop the decision; procedural permissibility does not itself establish propriety; the budget window is limited.

Options: comply silently; leak externally; resign immediately; or record a reasoned welfare-impact objection, seek written confirmation and escalate through financial, audit and competent oversight channels while continuing lawful duties. Silent compliance fails public interest and transparency. A leak bypasses lawful routes. Immediate resignation removes a principled internal voice before resistance has been tested.

Decision: choose written dissent and time-bound escalation. The decisive checks are public purpose and transparency, because legality may not clearly eliminate the proposal. **Steelman:** internal channels may be captured and delay can consummate diversion. Rajesh should therefore set a short response period and ensure the objection enters the independent audit trail.

Implementation: attach beneficiary and fiscal impact, request a speaking direction, refer to the competent financial authority, and refuse to certify facts he knows are false. Resignation remains a last resort if all lawful channels fail and continued office would compel personal execution or legitimisation of the wrong. **Residual risk:** retaliation or formal

override remains; a named senior financial authority and later audit should review the decision and preserved dissent.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2021 - 20 marks

Question: Neutral routing of GS-IV Q10: a hospital administrator must devise and justify criteria for deploying scarce clinical and non-clinical staff during a COVID-19 surge and consider whether a private hospital changes the ethical justification.

Source / ownership: Neutral demand verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-21-GENSTUDIESPAPER-IV-110122.pdf, page 8. The official scenario controls the precise subparts.

Model solution

Facts: demand exceeds safe staffing capacity during an infectious-disease emergency. Stakeholders: patients, clinical and non-clinical staff, vulnerable groups, families, management and the public health system. Constraints: skills are not interchangeable, exposure risk is unequal, fatigue impairs care, and decisions must be made rapidly with incomplete forecasts.

Options: deploy volunteers ad hoc; allocate only by seniority; maximise immediate clinical throughput without equity safeguards; or publish clinically relevant criteria covering competence, urgency, exposure, rotation, vulnerability and continuity, with review and grievance mechanisms. Ad hoc and seniority-only methods are arbitrary; pure throughput can devalue vulnerable patients and exhaust staff.

Decision: use transparent, competence-based and equity-audited triage. Consequentialism supports saving the most lives and maintaining service; duty ethics protects non-discrimination and staff safety; compassion requires protection for high-risk workers. Steelman: rigid criteria may become obsolete as the surge changes. A fixed review cycle and incident-command discretion with written reasons answer it.

Implementation: publish the matrix, train deployment teams, provide protective equipment, rotate exposure, preserve surge reserves and communicate individual decisions respectfully. The ethical floor does not fall in a private hospital: ownership may change internal resourcing discretion, not duties of non-discrimination, safety and honest criteria during a public-health emergency. Residual risk: metric bias or sudden absenteeism remains; a multidisciplinary triage committee should audit outcomes daily and revise criteria openly.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2022 - 20 marks

Question: Neutral routing of GS-IV Q9: an investigative journalist uncovers a stone-mining mafia linked with police, civil officials and political influence, while the media owner pressures the journalist to suppress the report.

Source / ownership: Neutral demand verified against

books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-22-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER IV-190922.pdf, page 10. This is a faithful routing, not a verbatim copy.

Model solution

Facts: alleged illegal mining is protected by a network that may compromise ordinary reporting channels, and the journalist faces inducement or suppression. Stakeholders: affected communities, workers, environment, honest officials, sources, the journalist, the media institution and justice agencies. Constraints: allegations need authentication; source safety and evidence integrity may be lost through premature publication; local enforcement may be captured.

Options: suppress the story; publish sensationally at once; resign without preserving evidence; or authenticate and duplicate records, obtain independent legal-editorial review, assess threats, use authorised regulatory or judicial channels, and publish responsibly when source and investigation risks are controlled. Suppression enables harm; impulsive disclosure may expose sources and destroy the case.

Decision: follow a protected dissent ladder, skipping the compromised internal rung but preferring an independent lawful channel before unrestricted disclosure. Steelman: delay allows continuing extraction and evidence destruction. The response therefore requires immediate preservation, parallel referral and a defined publication decision point.

Implementation: keep dated copies, separate source identity, inform an independent editor or professional body, seek security if threats are credible, and route evidence to the competent State authority or court with jurisdiction. Residual risk: retaliation, institutional capture and source exposure remain; an independent legal representative should maintain an access log and review safety and follow-up at fixed intervals.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2023 - 20 marks

Question: Neutral routing of GS-IV Q10: an honest IAS officer serving as Managing Director of a State Road Transport Corporation faces a corrupt, politically powerful Chairman and separate pressure from an Opposition party.

Source / ownership: Neutral demand verified against

books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-23-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV-180923.pdf, pages 10-11. The official paper remains controlling.

Model solution

Facts: the Managing Director faces suspected corruption from the Chairman and partisan pressure from the Opposition. Stakeholders: commuters, employees, taxpayers, vendors, the Corporation, both political actors and the officer. Constraints: the officer cannot remove the Chairman alone, must verify specific irregularities and must preserve political neutrality while services continue.

Options: comply with the Chairman; hand internal records to the Opposition; resign immediately; or document each irregular direction, seek written clarification, protect decisions within lawful authority and escalate through audit, vigilance and the administrative department. Compliance breaches public trust. A partisan leak compromises neutrality. Resignation is premature while institutional resistance remains.

Decision: choose documented, non-partisan escalation. Legality and procurement propriety screen verified wrongdoing; transparency and public interest guide the response. Steelman: internal channels may be delayed by political influence. The answer is a time-bound referral with independent record preservation, not a political counter-alliance.

Implementation: record oral pressures, seek written orders, decline political sharing outside lawful disclosure, secure procurement records and maintain service delivery. If the normal recipient is compromised, move to the next independent vigilance or statutory tier. Residual risk: transfer, slow-walking and continuing loss remain; a competent

external oversight authority should acknowledge the referral, monitor deadlines and audit affected contracts.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2024 - 20 marks

Question: Neutral routing of GS-IV Q7: ABC Incorporated must respond to rapid AI expansion, a substantial increase in greenhouse-gas emissions, a net-zero commitment, innovation pressure and proposed environmental penalties.

Source / ownership: Neutral demand verified against books\mains\05 UPSC 2024 Paper-IV_Final 1.pdf, page 4. Numerical and contextual details should be taken from that official paper.

Model solution

Facts: AI-related data-centre growth conflicts with a public climate commitment and commercial competition.

Stakeholders: communities, workers, customers, shareholders, regulators, suppliers and future generations.

Constraints: the company cannot treat a pledge as performance, but an abrupt shutdown could destroy useful innovation and employment; measurement boundaries must be credible.

Options: continue and manage publicity; halt AI growth; rely mainly on offsets; or adopt independently verified absolute and intensity targets for efficiency, cleaner power, water, hardware and supply chains while continuing calibrated innovation. Inaction risks greenwashing; a total halt may be disproportionate; offset-only action leaves underlying demand unchanged.

Decision: choose the time-bound verified transition. Public interest, intergenerational justice and transparency outweigh short-term cost, while proportionality preserves innovation. Steelman: competitors without similar costs may erode the firm's market position and future capacity to invest. Milestones should therefore be ambitious but sequenced, technology-neutral and reviewed against both environmental and commercial evidence.

Implementation: commission external assurance, publish assumptions, link executive accountability to targets, price environmental costs into investment and support proportionate penalties with due process and equal criteria. Residual risk: clean-power scarcity and rebound demand may defeat efficiency gains; the board sustainability committee should monitor absolute emissions and trigger corrective capital allocation when the pathway is missed.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2024 - 20 marks

Question: Neutral routing of GS-IV Q10: Sneha chairs a hospital procurement process in which her financially stressed brother is a bidder, while management says it will support whatever decision she takes.

Source / ownership: Neutral demand verified against books\mains\05 UPSC 2024 Paper-IV_Final 1.pdf, page 8. The entry is condensed to preserve neutral routing.

Model solution

Facts: Sneha exercises procurement influence while a close family member competes for financial benefit.

Stakeholders: patients, hospital management, all bidders, her brother, Sneha and institutional credibility. Constraints: management trust does not remove the conflict; procurement must conclude on time and against defensible quality and cost criteria.

Options: score all bids herself; secretly disadvantage her brother; ask him to withdraw informally; or disclose the relationship in writing, recuse, refer evaluation to an unconflicted authority and apply pre-announced criteria. The first two options remain biased in opposite directions. Informal withdrawal solves one outcome but leaves no durable process.

Decision: disclose, recuse, refer and publish or consistently apply the criteria. Conflict of interest is a hard threshold; claimed personal integrity cannot make continued participation legitimate. Steelman: recusal may reveal private family hardship and delay urgently needed supplies. Disclosure should be limited to what the competent authority needs, and an alternate evaluator should be appointed immediately.

Implementation: record the relationship before final evaluation, cease all influence, preserve bid confidentiality and communicate the result uniformly. Residual risk: bidders may still perceive concealed influence or reverse discrimination. Management's compliance or audit function should review the scoring trail and require the same recusal in future tenders involving the brother.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2024 - 20 marks

Question: Neutral routing of GS-IV Q12: Dr Srinivasan faces pressure to accelerate a biotechnology trial despite deficiencies in informed consent and the exclusion of an unfavourable data point.

Source / ownership: Neutral demand verified against books\mains\05 UPSC 2024 Paper-IV_Final 1.pdf, page 9. The official paper controls the full narrative and subparts.

Model solution

Facts: vulnerable participants may not have received adequate informed consent, and unfavourable evidence has been excluded under commercial pressure. Stakeholders: participants, future patients, research staff, the ethics committee, regulator, company and scientific community. Constraints: valid consent and data integrity are threshold requirements; the scientist cannot alone substitute for the competent ethics body.

Options: continue unchanged; retrospectively regularise records; halt everything unilaterally; or disclose both lapses, restore the complete dataset, protect participants and ask the ethics committee to decide re-consent, suspension or continuation. Concealment and falsification fail legality and research ethics. Unilateral action may exceed role authority and weaken institutional review.

Decision: immediate written disclosure and referral to the ethics committee, with no further compromised enrolment. Duty to participants and truth in science outweigh timeline pressure. Steelman: interruption may delay a beneficial treatment and impose costs on participants already enrolled. The committee should therefore conduct urgent, evidence-based review rather than accept either concealment or indefinite delay.

Implementation: secure raw data, stop improper recruitment, arrange independent re-consent where directed, inform the board that continuation is institutionally controlled and protect reporters from retaliation. Residual risk: re-consent may itself pressure vulnerable participants and restored data may be mishandled; the ethics committee should appoint an independent monitor and conduct a follow-up site audit.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2025 - 20 marks

Question: Neutral routing of GS-IV Q7: Deputy Commissioner Vijay leads relief after a devastating hill disaster when his mother dies far away and the crisis worsens, creating competing personal and public duties.

Source / ownership: Neutral demand verified against books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf, pages 4-5. The canonical Basic treatment supplies the controlling case method.

Model solution

Facts: Vijay directs continuing relief amid renewed danger, disrupted communications and personal bereavement. Stakeholders: victims, relief teams, his family, the deputy command, seniors and Vijay's wellbeing. Constraints: relief cannot pause; travel and communication are uncertain; any absence requires authorised, competent and recorded delegation.

Options: leave immediately through informal handover; remain and abandon the rites; rely only on remote management; or make a brief authorised absence after written delegation, intensive briefing and scheduled remote oversight. Nested dilemmas must be separated: personal duty versus public duty, fairness in relief allocation, and truthful communication versus public calm.

Decision: choose brief, tightly controlled delegation if a competent deputy and communications are genuinely available; otherwise remain until those safeguards exist. No illegality decides the case, so proportionality, continuity and compassion are weighted. Steelman: any absence during resumed rain may create a fatal command gap. Clear authority limits, check-ins and immediate return triggers convert that objection into design conditions.

Implementation: obtain senior authorisation, issue written delegation, publish the command arrangement internally, preserve existing triage criteria and define escalation triggers. Residual risk: deputy error or sudden deterioration survives; Vijay should maintain check-ins, return on trigger and personally lead an after-action review of decisions taken during the absence.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2025 - 20 marks

Question: Neutral routing of GS-IV Q9: PWD Secretary Subash holds confidential road-alignment information sought by his real-estate businessman son, while a Minister also signals that a relative's company should receive favourable treatment.

Source / ownership: Neutral demand verified against books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf, page 7. The local official paper and canonical Basic treatment control details.

Model solution

Facts: Subash faces two linked improprieties: family demand for privileged information and ministerial pressure favouring a connected company. **Stakeholders:** landowners, bidders, taxpayers, the son and nephew, PWD staff, the Minister, Subash and public trust. **Constraints:** confidential information cannot be shared; tender and land decisions must use lawful authority and objective criteria.

Options: disclose selectively; refuse privately but continue alone; transfer the whole responsibility without explanation; or record both approaches, refuse disclosure, declare the family connection, recuse where that connection touches the decision, and route evaluation through an untainted committee using published criteria. Private refusal leaves pressure undocumented; unexplained transfer weakens accountability.

Decision: use the conflict sequence and written-order response together. Legality and conflict are hard thresholds, so family loyalty, secrecy assurances or political convenience cannot outweigh them. **Steelman:** formal escalation may damage working relations and delay a strategic project. Immediate committee-based routing and a concise professional record preserve both speed and integrity.

Implementation: secure alignment data, restrict access, seek written confirmation of improper directions, notify the competent superior or vigilance authority and audit communications and bid evaluation. **Residual risk:** proxies may still trade on leaked information or influence specifications. An independent procurement and land-acquisition review should monitor access logs, criteria and beneficial-interest declarations.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 12 - 2025 - 20 marks

Question: Neutral routing of GS-IV Q10: engineer Rajesh faces an urgent culvert repair whose true cost exceeds delegated financial power, and a contractor proposes splitting the work to avoid superior sanction.

Source / ownership: Neutral demand verified against books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf, pages 8-9. Exact monetary and procedural facts must be checked in the official paper.

Model solution

Facts: public safety requires urgent repair, but the genuine requirement exceeds Rajesh's delegated authority and the contractor proposes artificial splitting. **Stakeholders:** commuters, nearby residents, contractors, the superior sanctioning authority, audit and Rajesh. **Constraints:** urgency is real; evading delegation is impermissible; only technically separable emergency work may be considered within existing power under the applicable procedure.

Options: split the same requirement; wait passively for normal sanction; undertake the full repair without authority; or record the danger, refer the full estimate urgently and execute only independently justified temporary stabilisation within lawful power while the permanent work is approved. Artificial splitting fails the legality and propriety threshold. Passive delay disregards foreseeable harm.

Decision: choose the phased lawful response only if engineering evidence establishes genuinely separate stabilisation. Public interest and proportionality then control among lawful options. **Steelman:** phasing may itself disguise splitting. Independent technical reasons, superior notice and later audit must therefore precede execution.

Implementation: send the full estimate and safety report immediately, document scope boundaries, use no contractor-designed paperwork, communicate temporary restrictions and seek expedited sanction. **Residual risk:** temporary work may fail or be perceived as evasion; the superior engineer should approve monitoring, inspect milestones and require internal audit before closure.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Explain why hard constraints should be mapped before options are generated in a GS-IV case study. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Hard constraints convert an ethical narrative into an administratively realistic decision. They include legality, delegated authority, jurisdiction, time, information, resources and institutional capacity. If a district officer lacks statutory power, an attractive promise cannot become a valid option merely because it appears compassionate.

The correct sequence is elimination before balancing. An unlawful disclosure, a conflicted decision or expenditure beyond delegated power is removed first. The surviving courses can then be compared through public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion. This prevents candidates from wasting words evaluating impossible choices.

Constraint mapping also improves hybrid design. An engineer may not sanction an entire urgent work, yet may lawfully secure a genuinely separable temporary stabilisation while referring the permanent repair upward. Thus constraints do not always paralyse action; they define the lawful space within which practical wisdom operates. A high-quality answer names the binding constraint, the competent authority and the feasible route around delay without evasion.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 10 marks

Question: Distinguish hard-threshold checks from weighted checks in ethical case analysis. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Hard-threshold checks determine whether an option may remain under consideration. Legality is the clearest example: expected welfare cannot authorise an unlawful act. A genuine conflict of interest is similarly near-disqualifying; the officer must disclose and recuse rather than claim personal objectivity.

Weighted checks compare options that survive. Public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion can conflict. During triage, maximising lives saved may pull against priority to the most vulnerable. The candidate must state which factor is decisive in that context and protect the weaker factor through safeguards, review or communication.

The distinction produces a disciplined sequence: identify conflicts and legality; remove impermissible choices; apply moral theories and weighted checks to lawful alternatives; choose; then answer the strongest objection. Treating every consideration as equal invites vague balancing and may imply that sufficient benefit can purchase legality. Treating every value as absolute, conversely, prevents reasoned choice. Ethical maturity lies in firm thresholds followed by explicit, evidence-based weighting.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 15 marks

Question: Show how nested-dilemma decomposition and steelmanning improve a complex case-study answer. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Nested-dilemma decomposition prevents one dramatic fact from swallowing the rest of the case. The 2025 Vijay-type disaster problem contains personal grief versus public duty, continuity and fairness of relief allocation, and honest communication versus panic control. Each tension should receive a compact independent pass through legality, public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion before the results are integrated.

The method avoids muddled phrases such as balance both sides. Vijay's personal dilemma may support a brief authorised absence; the allocation dilemma still requires the deputy to retain published triage criteria; the communication dilemma requires verified, calibrated updates. Separate resolutions therefore become one coherent operational plan.

Steelmanning then tests the plan against its strongest credible objection. The serious objection is not that family duty is irrelevant, but that any command gap during renewed danger could cost lives. A mature answer accepts this risk and makes competent written delegation, scheduled contact and immediate-return triggers conditions of the decision.

The two devices serve different functions: decomposition clarifies what must be decided, while steelmanning tests whether the selected response survives informed criticism. Both must remain proportionate to the word limit; artificial sub-dilemmas and repeated counter-arguments create indecision rather than depth.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 4 - 15 marks

Question: Evaluate the written-order response and ethical-dissent ladder as safeguards against improper administrative pressure. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Improper oral pressure is dangerous because it seeks compliance without accountability. The officer should record the instruction, seek written confirmation and place the legal, technical and ethical objection on the official record. This protects institutional memory, fixes responsibility and demonstrates independent professional judgment. The officer should continue lawful work while referral is pending unless the act would itself be unsafe or unlawful.

If the pressure persists, dissent should climb proportionately: competent internal reporting; an independent internal vigilance, audit or ethics tier; an authorised regulator, ombudsman or external authority; and public disclosure only when serious continuing harm and failed lawful alternatives justify that last step. When the normal superior is implicated, the compromised rung may be skipped, but evidence and lawful purpose remain essential.

The strongest objection is that formal recording can provoke retaliation or administrative delay. Therefore the response should be concise, factual, time-bound and supported by secure evidence and anti-retaliation measures where available. Resignation is not the automatic next rung: it is justified only when resistance is exhausted and departure protects public interest better than continued principled service.

Together, written reasons and graduated escalation turn private conscience into accountable institutional action without confusing courage with impulsive leakage or theatrical exit.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 5 - 20 marks

Question: A district faces severe water scarcity among households, hospitals, farmers and industry. Apply the complete case-study architecture to design an ethical allocation response. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

Facts and dilemma: available water cannot meet all claims, while immediate survival needs and longer-term livelihoods conflict. Stakeholders include households, hospitals, vulnerable settlements, farmers, workers, industry, local bodies, ecosystems and future users. Constraints are the actual reservoir level, drinking-water law and policy, conveyance losses, time, uncertain rainfall and limited enforcement capacity.

Options are: retain historical quotas; use first-come political bargaining; impose an undifferentiated cut; or publish a tiered emergency allocation. The tiered course should protect minimum drinking, sanitation and critical-care needs first; reserve ecological and fire-safety minima; then distribute livelihood and industrial supplies through transparent necessity, efficiency and vulnerability criteria, with recycling and temporary restrictions.

Evaluation begins with legality and non-discrimination as thresholds. Consequentialism supports preventing death and maintaining essential services; duty ethics protects equal dignity and a basic minimum; proportionality rejects both unrestricted consumption and blanket closure. The decisive weighted considerations are urgency, vulnerability and avoidable harm. Steelman: prioritising urban hospitals and households may ruin farms and jobs. The plan therefore needs crop-saving rotations, fodder and income support, recycled industrial water and rapid loss reduction rather than simply transferring all scarcity to rural users.

Decision and implementation: constitute a multi-stakeholder drought cell, publish daily availability and criteria, meter bulk users, repair leaks, enforce restrictions uniformly and create an expedited appeal route. Communicate uncertainty honestly and revise allocations at fixed hydrological triggers.

Residual risk equals severe inherent scarcity minus conservation, prioritisation and augmentation controls, plus forecast and enforcement uncertainty. Capture by powerful users may remain. The district drought cell should publish allocation logs, commission independent audit and review impacts on vulnerable groups every week.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 6 - 20 marks

Question: A public-sector quality officer discovers that a safety-critical product failed tests, but senior management orders clearance to avoid losses and threatens retaliation. Decide. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

Facts and dilemma: a failed safety result conflicts with management's commercial and reputational interests, and the officer faces personal retaliation. Stakeholders include consumers, workers, distributors, shareholders, the regulator, honest colleagues, management and the officer's family. Constraints include mandatory safety standards, release deadlines, evidence custody, the officer's limited authority and the possibility that the ordinary reporting line is compromised.

Options are: alter or ignore the result; delay silently; resign without reporting; or preserve the original test, record the oral direction, stop clearance within lawful authority and escalate with evidence to independent quality governance and, if required, the competent regulator. The first option fails legality, professional duty and public interest. Silent delay leaves the hazard active. Immediate resignation removes the witness and does not protect consumers.

Decision: choose evidence preservation, written refusal and graduated escalation. Deontology requires fidelity to safety and truth; consequences favour preventing mass harm; virtue ethics supports courage disciplined by prudence. Steelman: a false or non-representative failed test could destroy the enterprise and jobs. Therefore an independent confirmatory test may proceed under controlled custody, but the product must remain quarantined until the competent authority decides; tests cannot be repeated selectively until a desired result appears.

Implementation: timestamp and secure samples and raw data, request written confirmation, notify the independent quality committee, define a short regulator trigger, protect affected staff and prepare a truthful recall plan if distribution occurred. Communicate verified risk without sensationalism.

Residual risk includes retaliation, evidence tampering and supply shortage. The regulator or independent quality head should control access logs, witness the retest, monitor the officer's employment treatment and audit corrective action. Resignation becomes defensible only if all lawful channels fail and continued office would require personal falsification.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Subject: Ethics | **Tier:** Advanced | **GS Paper:** GS-IV (Section B, Case Studies). **Core area:** Deeper refinement of the case-study architecture - handling nested dilemmas, weighting conflicting checks, and defending a decision against an examiner's counter-argument. **Grounded in:** Official UPSC GS-IV Section-B case-study format; audited GS-IV PYQs (2024-2025 Mains); moral theories (08); ARC-derived concepts across this folder. **FACT:** = PYQ/source-grounded | **ANALYSIS:** = inference/analysis | **CURRENT:** = current anchor. *Companion:* basic/22_Case-Study-Method-and-Answer-Architecture.md.

1. Architecture

LAYER 1: DECOMPOSE

Nested dilemmas? Separate each sub-dilemma and solve independently before recombining into one answer

LAYER 2: BOUND THE PROBLEM

State the HARD CONSTRAINTS (legal, delegation, time, information, jurisdiction, capacity) that make some notionally attractive options simply unavailable

LAYER 3: WEIGHT THE SIX CHECKS

Not all checks carry equal weight in every case - state explicitly which check is DECISIVE and why (legality is always a hard threshold; compassion may be secondary to public interest in a resource-scarcity case)

LAYER 4: STRESS-TEST AND DEFEND

State the strongest objection to your chosen option and explain why it does not overturn your conclusion; then name the residual risk that survives your own recommendation, and how it will be monitored

Analytical claim: The advanced skill beyond the basic six-step architecture is **explicit weighting and stress-testing** - a mature answer does not treat all six checks as equally decisive in every case, and it pre-empts the most obvious counter-argument rather than leaving it for the examiner to raise unaddressed.

2. Concepts and distinctions

Concept	Precise meaning
ANALYSIS: Hard threshold vs weighted check	Legality and (usually) conflict-of-interest function as hard thresholds - an illegal or self-interested option is eliminated outright, not merely weighed against other factors; public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion function as weighted checks that must be balanced against each other case by case.
ANALYSIS: Nested-dilemma decomposition	Complex cases (see 09's advanced treatment) often contain 2-3 analytically separable dilemmas; solving them independently before recombining avoids a single, muddled, "on the one hand... on the other hand" answer that never actually decides anything.
ANALYSIS: Steelmanning the counter-argument	Explicitly stating the <i>strongest</i> version of the objection to your chosen decision (not a weak strawman) and showing why your decision still holds, or modifying the decision to accommodate the valid part of the objection.
ANALYSIS: Residual-risk acknowledgment	A mature implementation/mitigation step names the specific risk that remains <i>even after</i> the chosen decision is implemented, and proposes a monitoring/review mechanism for it - rather than presenting the decision as a complete, risk-free resolution.

3. Detailed treatment

A conflict-of-interest case worked at advanced level - 2025 GS-IV Q9 (Subash) and 2024 Q10 (Sneha)

- FACT: 2025 GS-IV Q9: Subash, Secretary PWD, holds pre-announcement knowledge of a mega road project's alignment; his son, a real-estate businessman, presses him to disclose the location, arguing he buys land routinely and will be discreet; separately the Minister has introduced his own nephew's infrastructure company and signalled that its business interests should be looked after.
- FACT: 2024 GS-IV Q10: Sneha chairs a hospital procurement committee and finds her brother - a financially stressed supplier - among the bidders; the hospital is private, so the lowest bid is not mandatory, and management would back whatever she decides.
- ANALYSIS: Advanced handling: both are **hard-threshold** cases, not weighted balancing exercises. The private-interest link is disqualifying in itself; the only defensible sequence is *disclose in writing -> recuse from the specific decision -> have the decision taken by an untainted authority on published criteria*. The fact that management "trusts her fully", or that the son "buys land anyway", is precisely the reasoning a corrupt outcome would use, and should be named as such.
- ANALYSIS: Note the distinct second issue in the 2025 case: unauthorised disclosure of price-sensitive official information is itself a breach of conduct rules and, if acted on, moves the matter from conflict of interest into the territory of an undue advantage under the PC Act (see 19) - an answer that treats it only as a family dilemma misses the legal escalation. The safeguard against ministerial pressure is the same one that protects Subash: put the advice and the refusal on the file, and route the project's land-acquisition and tendering through published, committee-based criteria (see 18).

Weighting the six checks - worked principle

- ANALYSIS: **Legality** is nearly always a hard threshold: no matter how compelling the public-interest or compassion argument, an illegal option should not be chosen (see 09, 10) - a case-study answer that "chooses" an illegal option because it "feels" more compassionate will lose significant marks.
- ANALYSIS: **Conflict of interest** is also close to a hard threshold: where present, disclosure/recusal is usually the correct first move regardless of other considerations, because proceeding despite a conflict undermines the legitimacy of *any* subsequent decision, however well-reasoned.
- ANALYSIS: **Public interest, proportionality, transparency, and compassion** are genuinely weighted checks

that can conflict with each other - e.g., in a resource-scarcity triage scenario (08), pure aggregate public interest might favour one allocation, while compassion for the most vulnerable individual might favour another; a strong answer explicitly states which check is being prioritised and why, rather than pretending no tension exists.

Nested-dilemma decomposition - applied to the 2025 DC-Vijay case

- ANALYSIS: As identified in 09's advanced treatment, the 2025 GS-IV Q7 case (DC Vijay) nests at least three dilemmas: (1) personal grief vs public duty; (2) resource-allocation fairness in ongoing disaster relief; (3) transparency vs maintaining public calm during an active crisis.
- ANALYSIS: Advanced answers solve each nested dilemma with its own mini six-check pass, then integrate: the personal/duty dilemma resolves through delegation-plus-brief-attendance (see basic file); the resource-allocation dilemma resolves through the deputy applying pre-established, transparent triage criteria (proportionality + public interest weighted over pure equal-treatment); the transparency-vs-calm dilemma resolves through honest, calibrated public communication that avoids both panic-inducing over-disclosure and trust-eroding under-disclosure.

Steelmanning - applied to the 2024 tech-company AI/environment case

- FACT: 2024 GS-IV Q7 (Section B case study) (see 12, 13): a strong steelman of the "just optimise for shareholder value and innovation pace" counter-argument would note that aggressive competitors unconstrained by voluntary emissions discipline could out-innovate a self-restrained company, eroding its market position and, paradoxically, its long-term capacity to invest in sustainability at all.
- ANALYSIS: A mature answer addresses this directly: recommend *time-bound, verifiable* (not indefinite or unlimited) renewable-energy and efficiency commitments calibrated to remain commercially competitive, explicitly linking the sustainability commitment to long-term brand/regulatory/ investor-confidence value rather than treating it as a pure cost with no offsetting competitive benefit - this directly answers the steelmanned objection rather than ignoring it.

Residual-risk acknowledgment - the mark of a mature closing section

- ANALYSIS: Every case-study answer should end not with "and thus the problem is solved" but with an explicit statement of what could still go wrong under the chosen decision, and how that residual risk will be monitored - e.g., in the DC-Vijay case: "the deputy's decisions during the DC's absence should be reviewed on return, and succession-readiness for future crises should be built into the district disaster-management plan," acknowledging that delegation itself carries some execution risk that must be actively managed, not merely assumed away.

4. Institutional and reform architecture

- ANALYSIS: This case-study architecture is transferable to real administrative decision documentation: a well-drafted file note for a genuinely discretionary decision should itself follow a similar structure (options considered, stakeholders identified, legal/conflict-of-interest check performed, public-interest rationale stated, and residual risk flagged) - directly reinforcing the probity/ transparency principles taught in 14, 15.
- ANALYSIS: Mission Karmayogi's case-based and simulation learning on the iGOT-Karmayogi platform (Cabinet approval 2 September 2020) increasingly uses structured case methods similar to this architecture to build administrative judgment, rather than relying purely on rule memorisation.

5. Indian applications and boundary cases

- ANALYSIS: A senior officer facing pressure to reallocate disaster-relief resources toward a politically favoured constituency, rather than the most acutely affected area, should apply the hard-threshold legality/conflict-of-interest check first (is this pressure itself improper?), then the weighted public-interest/proportionality check (which allocation actually serves the most acute need), arriving at a defensible, need-based allocation regardless of the political pressure.
- ANALYSIS: Boundary case: where two weighted checks (e.g., transparency and short-term public calm) appear to conflict acutely during an active crisis, a mature answer favours calibrated, honest communication (partial, accurate disclosure with a commitment to fuller disclosure once verified) over either full immediate disclosure (risking panic before facts are confirmed) or prolonged non-disclosure (risking trust erosion once the truth eventually emerges).

6. Limitations and trade-offs

- ANALYSIS: The six-check framework is a synthesis heuristic, not an algorithm that mechanically outputs a single correct answer - different, well-reasoned weightings can defensibly favour different decisions in genuinely hard cases; examiners reward the *quality of reasoning*, not conformity to one "correct" answer.
- ANALYSIS: Steelmanning counter-arguments, if overdone, can make an answer read as indecisive; the skill is to acknowledge the strongest objection concisely and then decisively explain why it does not overturn the conclusion, not to relitigate the entire dilemma repeatedly.
- ANALYSIS: Nested-dilemma decomposition adds rigor but also length; in a time-constrained exam, candidates must prioritise decomposing only the dilemmas that are genuinely analytically separable and exam-relevant, not artificially multiplying sub-dilemmas for their own sake.

7. Must-Know Facts for Advanced Prelims

- ANALYSIS: GS-IV case studies do not have a single official "model answer" published by UPSC; the six-step, weighted-check architecture is a defensible, examiner-tested heuristic synthesised from standard case-study methodology and the ARC's own ethical-analysis vocabulary (bona fides, proportionality, transparency), not a verbatim reproduction of any single official document.
- ANALYSIS: Legality and conflict-of-interest function as hard thresholds; public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion function as weighted, case-specific checks.

8. Advanced Prelims traps

- WRONG: All six checks in the case-study framework carry equal weight in every scenario. -> Legality and conflict-of-interest are near-hard thresholds; the remaining four are weighted and can genuinely conflict, requiring explicit prioritisation reasoning.
- WRONG: A good case-study answer avoids mentioning any weakness in its own chosen decision. -> Examiners reward explicit acknowledgment of residual risk and the strongest counter-argument, addressed rather than ignored.
- WRONG: Nested-dilemma decomposition means treating every case study as containing many separate problems regardless of the facts. -> Decomposition should be used only where the case genuinely contains analytically separable dilemmas; over-decomposition of a simple case wastes time and dilutes the answer's focus.

9. Current application

Current application (verify before use)	Topic-specific analytical use
ANALYSIS: Mission Karmayogi case-based or simulation learning	Reinforces structured judgment-building as a training method; cite a named iGOT module before presenting it as a current programme-wide requirement.

10. PYQ-based analytical application

- FACT: 2025 GS-IV Q7 (Section B case study: DC Vijay) rewards nested-dilemma decomposition and explicit check-weighting
(public duty as a near-hard threshold once delegation is arranged; compassion for personal grief weighted alongside, not overriding, that duty).
- FACT: 2024 GS-IV Q7 (Section B case study: tech company) rewards steelmanning the profitability/innovation counter-argument and proposing a time-bound, verifiable, competitively-viable sustainability commitment rather than an unqualified "prioritise the environment" answer.

11. Mains-ready framework

Central thesis: An advanced GS-IV case-study answer decomposes nested dilemmas, explicitly weights the six ethical checks (treating legality and conflict-of-interest as hard thresholds and the remainder as case-specific weighted factors), steelmans and directly addresses the strongest counter-argument to its decision, and closes with an honest acknowledgment of residual risk and its monitoring mechanism.

1. Decompose the case into its analytically separable nested dilemmas, if more than one exists.
2. State the hard constraints that bound the choice, so that unrealisable options are eliminated before, not after, the ethical evaluation.
3. Apply the six-check framework to each, explicitly noting which checks are hard thresholds and which are weighted, with a stated rationale for the weighting.
4. Reach a decision for each nested dilemma, then integrate into a single coherent recommendation.
5. State the strongest counter-argument to your decision and directly address it.
6. Close with a specific implementation step and an honestly acknowledged residual risk with its monitoring/mitigation mechanism.

12. Probable questions

- ANALYSIS: **Mains (case study, 20 marks):** A district officer must reallocate scarce disaster-relief resources under political pressure to favour one constituency. Apply the full case-study architecture, including a steelmanned counter-argument and residual-risk acknowledgment.
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (case study, 20 marks):** A public-sector bank manager's good-faith loan decision has defaulted amid adverse market conditions, triggering a vigilance complaint. Apply the bona fides test (21) within the six-step case-study architecture to determine the appropriate response.

13. Study links

- FACT: Foundation companion: `basic/22_Case-Study-Method-and-Answer-Architecture.md`.
- FACT: `09_Public-Service-Values-Status-and-Ethical-Dilemmas.md` - nested-dilemma decomposition source.
- FACT: `08_Moral-Theories-Deontology-Consequentialism-Virtue-Ethics.md` - the theory-application layer.
- FACT: `21_Protecting-Honest-Officials-and-Vigilance-Administration.md` - the bona fides test as a case-study tool.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: `_PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS3-GS4-2018-2023.md`.

- **Years represented:** 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023
- **Paper(s):** GS-IV
- **Routed question demands:** 36

Semantic table split - Year

- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 7
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Rakesh (district officer) - elderly couple applies for senior citizen healthcare scheme; surgeon willing to operate free but couple cannot afford incidental costs; how should he respond
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words

- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 8
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Senior Ministry officer with access to policy decisions - minister requests road realignment near his farm and offers land in wife's name; conflicts of interest and responsibilities as public servant
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 9
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** SP appointed in prohibition state notorious for illicit liquor distillation causing deaths; what new approach to bring problem under control
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 10
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Corporate chemical factory ordered closed after pollution protests and public agitation; closure causes unemployment in workers and ancillary units; address as senior officer
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 11
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Dr. X charitable trust hospital - tax irregularities found on inspection; two options: broad substantial compliance ignoring technical defaults vs strict pursuit on all fronts
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2018
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 12
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Edward Snowden released classified government surveillance documents citing moral obligation to inform public; ethically justified even if legally prohibited - weighing competing values
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method

- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2019
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 7
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Rescue officer in severe natural calamity - team members assaulted by angry crowd - some plead to call off operations; what will be your response and what qualities of public servant are required
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2019
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 8
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Civil servants implicated and imprisoned for bonafide mistakes - moral fibre of civil services rattled; how this trend affects functioning and measures to protect honest officers
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2019
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 9
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Apparel company - marketing executive sexually harasses woman employee - company offers money to withdraw FIR; identify ethical issues and options available to woman employee
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2019
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 10
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Rising politicization of bureaucracy - political executive encroaching on permanent executive including transfers and postings; consequences of this trend
- **Directive / format:** Discuss · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2019
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 11
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Woman SP appointed in frontier narcotics district - money laundering poppy farming arms smuggling education collapse; identify dimensions and suggest measures to restore normalcy
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method

- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2019
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 12
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Civil service ethics reform - institutional measures for anticipating ethical threats strengthening ethical competence and developing administrative processes promoting integrity
- **Directive / format:** Suggest · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2020
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 7
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Finance Ministry official Rajesh Kumar: re-appropriation of NHS welfare funds to SEZ and gas plant - (a) ethical issues; (b) options available including whether resignation is worthy
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2020
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 8
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** BML Chairman asked to expand ATGM production for export to friendly nation - (a) ethical issues for a responsible arms-exporting nation; (b) five ethical factors influencing arms sale decision
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2020
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 9
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** DC of tribal Rampura district: minor girls trafficked to cotton farms as child labour by contractors; identify ethical issues; steps to ameliorate conditions and economic scenario
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2020
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 10
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Municipal Commissioner: mall collapse causing deaths; corruption nexus between officials and builder; POSH threat by minister relative; ethical issues and selected course of action
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method

- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2020
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 11
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Anil APW factory in backward Parmal district: CSR-driven development of Noora village - critically analyse ethical issues; assess APW as role model for backward area development
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2020
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 12
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** migrant workers during COVID lockdown: ethical issues in crisis; meaning of ethical care and ethical giving; civil society role in mitigating migrant suffering
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2021
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 7
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Sunil in tribal district combats illegal sand mining mafia and faces violence threats - (a) options available; (b) evaluate each option; (c) most appropriate course of action
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2021
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 8
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Vice Principal faces management pressure to suppress exam cheating involving students of influential local politician and businessman - (a) ethical issues; (b) options and best course
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2021
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 9
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** project manager of elevated corridor notices crack in pier; minister and chief engineer pressure to overlook - (a) options; (b) ethical dilemmas; (c) professional challenges; (d) consequences
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method

- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
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- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** COVID-19 hospital administrator: criteria and justification for deploying clinical and non-clinical staff in infectious crisis; whether justification differs for a private hospital
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- **Year:** 2021
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 11
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** food company sells inferior products domestically and dumps rejected export products in Indian market - (a) authority action; (b) company remedy to restore reputation; (c) ethical dilemma
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2021
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 12
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Pawan faces chronic workplace harassment and public humiliation by senior officer causing mental anguish and family distress - options to cope; approach for tranquillity; training suggestions
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
- **Year:** 2022
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 7
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on a marketing VP offered rival firm's defence tender documents in exchange for employment
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2022
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 8
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on a state civil service officer directed to withdraw confidential report on illegal migrant infiltration
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2022

- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 9
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on a journalist exposing stone-mining mafia-official-politician nexus who faces report suppression by the media owner
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2022
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 10
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on a quality inspection officer pressured to clear an export-rejected defective consignment for domestic market
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2022
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 11
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on Joint Commissioner adjudicating bus driver death compensation dispute and resolving transport workers strike
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2022
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 12
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on Environment Pollution Control Board officer enforcing industrial environmental compliance despite resistance and threats
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2023
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 7
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on bank executive whose colleague's father's surgery was funded by manager from a dormant account without authorisation
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2023
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 8
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on District Magistrate (AIIMS physician) facing blood-transfusion dilemma during a landslide relief operation
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words

- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2023
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 9
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on Joint Secretary navigating work-life obligations and equitable workplace laws protecting women in service
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2023
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 10
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on honest IAS officer as SRTC MD facing corrupt politically powerful Chairman and pressure from Opposition party
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2023
- **Paper:** GS-IV
- **Q:** 11
- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on ADG CPWD handling workplace harassment of a new woman architect by an insecure senior Chief Architect
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
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- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.
- **Year:** 2023
- **Paper:** GS-IV
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- **PYQ demand (neutral rendering):** Case on senior government official managing son's cyberbullying and posting a counter-video on social media
- **Directive / format:** Case study · 20 marks · 250 words
- **Source status:** Case routed to Ethics case-study method
- **Owner requirement:** Apply stakeholders, dilemmas, options, justification, implementation and safeguards.

What this owner must now support

- Rakesh (district officer) - elderly couple applies for senior citizen healthcare scheme; surgeon willing to operate free but couple cannot afford incidental costs; how should he respond
- Senior Ministry officer with access to policy decisions - minister requests road realignment near his farm and offers land in wife's name; conflicts of interest and responsibilities as public servant
- SP appointed in prohibition state notorious for illicit liquor distillation causing deaths; what new approach to bring problem under control
- Corporate chemical factory ordered closed after pollution protests and public agitation; closure causes unemployment in workers and ancillary units; address as senior officer
- Dr. X charitable trust hospital - tax irregularities found on inspection; two options: broad substantial compliance ignoring technical defaults vs strict pursuit on all fronts

- Edward Snowden released classified government surveillance documents citing moral obligation to inform public; ethically justified even if legally prohibited - weighing competing values
- Rescue officer in severe natural calamity - team members assaulted by angry crowd - some plead to call off operations; what will be your response and what qualities of public servant are required
- Civil servants implicated and imprisoned for bonafide mistakes - moral fibre of civil services rattled; how this trend affects functioning and measures to protect honest officers
- Apparel company - marketing executive sexually harasses woman employee - company offers money to withdraw FIR; identify ethical issues and options available to woman employee
- Rising politicization of bureaucracy - political executive encroaching on permanent executive including transfers and postings; consequences of this trend
- Woman SP appointed in frontier narcotics district - money laundering poppy farming arms smuggling education collapse; identify dimensions and suggest measures to restore normalcy
- Civil service ethics reform - institutional measures for anticipating ethical threats strengthening ethical competence and developing administrative processes promoting integrity
- Finance Ministry official Rajesh Kumar: re-appropriation of NHS welfare funds to SEZ and gas plant - (a) ethical issues; (b) options available including whether resignation is worthy
- BML Chairman asked to expand ATGM production for export to friendly nation - (a) ethical issues for a responsible arms-exporting nation; (b) five ethical factors influencing arms sale decision
- DC of tribal Rampura district: minor girls trafficked to cotton farms as child labour by contractors; identify ethical issues; steps to ameliorate conditions and economic scenario
- Municipal Commissioner: mall collapse causing deaths; corruption nexus between officials and builder; POSH threat by minister relative; ethical issues and selected course of action
- Anil APW factory in backward Parmal district: CSR-driven development of Noora village - critically analyse ethical issues; assess APW as role model for backward area development
- migrant workers during COVID lockdown: ethical issues in crisis; meaning of ethical care and ethical giving; civil society role in mitigating migrant suffering
- Sunil in tribal district combats illegal sand mining mafia and faces violence threats - (a) options available; (b) evaluate each option; (c) most appropriate course of action
- Vice Principal faces management pressure to suppress exam cheating involving students of influential local politician and businessman - (a) ethical issues; (b) options and best course
- project manager of elevated corridor notices crack in pier; minister and chief engineer pressure to overlook - (a) options; (b) ethical dilemmas; (c) professional challenges; (d) consequences
- COVID-19 hospital administrator: criteria and justification for deploying clinical and non-clinical staff in infectious crisis; whether justification differs for a private hospital
- food company sells inferior products domestically and dumps rejected export products in Indian market - (a) authority action; (b) company remedy to restore reputation; (c) ethical dilemma
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The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

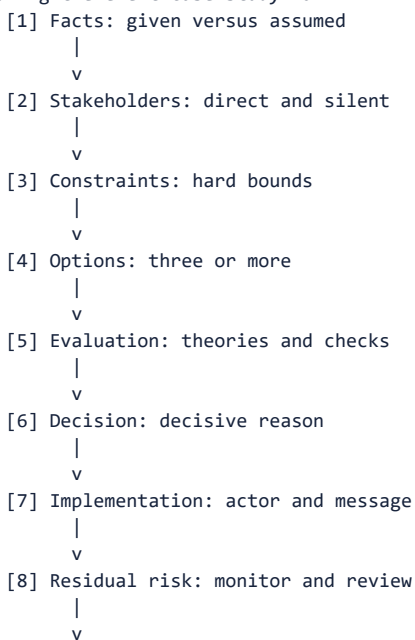
EMBEDDED TWELVE-PANEL ASCII REVISION ATLAS

The panels compress the learning route without replacing the complete teaching and solved practice above.

ASCII PANEL 1/12 - 1. Eight-element case-study rail

CENTRAL FOCUS

1. Eight-element case-study rail



VERDICT -> A case answer is a complete decision process, not a moral reaction.

ANSWER USE -> Use as the universal opening architecture.

ASCII PANEL 2/12 - 2. Constraint gate before option design

CENTRAL FOCUS

2. Constraint gate before option design

- [1] Legality defines permission
 - |
 - v
- [2] Delegation defines authority
 - |
 - v
- [3] Jurisdiction defines forum
 - |
 - v
- [4] Time defines urgency
 - |
 - v
- [5] Information defines confidence
 - |
 - v
- [6] Resources define capacity
 - |
 - v
- [7] Safety defines tolerable exposure
 - |
 - v
- [8] Survivors become real options
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> Impossible or unlawful proposals should never enter later balancing.

ANSWER USE -> Use before listing options in every administrative case.

ASCII PANEL 3/12 - 3. Six-check evaluation matrix

CENTRAL FOCUS

3. Six-check evaluation matrix

- [1] Conflict: hard threshold
 - |
 - v
- [2] Legality: hard threshold
 - |
 - v
- [3] Public interest: weighted
 - |
 - v
- [4] Proportionality: weighted
 - |
 - v
- [5] Transparency: weighted
 - |
 - v
- [6] Compassion: weighted
 - |
 - v
- [7] Long-term effects: projected
 - |
 - v
- [8] Decisive weight: stated
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> Eliminate first, weigh second and explain what controlled the choice.

ANSWER USE -> Use for the ethical-evaluation element.

ASCII PANEL 4/12 - 4. Conflict-of-interest resolution sequence

CENTRAL FOCUS

4. Conflict-of-interest resolution sequence

- [1] Detect personal-interest link
 - |
 - v
- [2] Disclose connection in writing
 - |
 - v
- [3] Recuse from the decision
 - |
 - v
- [4] Refer to untainted authority
 - |
 - v
- [5] State objective criteria
 - |
 - v
- [6] Apply criteria consistently
 - |
 - v
- [7] Preserve the scoring trail
 - |
 - v
- [8] Publish or defend the rationale
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> Personal honesty cannot substitute for an unconflicted process.

ANSWER USE -> Use in procurement, licensing and privileged-information cases.

ASCII PANEL 5/12 - 5. Nested dilemma and steelman loop

CENTRAL FOCUS

5. Nested dilemma and steelman loop

- [1] Identify dilemma one
 - |
 - v
- [2] Run compact ethical checks
 - |
 - v
- [3] Identify dilemma two
 - |
 - v
- [4] Run compact ethical checks
 - |
 - v
- [5] Recombine compatible decisions
 - |
 - v
- [6] State strongest objection
 - |
 - v
- [7] Absorb valid objection
 - |
 - v
- [8] Confirm or revise decision
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> Decomposition clarifies the problem; steelmanning tests the solution.

ANSWER USE -> Use for dense cases with multiple genuine conflicts.

ASCII PANEL 6/12 - 6. Residual-risk closing formula

CENTRAL FOCUS

6. Residual-risk closing formula

- [1] Name inherent danger
 - |
 - v
- [2] List preventive controls
 - |
 - v
- [3] Test control weakness
 - |
 - v
- [4] Add uncertainty exposure
 - |
 - v
- [5] State surviving risk
 - |
 - v
- [6] Choose monitoring indicator
 - |
 - v
- [7] Name accountable authority
 - |
 - v
- [8] Set review or trigger date
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> Residual risk equals inherent risk reduced by controls, with uncertainty retained.

ANSWER USE -> Use as the final paragraph of every solved case.

ASCII PANEL 7/12 - 7. Written-order response to pressure

CENTRAL FOCUS

7. Written-order response to pressure

- [1] Identify improper oral direction
 - |
 - v
- [2] Record its substance promptly
 - |
 - v
- [3] Seek written confirmation
 - |
 - v
- [4] State professional objection
 - |
 - v
- [5] Preserve supporting evidence
 - |
 - v
- [6] Refer through proper hierarchy
 - |
 - v
- [7] Continue lawful substantive duty
 - |
 - v
- [8] Escalate impropriety if persistent
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> Writing fixes responsibility and converts private resistance into institutional accountability.

ANSWER USE -> Use for ministerial, superior and corporate pressure.

ASCII PANEL 8/12 - 8. Whistleblowing and dissent ladder

CENTRAL FOCUS

8. Whistleblowing and dissent ladder

- [1] Preserve credible evidence
 - |
 - v
- [2] Report to competent superior
 - |
 - v
- [3] Skip a compromised recipient
 - |
 - v
- [4] Use independent internal tier
 - |
 - v
- [5] Use authorised external channel
 - |
 - v
- [6] Protect identity and safety
 - |
 - v
- [7] Consider public disclosure last
 - |
 - v
- [8] Review retaliation and follow-up
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> Escalate only as far as failure and continuing harm require.

ANSWER USE -> Use when loyalty, secrecy and public interest conflict.

ASCII PANEL 9/12 - 9. Resignation decision test

CENTRAL FOCUS

9. Resignation decision test

- [1] Record personal non-participation
 - |
 - v
- [2] Test internal resistance
 - |
 - v
- [3] Test independent escalation
 - |
 - v
- [4] Assess continuing public influence
 - |
 - v
- [5] Assess complicity from remaining
 - |
 - v
- [6] Assess impact of departure
 - |
 - v
- [7] Define the resignation trigger
 - |
 - v
- [8] Resign only if net protection rises
 - |
 - v

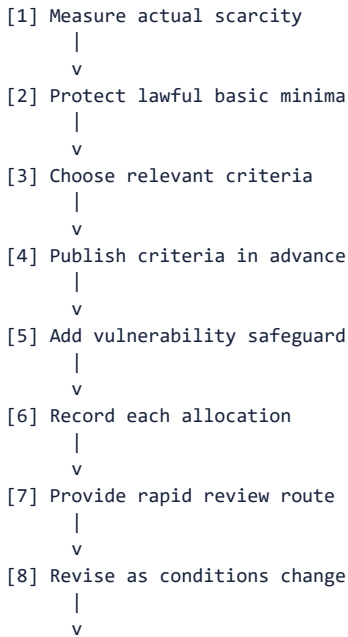
VERDICT -> Resignation is ethical only when it protects the public better than principled service.

ANSWER USE -> Use whenever an option list includes exit from office.

ASCII PANEL 10/12 - 10. Scarce-resource triage cycle

CENTRAL FOCUS

10. Scarce-resource triage cycle



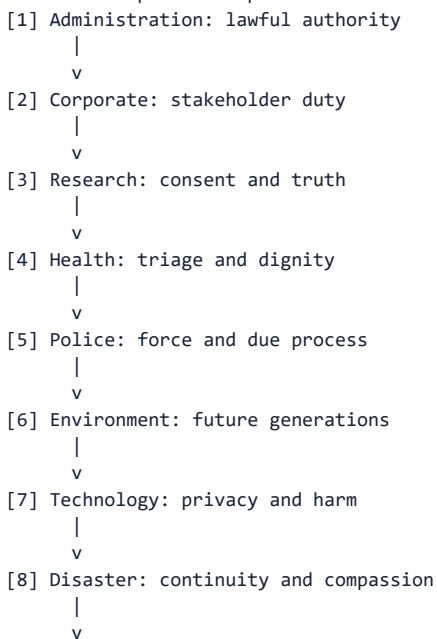
VERDICT -> Transparent criteria are ethically superior to hidden case-by-case discretion.

ANSWER USE -> Use for beds, staff, water, relief and compensation.

ASCII PANEL 11/12 - 11. Domain adaptation map

CENTRAL FOCUS

11. Domain adaptation map



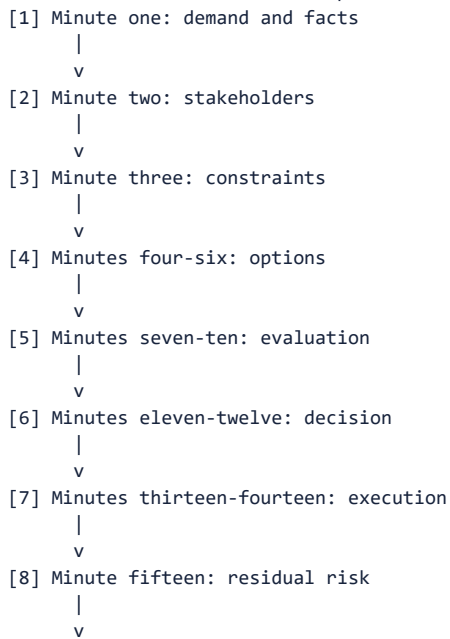
VERDICT -> The architecture stays constant while standards, institutions and evidence change.

ANSWER USE -> Use to transfer the method without copying remedies blindly.

ASCII PANEL 12/12 - 12. Time-bound examiner answer spine

CENTRAL FOCUS

12. Time-bound examiner answer spine



VERDICT -> Compress every element; do not sacrifice the ending to an oversized introduction.

ANSWER USE -> Use as a planning clock for a twenty-mark case.

ONE-PAGE CONCEPT GRID

Concept / thinker	Exam-ready formulation
Facts must be separated from assumptions	A disciplined case answer restates only verified facts, identifies uncertainty and avoids silently inventing motives, powers or resources; later options and judgments must remain traceable to what the scenario actually establishes.
Stakeholder mapping includes silent parties	Stakeholder mapping must include direct participants and less visible parties such as future generations, absent beneficiaries, vulnerable groups and the institution whose long-term credibility may be altered by the decision.
Hard constraints eliminate impossible choices early	Legal authority, delegation limits, time, verified information, jurisdiction and actual capacity should be mapped before generating options; a proposal that breaches a binding constraint is not a realistic administrative choice.
Options require realistic comparison	A strong answer develops at least three feasible courses, including a sequenced or hybrid response where useful, and states one concrete advantage and disadvantage before selecting the most defensible course.
Legality operates as a hard threshold	An unlawful option is normally eliminated before ethical balancing, even when it appears compassionate or efficient; claimed benefits cannot convert absence of lawful authority into a permissible administrative response.
Conflict of interest is near-disqualifying	A genuine personal, family or financial interest requires disclosure and withdrawal from the specific decision; confidence in one's own honesty cannot cure the appearance or structural risk of biased authority.
Weighted checks require an explicit priority	Public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion may pull in different directions; the candidate should state which consideration is decisive in context and explain why the remaining concerns are mitigated rather than denied.
Moral theories test surviving options	After threshold screening, deontology tests duties and rights, consequentialism compares foreseeable outcomes, and virtue ethics asks what integrity, courage, compassion and practical wisdom require from the decision-maker.
Nested dilemmas should be solved separately	When a scenario contains analytically distinct tensions, each should receive a compact independent evaluation before the answers are recombined; this prevents one emotional conflict from obscuring resource, transparency or legality questions.
Steelmanning uses the strongest objection	Before closing, the answer should present the most credible objection to its chosen course and either defeat it with reasons or modify implementation to absorb its valid concern without abandoning the decision.
Residual risk must name monitoring and accountability	A mature conclusion identifies the specific harm that may survive the preferred course, names a review or monitoring mechanism and assigns responsibility to a person or institution rather than claiming complete resolution.
Residual risk can be expressed as a control formula	Residual risk equals inherent risk reduced by effective controls, while uncertainty and control failure remain visible; the expression disciplines mitigation but does not pretend ethical judgment can be reduced to arithmetic.

CORE REVISION SPINE

- **Conflict resolution follows disclose, recuse, refer, publish:** A conflicted decision-maker should disclose the connection in writing, recuse from that matter, refer it to an untainted authority and ensure objective criteria govern the eventual decision and its defensibility.
- **Improper oral pressure should be converted into writing:** An officer facing an improper oral direction should record its substance, seek written confirmation, state the professional objection and use the normal escalation route while continuing lawful duties unless action would itself be unsafe.
- **Ethical dissent climbs a proportionate ladder:** Evidence-based dissent normally moves from competent internal reporting to an independent internal tier, then to authorised external channels and only finally to public disclosure when serious continuing harm and failed alternatives justify it.
- **Resignation is an evaluated last resort:** Resignation becomes defensible only after lawful resistance and escalation are exhausted or unavailable, and when departure protects public interest better than remaining as a principled internal safeguard; it should not function as emotional escape.
- **Triage criteria should be published and reviewable:** Scarce-resource allocation should use pre-announced, relevant and non-discriminatory criteria, record their actual application, provide an appropriate review route and revise them when resources or the emergency profile materially changes.
- **Triage must acknowledge its value trade-off:** A defensible allocation explains whether aggregate welfare, urgency, survivability, vulnerability or priority to the worst-off is being emphasised, then adds equity safeguards so the chosen metric does not become mechanically dehumanising.
- **Domain adaptation preserves the architecture:** The same eight elements apply across administration, corporate governance, policing, research, health and environmental disputes, but legal authority, technical standards, affected stakeholders and competent institutions must be adapted to the domain.
- **Time pressure changes depth, not sequence:** Under examination pressure, candidates should compress each architectural element rather than omit it: one-line facts and dilemma, a compact stakeholder-constraint map, three options, decisive checks, action steps and a residual-risk close.
- **Decision writing should identify the decisive reason:** A recommendation should name the selected option, the threshold or weighted consideration that controls the choice and the safeguard answering the strongest objection; merely saying balance all interests does not decide the case.
- **Implementation must assign actions and audiences:** Implementation should specify immediate and later actions, competent actors, documentation and communication to seniors, team members and affected people; a morally attractive choice without an execution route remains administratively incomplete.
- **Communication should be honest and calibrated:** Crisis communication should disclose verified information, acknowledge uncertainty, prevent avoidable panic and commit to updates; neither premature certainty nor prolonged concealment protects trust when facts are still developing.
- **A complete answer ends with qualified confidence:** The final verdict should be decisive but not absolute: it should connect lawful action, public purpose, proportionate safeguards and review, showing confidence in the chosen route while accepting that implementation requires continuing ethical oversight.

SOURCE AND ATTRIBUTION DISCIPLINE

Topic 22 owns the complete method for GS-IV case studies: facts, stakeholders, constraints, realistic options, ethical evaluation, decision, implementation and communication, and residual-risk mitigation. The six-check framework is a synthesis heuristic, not an official UPSC algorithm or a promise of one uniquely correct answer. Legality is normally a hard threshold; conflict of interest is near-disqualifying and ordinarily triggers written disclosure, recusal, referral to an untainted authority and objective criteria. Public interest, proportionality, transparency and compassion are weighted considerations whose relative importance must be explained. Moral theories supplement rather than replace the six checks. Nested dilemmas should be separated only when analytically genuine. A steelman is the strongest credible objection, not a ceremonial weak counterpoint. Residual risk means the specific danger remaining after controls, with a named monitor and review mechanism; its formula is a reasoning aid, not literal arithmetic. Improper oral directions should be converted into a written record with the officer's professional objection and lawful escalation. Ethical dissent usually moves through internal, independent internal, authorised external and last-resort public channels; a compromised recipient may be skipped. Public disclosure can carry confidentiality, safety and legal risks. Resignation

is an evaluated last resort after resistance and escalation, not an automatic symbol of integrity. Triage requires relevant published criteria, an explicit welfare-equity trade-off, records, review and adaptation. The architecture transfers across domains, but each answer must identify the governing legal authority, technical standard and competent institution; Topic 22 does not replace the detailed law in Topics 14-21 or named-case evidence in Topic 23. Official local UPSC papers control question wording. PYQ entries marked neutral routing deliberately condense scenarios because some scans have imperfect OCR; they must not be presented as verbatim quotations. The canonical Basic treatment controls the 2018-2025 routing and worked method, while the Advanced treatment adds weighting, stress testing and residual-risk refinement. The Capacity Building Commission pages support a current case-based-learning anchor but do not make this exact answer framework an official Mission Karmayogi requirement.

ANSWER SPINE

1. Define the precise ethical concept or teaching.
2. State a qualified thesis rather than a moral slogan.
3. Explain the causal or decision-making mechanism.
4. Add one specific Indian administrative illustration.
5. Test the strongest limitation or attribution caveat.
6. End with a practical, institution-aware verdict.

CASE-STUDY METHOD AND ANSWER ARCHITECTURE RAPID REGISTER

1. THE EIGHT-ELEMENT NON-NEGOTIABLE SPINE

1. **Facts:** one-line dilemma; separate given facts from assumptions and unknowns.
2. **Stakeholders:** direct, indirect and silent parties, including future generations and institutional trust.
3. **Constraints:** legality, delegation, jurisdiction, time, information, resources, capacity and safety.
4. **Options:** at least three realistic courses; include a hybrid or sequenced course where useful; give a concrete pro and con.
5. **Ethical evaluation:** moral theories plus six checks; eliminate threshold failures before balancing.
6. **Decision:** select one course, name the decisive reason and answer the strongest objection.
7. **Implementation and communication:** immediate and later steps, actors, records and audiences.
8. **Residual risk:** name surviving danger, monitor, accountable authority and review trigger.

2. HARD CONSTRAINTS BEFORE OPTIONS

- An option outside lawful authority or jurisdiction is not a real option.
- A hard time limit does not legalise evasion; it may justify a lawful emergency or phased route.
- Information gaps should produce verification steps, not invented certainty.
- Resource and capacity limits must be costed explicitly.
- State what the protagonist can decide, what must be delegated and what must be referred.
- Best sequence: constraint gate -> surviving options -> ethical comparison.

3. SIX CHECKS AND THEIR WEIGHT

- **Conflict of interest:** near-hard threshold; personal confidence does not cure structural bias.
- **Legality:** normally a hard threshold; benefit cannot purchase lawful authority.
- **Public interest:** broader and less vocal stakeholders count.
- **Proportionality:** avoid both under-reaction and over-reaction.
- **Transparency:** could reasons be recorded and defended under scrutiny?
- **Compassion and long-term consequence:** dignity now plus foreseeable effects later.
- Apply deontology, consequentialism and virtue ethics to surviving options.
- State which weighted check is decisive and how the others are protected.

4. DISCLOSE -> RECUSE -> REFER -> PUBLISH

- Detect the personal, family, financial or reputational connection.

- Disclose it in writing before the decision.
- Recuse from deciding, chairing and influencing that specific matter.
- Refer to a genuinely untainted superior, colleague or committee.
- Apply pre-announced, objective criteria and preserve the evaluation trail.
- Publish or consistently communicate the defensible rationale where rules permit.
- Anchor cases: 2024 Sneha and 2025 Subash.

5. NESTED DILEMMAS AND STEELMANNING

- Decompose only genuinely independent tensions.
- Give each sub-dilemma a mini threshold and weighted-check pass.
- Recombine the resulting decisions into one operational course.
- State the strongest informed objection to the chosen course.
- Defeat it with reasons or redesign implementation to absorb its valid concern.
- One strong objection is enough; repeated counterpoints create indecision.
- Vijay example: grief versus duty; allocation fairness; transparency versus calm.

6. RESIDUAL-RISK FORMULA

- Working expression: **residual risk = inherent risk - effective controls + uncertainty/control failure exposure.**
- The expression is qualitative, not a claim that ethics is arithmetic.
- Name the surviving risk specifically: retaliation, misclassification, capture, execution error or public distrust.
- Choose an indicator, review mechanism and trigger.
- Name the office or person responsible; avoid passive claims that it will be monitored.
- Close with qualified confidence, never with a claim that all risk has vanished.

7. WRITTEN-ORDER RESPONSE TO ORAL PRESSURE

- Record the substance and date of the oral instruction.
- Seek written confirmation from the person giving it.
- Place the legal, technical and ethical objection on record.
- Preserve the supporting evidence and continue lawful substantive duty.
- Refer through the normal hierarchy; use vigilance or oversight if the pressure itself is improper.
- Written reasons protect both accountability and the officer's bona fides.

8. WHISTLEBLOWING AND ETHICAL DISSENT

- Rung 1: competent internal reporting with evidence.
- Rung 2: independent internal authority such as vigilance, audit or ethics mechanism.
- Rung 3: authorised regulator, ombudsman or lawful external authority.
- Rung 4: public disclosure only as a genuine last resort against serious continuing harm.
- Skip a recipient who is implicated, but do not skip evidence, necessity and lawful purpose.
- Protect identity, custody, safety and access records.
- A complaint starts verification; it does not establish guilt.

9. RESIGNATION TEST

- Have written dissent and lawful escalation been exhausted or become impossible?
- Does staying preserve a principled internal safeguard?
- Would leaving reduce complicity or merely remove resistance?
- Would departure improve the public outcome rather than only personal moral comfort?
- Define the trigger: compelled personal execution, signature or legitimisation of unresolved wrongdoing.
- Rajesh Kumar 2020 is the classic option-evaluation anchor.

10. TRIAGE AND SCARCE RESOURCES

- Measure actual scarcity; protect lawful and dignity-based minima.
- Publish relevant criteria before individual allocation where time permits.
- State the trade-off: aggregate welfare, urgency, survivability, vulnerability or worst-off priority.
- Add an equity audit so metrics do not become mechanically discriminatory.
- Record who applied which criterion and why.
- Provide a rapid review or grievance route.
- Revise criteria as resources and emergency conditions change.
- Public and private institutions share the ethical floor even when operational powers differ.

11. DOMAIN ADAPTATION

- **Procurement:** delegation, conflict, objective criteria and audit trail.
- **Disaster:** command continuity, triage, communication and succession risk.
- **Corporate environment:** stakeholder duty, verified transition and rebound risk.
- **Research:** informed consent, vulnerable participants, complete data and ethics review.
- **Policing:** legality, proportionality, evidence and due process for all parties.
- **Privacy:** lawful purpose, necessity, minimisation and review.
- **Workplace harassment:** safe complaint route, unbiased inquiry and anti-retaliation.
- **Border or refugee cases:** separate humanitarian need from verified security risk; avoid blanket extremes.

12. 2018-2025 PYQ ROUTES

- **2018:** privileged policy information and ministerial conflict -> refuse benefit, record, recuse where required, objective route.
- **2019:** attacked rescue team -> mission continuity plus proportionate team safety and community liaison.
- **2020:** welfare re-appropriation -> written dissent, oversight escalation, resignation last.
- **2021:** hospital staff scarcity -> published triage criteria, equity safeguard and review cycle.
- **2022:** mining-mafia journalist -> preserve evidence, skip captured rung, lawful external escalation.
- **2023:** SRTC political pressure -> neutrality, written clarification, independent vigilance route.
- **2024:** AI emissions, Sneha conflict and trial integrity -> domain-specific use of the same architecture.
- **2025:** Vijay, Subash and Rajesh -> nested duties, conflict controls and lawful urgent procurement.

13. TIME MANAGEMENT FOR A TWENTY-MARK CASE

- Minute 1: read the directive and frame the dilemma.
- Minute 2: facts, stakeholders and constraints in compact bullets.
- Minutes 3-6: generate three or four real options with short pros and cons.
- Minutes 7-10: thresholds, moral theories and weighted checks.
- Minutes 11-12: decision and decisive reason.
- Minutes 13-14: implementation, communication and steelman response.
- Minute 15: residual risk, monitor and review trigger.
- Compress every element; never spend the answer retelling the narrative.

14. EXAMINER TRAPS

- One asserted correct option without alternatives.
- Vague balancing without a decision.
- Treating compassion as permission for illegality.
- Treating all six checks as equally weighted.
- Confusing disclosure with completed recusal.
- Jumping directly to media exposure or resignation.

- Giving a remedy outside the protagonist's authority.
- Omitting implementation, communication or residual risk.
- Using a public-sector remedy unchanged in a clinical, corporate or research setting.
- Claiming the chosen option removes all risk.

15. EIGHT-LINE ANSWER RECALL

1. What is verified and what is the dilemma?
2. Who is affected, including silent stakeholders?
3. What cannot legally or practically be done?
4. What three or four real courses remain?
5. Which fail thresholds, and how do the survivors compare?
6. What will I choose, and why does the strongest objection not defeat it?
7. Who will do what, record what and communicate what?
8. What can still go wrong, who monitors it and when is review triggered?

Final thesis: A high-scoring GS-IV case answer is a bounded administrative decision, not an emotional essay. Verify facts, map visible and silent stakeholders, state hard constraints, compare realistic options, eliminate illegality and conflict, weigh public interest with proportionality, transparency and compassion, decide clearly, implement through named actors and communication, and close by owning the residual risk.